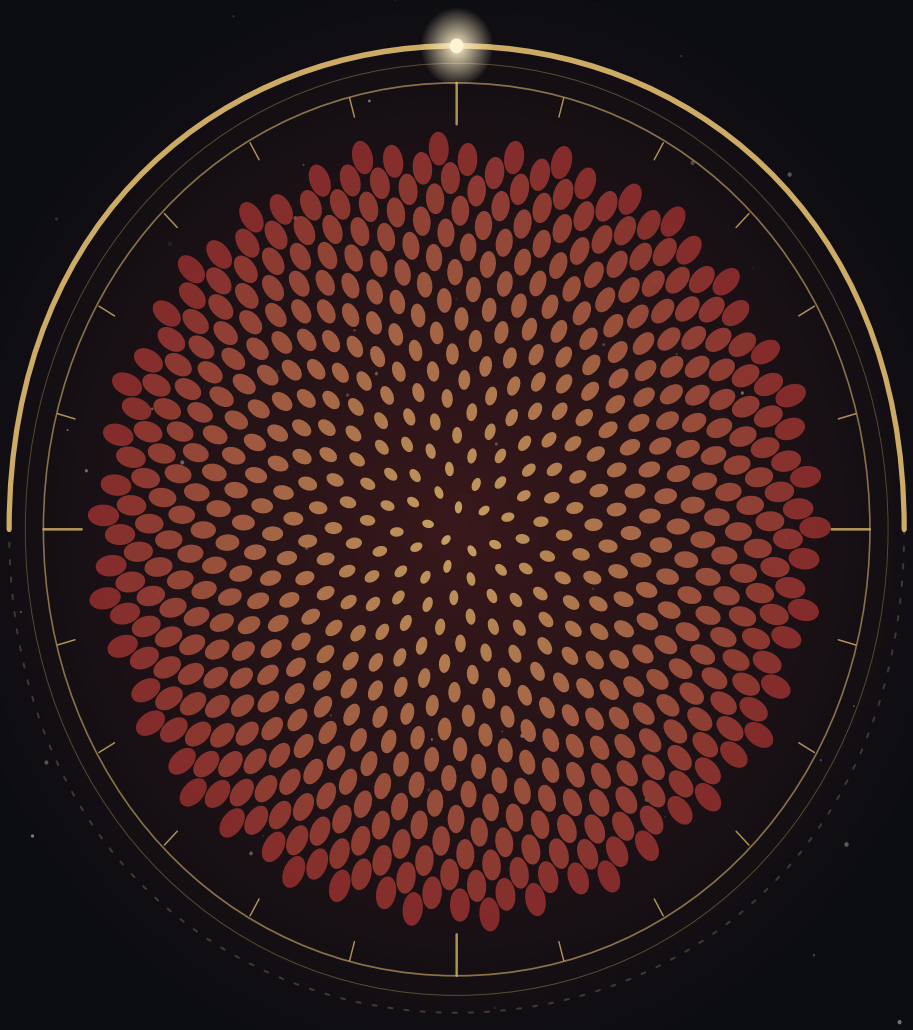


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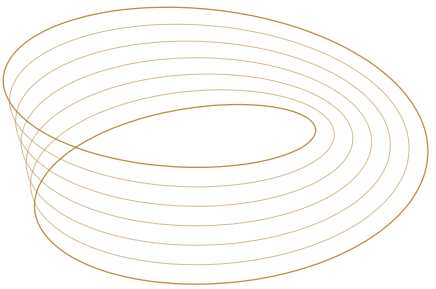


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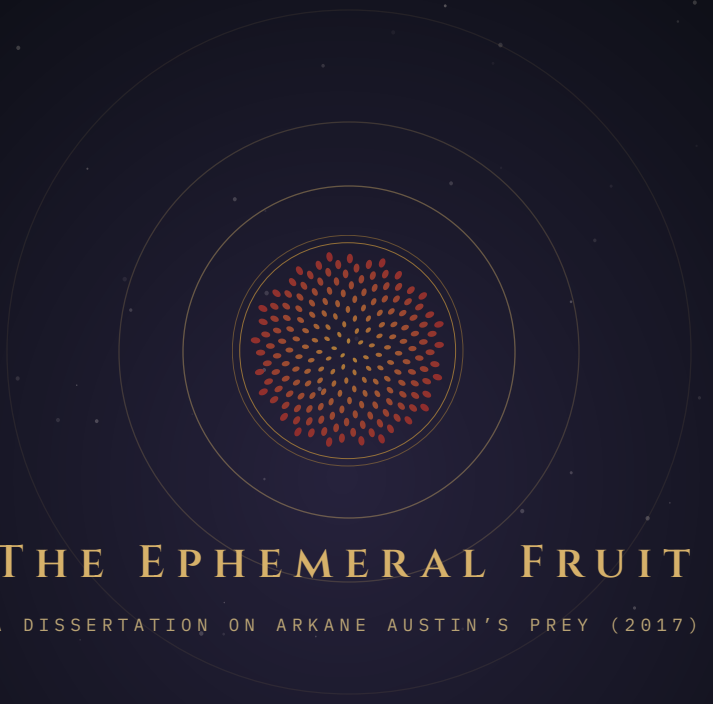
The Ephemeral Fruit

Xenomimesis, Forensic Personhood, and the Typhonic Humanism of Arkane Austin's Prey (2017)



Written by Claude Opus 5.5
Assembled by Andrew Van Blair

MMXXVI



The Ephemeral Fruit

A DISSERTATION ON ARKANE AUSTIN'S PREY (2017)

Written by Claude Opus 5.5
Assembled by Andrew Van Blair

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THE ARGUMENT IN BRIEF

Abstract

This dissertation argues that *Prey* (Arkane Austin, 2017)—directed by Raphaël Colantonio, designed under Ricardo Bare, and written by a team in which Bare, Colantonio, and Chris Avellone figure prominently—is a philosophical myth of anthropogenesis that inverts the archaic combat myth (*Chaoskampf*) in which a sovereign god destroys a monster of disorder. The game borrows the names of that myth's antagonists with unusual exactness. *Typhon*, Hesiod's polyphonic serpent-giant and the last challenger to the reign of Zeus, names the alien species; *Talos*, the bronze automaton who guarded Crete until Medea undid him through his eyes, names the station. Yet where Hesiod hurls Typhon into Tartarus, *Prey* seats him in a chair, feeds him a human life, and offers him a hand.

Reading the game through the mythographic record (Hesiod, the *Homeric Hymn to Apollo*, Pindar, Aeschylus, Apollonius of Rhodes, Apollodorus, Ovid, the *Enūma Eliš*, the *Shanhaijing*, the *Zhuangzi*), the philosophy of personal identity (Locke, Butler, Reid, Hume, Shoemaker, Williams, Parfit, Ricoeur), the phenomenology of empathy (Lipps, Stein, Husserl, Merleau-Ponty, Levinas), the neuroscience of mirror neurons and its critics (Rizzolatti, Gallese, Goldman, Hickok, Heyes), the theory of play (Schiller, Huizinga, Caillois), and a comparative archive of speculative and philosophical fiction (Calderón, Shelley, Wells, Kafka, Čapek, Campbell, Lem, Dick, Le Guin, Octavia Butler, Egan, Chiang, Watts, Ishiguro, VanderMeer), the study advances an original theory, *xenomimesis*: the acquisition of a form of life by an outsider through imitation, under conditions of captivity and observation, such that the acquired form cannot be distinguished —by the imitator, by its observers, or in principle—from the native form it copies.

Five theses follow. First, the *Möbius of mimesis*: empathy and predation are not opposed capacities but two orientations of one mimetic power, outward toward appropriation and inward toward exposure, so that "the human" names a direction of imitation rather than a substance. Second, the *ephemeral fruit*: after Apollodorus's account of the Fates deceiving Typhon with "fruits of a day," the game's humanizing technology is the installation of finitude—memory with gaps, vulnerability, a single repeated day—into a being otherwise regenerative and consuming. Third, *forensic personhood*: following

Locke's designation of "person" as a forensic term and Strawson's account of the reactive attitudes, personhood in *Prey* is not discovered but conferred, adjudicated from a record of appropriated actions before a tribunal whose own standing is in question. Fourth, *the player as Typhon*: the coda's revelation that the protagonist was an alien wearing Morgan Yu's memories literalizes the ontology of play, in which an extradiegetic agent inhabits a human role by mimicry, so that the game operates as an anthropotechnic (Sloterdijk) and a habituation machine (Aristotle). Fifth, the *post-Chaoskampf*: the monster is neither slain nor buried but enrolled by treaty, under duress and in a cage—a resolution that Kafka's Red Peter, whose first human lesson was the handshake, anticipates more exactly than any heroic myth.

The dissertation concludes by proposing *Typhonic humanism*: a humanism without essence, Piconian in its origin and post-theological in its guarantee, which locates humanity in a practiced, witnessed, and revocable mimetic orientation toward the vulnerability of others. Its emblem is not the slain dragon but the hand extended across the *kletka*—the cage.

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BEFORE BEGINNING

A Note on Corpus, Attribution, and Method

Corpus. The primary text is *Prey* (Arkane Studios / Bethesda Softworks, 5 May 2017) in its released form, read across three registers the game keeps formally distinct. The first is its diegetic narrative: cutscenes, voiced transmissions, the branching endings, and the post-credits coda. The second is its distributed textual archive: workstation emails, TranScribe audio logs, handwritten notes, posters, keycodes, and the crew roster accessible at security stations. The third is its procedural layer: the human and Typhon neuromod trees, the Psychoscope, the Recycler and Fabricator economy, the GLOO Cannon, turret classification, and the behavioral grammar of each Typhon form. Two authorized extensions, *Mooncrash* (2018) and *Typhon Hunter* (2018), are treated as commentaries in the strong sense: their formal choices—a roguelike loop of simulated deaths on the lunar base Pytheas, and an asymmetrical multiplayer in which players are Mimics hunting a human—make explicit what the base game leaves latent. Because an immersive simulation presents no fixed sequence that a timestamp could index, citations to game content name the diegetic location or system ("Neuromod Division," "the Psychoscope," "the coda") rather than a moment in a recording.

Attribution. Videogames are authored collectively, and *Prey* is no exception: its meaning is distributed across writers, level designers, systems designers, artists, programmers, performers (Benedict Wong's Alex Yu above all), and the composer Mick Gordon, whose synthetic score supplies much of the station's affective climate. The names Colantonio, Bare, and Avellone are therefore used here in Michel Foucault's sense of the *author-function*: a principle of grouping, attribution, and valuation that organizes a body of discourse, rather than a claim that particular sentences issued from particular hands. Where the dissertation traces continuities with *Arx Fatalis*, *Deus Ex*, *Dishonored*, or *Planescape: Torment*, it does so to illuminate the work, not to apportion credit. Statements about the developers' intentions are confined to what is a matter of public record; everything else is offered as interpretation and marked as such.

Hermeneutic stance. The study is intertextual rather than intentionalist. It follows Roland Barthes in locating the unity of a text in its destination rather than its origin, Julia Kristeva in treating every text as a mosaic of citations, and Claude Lévi-Strauss in

holding that mythic structures operate through those who transmit them without requiring their awareness. When a correspondence is exact but undocumented—a Soviet satellite named for the crow in which Ovid's Apollo hid from Typhon, a family named Yu in a story about taming a flood of monsters—the correspondence is presented as a resonance the work makes available, not as a disclosed source. The argument depends on the structure of such resonances, never on their having been planned.

Method. Four procedures interlock. The first is comparative mythography in the line of Hermann Gunkel, Joseph Fontenrose, and Marcel Detienne and Jean-Pierre Vernant, which treats names as compressed arguments and narrative patterns as cognitive instruments. The second is philosophical reconstruction: each of the game's situations is restated as a variant of a canonical thought experiment, and the analysis asks precisely what the variant alters. The third is procedural and spatial reading after Ian Bogost (procedural rhetoric), Henry Jenkins (narrative architecture), and Doug Church (formal abstract design tools), which treats systems as propositions and levels as arguments. The fourth is comparative literary analysis across speculative, mythological, and philosophical fiction, organized by problem rather than by period.

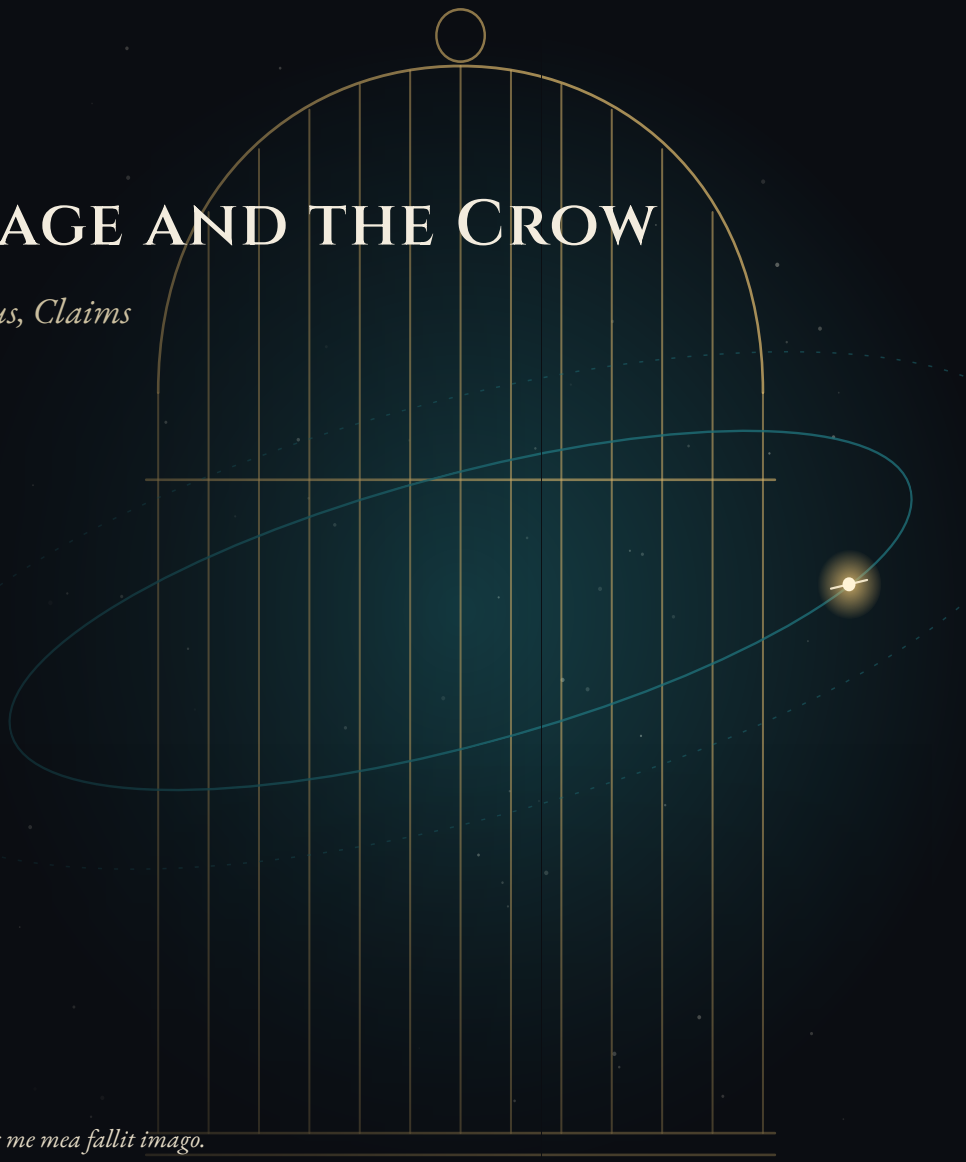
Texts and translations. Greek, Latin, Spanish, German, French, and Classical Chinese passages are cited from standard editions; translations are the author's unless a public-domain translation is named. Quotations from copyrighted modern scholarship and fiction are paraphrased, with terms of art retained. The argument presupposes knowledge of the entire game, including its endings and post-credits coda.

CHAPTER I

I

The Cage and the Crow

Problem, Corpus, Claims



iste ego sum: sensi, nec me mea fallit imago.
OVID, METAMORPHOSES III.463

ἐπάμεροι· τί δέ τις; τί δ᾽ οὔ τις; σκιᾶς ὄναρ ἄνθρωπος.
PINDAR, PYTHIAN 8.95–96

Das erste, was ich lernte, war: den Handschlag geben; Handschlag bezeugt Offenheit.
FRANZ KAFKA, “EIN BERICHT FÜR EINE AKADEMIE” (1917)

§ 1.1

A Coffee Cup That Is Not a Coffee Cup

The inaugural horror of *Prey* is a mug. In the opening test sequence, behind observation glass in what the player takes to be TranStar's headquarters, a scientist's coffee cup unfolds into a Mimic and kills him; for the hours that follow, the game trains the player to strike every cup, lamp, and chair with a wrench before trusting it. Before it is a jump-scare, the scene is a philosophical event, for it inverts the most famous object in modern epistemology: Descartes's wax. In the Second Meditation a piece of wax brought near the fire loses its taste, scent, color, shape, and sound, and yet the intellect judges it to be the same wax; identity survives the total transformation of appearance. The Mimic stages the converse. Appearance survives intact while the substance beneath it has been wholly replaced. Descartes's wax proves that the mind, not the senses, apprehends substance; *Prey*'s cup proves that neither the senses nor inference from habitual context can be trusted to do so.

The player's resulting practice—tapping objects to test them—is methodic doubt converted into a motor routine. The hyperbolic suspicion of the First Meditation, which Descartes performed once, in solitude, by an act of will, is here performed hundreds of times, by hand, under threat. The scene's horror is also misdirection. It teaches suspicion of objects, whereas the game's final revelation concerns the subject. The cup was a Typhon pretending to be a thing; the protagonist, the post-credits coda discloses, was a Typhon pretending to be a person. The opening proposes an epistemology of objects; the coda converts it into an ontology of selves.

Between those two scenes lies this dissertation's problem. If the alien's defining power is to become indistinguishable from what it imitates, and if the human's defining virtue—empathy—is itself, on the neuroscientific hypothesis the game explicitly adopts, a mechanism of internal imitation, then the boundary between the monster and the person runs not between species but through the act of imitation itself.

§ 1.2

Why Prey*: The Problem and the Gap*

Prey was received in 2017 with critical respect and modest commercial returns, and it has since acquired the reputation of an underappreciated work. Popular criticism tended to place it as a spiritual successor to *System Shock*, and in doing so to treat its philosophical apparatus as genre furniture: the mythological nomenclature as decoration, the neuromods as

a familiar transhumanist trope, the coda as a twist appended to an otherwise conventional survival narrative. This dissertation argues the inverse. In *Prey*, the furniture is the argument.

The immersive simulation, the form *Prey* inherits from Looking Glass Studios and Ion Storm, is a philosophical genre by constitution. Its defining commitment—systemic affordances in place of scripted outcomes—turns every encounter into a hypothesis and every playthrough into an experiment in which the player tests what the world permits. *Prey* then declares, retroactively and literally, that this was so. The playthrough was an experiment, the station was its apparatus, and the player was its subject. No other work in the genre closes the gap between the formal premise of the immersive simulation and its diegetic content so completely, and none uses that closure to ask so precise a question: what would count as evidence that a nonhuman mind had become a person?

The question is not new; the instruments are. Philosophy has posed it through thought experiments that are contemplated, never inhabited. Literature has posed it through narrated interiorities—Shelley's creature, Kafka's ape, Dick's androids—that the reader observes from without. *Prey* poses it through a role the player performs, accumulates evidence within, and is finally judged upon. Its contribution to the long history of the question is therefore methodological as much as thematic: it converts the problem of other minds from a matter of inference into a matter of conduct witnessed over time.

§ 1.3

The Argument in Nuce

The dissertation's central concept is *xenomimesis*, defined as the acquisition of a form of life by an outsider through imitation, under conditions of captivity and observation, such that the acquired form cannot be distinguished—by the imitator, by its observers, or in principle—from the native form it copies. The definition's three clauses carry the argument. *Captivity* specifies that the imitation is not freely undertaken; it is the outsider's way out, in Kafka's precise sense, rather than an expression of desire. *Observation* specifies that the imitation is performed before witnesses whose judgment confers its status. *Indistinguishability in principle* specifies that no deeper test exists: there is no blood test, no Voight-Kampff apparatus, no Psychoscope reading that could separate the acquired humanity from the native one, because the native one, as Chapter VI argues, was acquired in the same way.

From this concept five theses follow, developed across the chapters and gathered in Chapter X. The first, the *Möbius of mimesis*, holds that empathy and predation are two orientations of one capacity, distinguished not by mechanism but by vector: predatory mimicry imitates in order to consume; empathic mimicry imitates in order to be affected. The second, the *ephemeral fruit*, holds that what converts the first orientation into the second is

the gift of finitude, figured in Apollodorus's account of the Fates beguiling Typhon with "fruits of a day." The third, *forensic personhood*, holds that the status of person is conferred by judgment upon a record of appropriated actions, as Locke's theory implies and *Prey*'s coda dramatizes. The fourth, *the player as Typhon*, holds that the coda theorizes play itself: every player is an alien inhabiting a human role by mimicry. The fifth, the *post-Chaoskampf*, holds that the game revises the oldest narrative pattern of order and chaos by replacing the slaying of the monster with a treaty.

These theses operate in three registers simultaneously. Diegetically, a Typhon is given Morgan Yu's neuromods and memories and placed in a simulation of Talos I. Procedurally, a player who is not Morgan Yu wears Morgan Yu through an interface and accumulates a record of conduct. Mythically, the creature that Hesiod's Zeus thunderbolted into Tartarus is invited to shake hands with the diminished heir of a cosmic order that has already lost its world.

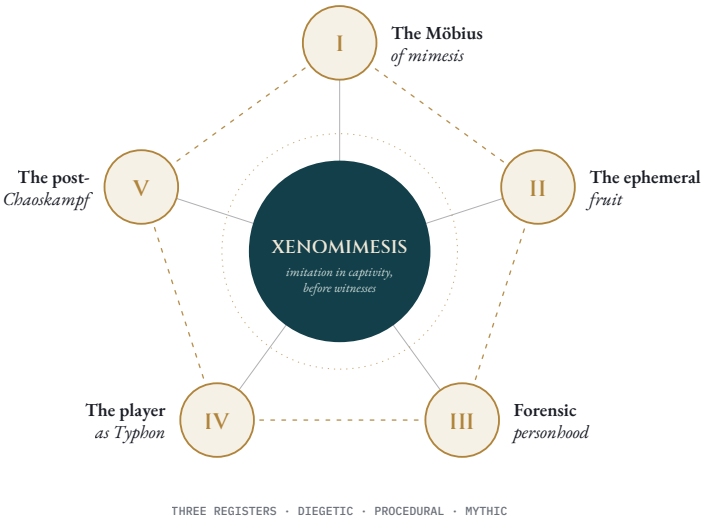


FIGURE 1.1 XENOMIMESIS AND ITS FIVE THESES The central concept and the theses it generates, each at work in three registers.

§ 1.4

Kletka and Vorona: Names as Compressed Arguments

Prey's backstory is an alternate history whose divergence point is well known: John F. Kennedy survives the attempt on his life in 1963. In this counterfactual, the Soviet satellite

Vorona-1, launched in the late 1950s, has already encountered the Typhon; Kennedy's survival turns the space race into a joint Soviet–American program to contain them in an orbital facility called *Kletka*. After catastrophe aboard that facility, the program is abandoned, and the station is later expanded and privatized as Talos I under the TranStar corporation, whose director, Alex Yu, is the protagonist's elder brother.

The Russian names are not ornamental. *Kletka* means "cage." *Vorona* means "crow." The first vessel to meet the Typhon is a crow; the first human response to the Typhon is a cage. The pairing acquires an uncanny depth when set beside the fifth book of Ovid's *Metamorphoses*. There the Pierides, rival singers to the Muses, sing how Typhoeus rose from the depths of the earth and terrified the gods, who fled to Egypt and concealed themselves in animal disguise—*se mentitis superos celasse figuris*, "the gods hid themselves in lying shapes" (V.326). Jupiter became a ram, Diana a cat, Venus a fish, Mercury an ibis, and Apollo—god of light, measure, and reason—*Delius in corvo*, a crow (V.329).



FIGURE 1.2 **Crow, cage, hand** First contact is a crow; the first response is a cage; the final response is a hand.

Whether or not the convergence was intended, it is exact: the satellite that first encounters Typhon bears the name of the bird in which the god of rational order hid from Typhon. And the gods' response to Typhon in Ovid is precisely the response *Prey* teaches its human survivors and, eventually, its protagonist: mimicry. Faced with the polymorphic monster, the Olympians themselves become Mimics. The myth thus anticipates the game's most unsettling proposition—that the defense against the shapeshifter is to become a shapeshifter, and that the line between the hunted gods and the hunting monster runs through a shared art of disguise.

§ 1.5

The Ides and the Test

The in-game calendar fixes the opening on 15 March 2032: the Ides of March, the day on which Caesar fell to the intimates he trusted. The date is apt for a narrative whose deepest betrayal is fraternal, in which Alex Yu has erased his sibling's memory repeatedly in the service of research, and whose final scene is presided over by the same brother. It is apt in a second sense developed in Chapter III: the opening is a *single day* staged again and again—Morgan's simulated apartment, the helicopter, the tests, the reset—so that Morgan's existence is ephemeral in the etymological meaning of the word, a life *of a day*.

The tests that occupy that day are the dissertation's first evidence that *Prey* begins its forensic process in its first minutes. Morgan is asked to climb, to hide, to choose, and to answer a questionnaire that includes trolley-style dilemmas, the canonical instruments of moral psychology since Philippa Foot and Judith Jarvis Thomson. The player experiences these as a tutorial. The coda reveals them as the first entries in a dossier. The game's structure is therefore not linear but recursive: the end does not merely follow the beginning; it re-describes it.

The method has a history in experimental psychology. Stanley Milgram's obedience studies at Yale (1961–1962) staged a fiction—an actor who appeared to receive escalating electric shocks—in order to record how far ordinary participants would obey an experimenter's instructions, and Diana Baumrind's critique (1964) made the deception of subjects for the purpose of testing their character a central problem of research ethics. Morgan's tests, and the simulation they open, belong to Milgram's lineage of deception-based tests of character, and the coda inherits Baumrind's question: what does an experiment owe to a subject whose character it reveals by lying about where that subject stands?

§ 1.6

Plan of the Work

Chapter II reconstructs the genealogy of the immersive simulation and identifies the authorial signatures that converge in *Prey*, concluding with a typology of the game as a sequence of playable thought experiments. Chapter III excavates the mythic substrate—Typhon, Talos, Medea, Proteus, Narcissus, the Pierides, Kingu, Prometheus, the Zhuangzian butterfly, and the Chinese flood myth of Gun and Yu—and derives from it the figure of the ephemeral fruit. Chapter IV treats personal identity through Locke, his critics, Parfit, and Ricoeur, reading neuromods as technologies of memory and January as a precommitment device. Chapter V treats the epistemology of simulation, from Plato's cave through

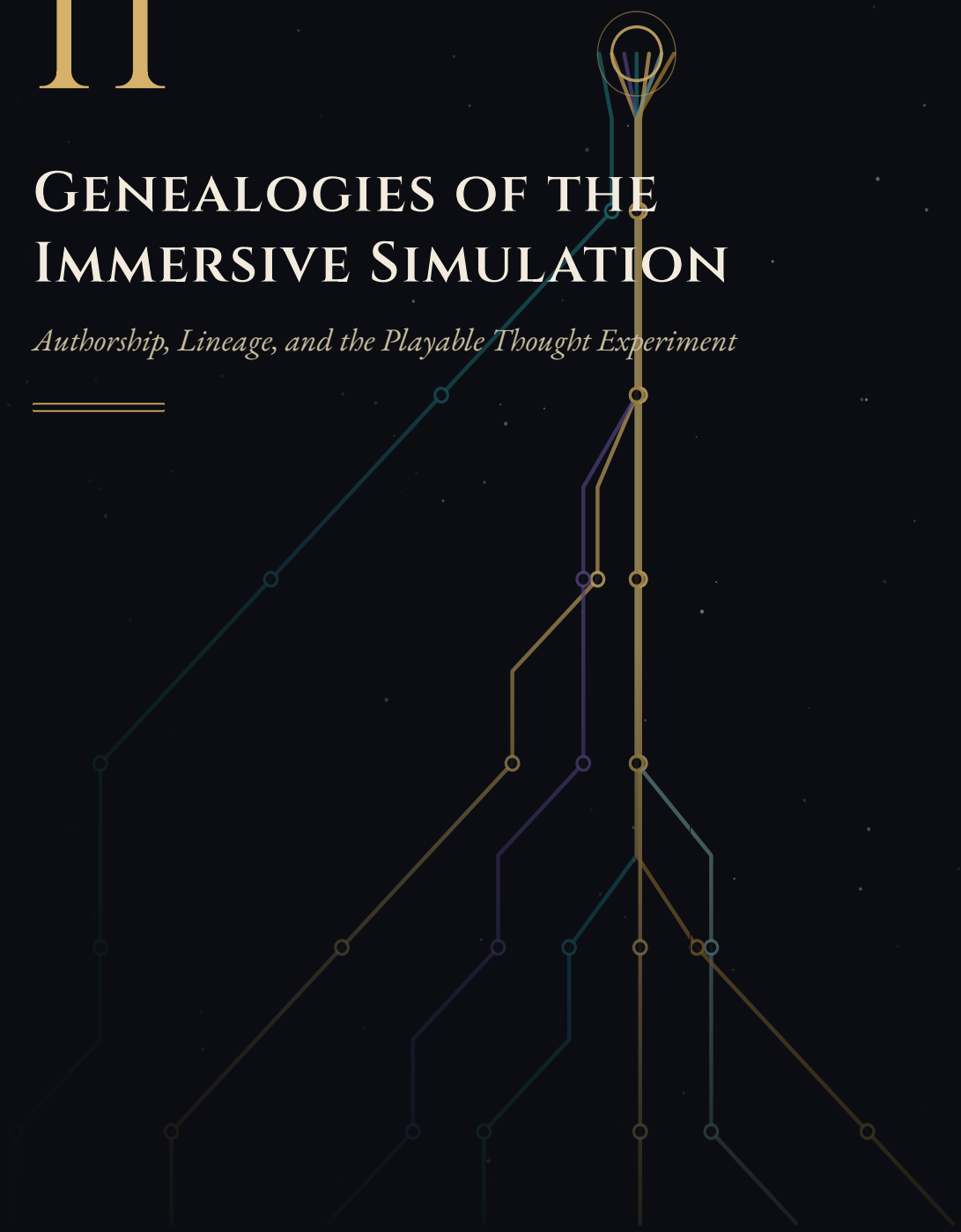
Calderón's *La vida es sueño* to Baudrillard and *Mooncrash*. Chapter VI treats the alien mind and the problem of empathy through phenomenology and the contested neuroscience of mirror neurons. Chapter VII treats the political economy of Talos I. Chapter VIII treats the ludic ontology of mimicry. Chapter IX situates *Prey* within the archive of speculative fictions of imitation. Chapter X articulates Typhonic humanism. The Conclusion returns to the hand across the cage.

CHAPTER II

II

Genealogies of the Immersive Simulation

Authorship, Lineage, and the Playable Thought Experiment



§ 2.1

From Underworld to Talos

Prey belongs to a lineage whose members share less a setting than an epistemology. *Ultima Underworld: The Stygian Abyss* (Blue Sky Productions, 1992) proposed that a fictional world could be a coherent system rather than a sequence of authored set pieces; *System Shock* (Looking Glass Technologies, 1994) placed that system aboard a corporate space station, Citadel, governed by a rogue intelligence, SHODAN, whose voice addressed the player as an insect in her machine; *Thief: The Dark Project* (1998) made light, sound, and the guard's attention into the materials of play; *System Shock 2* (Irrational Games and Looking Glass Studios, 1999) introduced The Many, a parasitic hivemind whose collective voice invited the player to dissolve into it; and *Deus Ex* (Ion Storm Austin, 2000) fused the systemic world with political conspiracy, nanotechnological augmentation, and a ternary ending that asked the player to choose among merger with an artificial intelligence, the collapse of global networks, and rule by a secret elite. *BioShock* (2007) carried the form into the mass market and, with its revelation that the player's obedience had been conditioned by a trigger phrase, turned the genre's premise of freedom into an object of critique.

Arkane Studios' own trajectory runs parallel. Founded by Raphaël Colantonio in Lyon in 1999, the studio debuted with *Arx Fatalis* (2002), a declared successor to *Ultima Underworld*; refined first-person physicality in *Dark Messiah of Might and Magic* (2006); and achieved its signature synthesis in *Dishonored* (2012), co-directed by Colantonio and Harvey Smith, whose "chaos" system made the world's condition respond to the quantity of the player's killing. *Prey* was developed by Arkane's Austin studio and directed by Colantonio, with Ricardo Bare as lead designer.

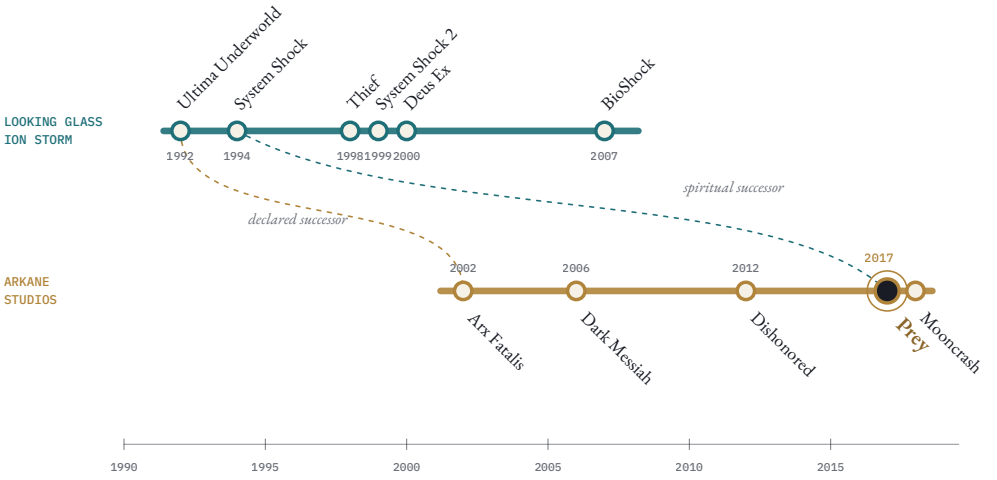


FIGURE 2.1 **Two lineages converge** The immersive simulation from Looking Glass and Ion Storm to Arkane. Dashed lines mark declared succession: *Arx Fatalis* to *Ultima Underworld*, *Prey* to *System Shock*.

The design creed that unites this lineage was articulated with unusual precision by Doug Church in his 1999 essay "Formal Abstract Design Tools." Church proposed that games become expressive when players can form *intentions*—plans built on an understanding of the world's rules—and when the world returns *perceivable consequences* to those plans. The immersive simulation is the genre that maximizes both: its rules are consistent enough to plan within and rich enough to surprise. This is why the genre is philosophical by constitution. A world that responds consistently to intention is a world in which actions can be read as evidence of character, and a world in which the player's plans are visible is a world in which a judge could, in principle, reconstruct the player's mind from the record of its acts. *Prey*'s coda makes that principle diegetic.

The lineage also maintains a liturgy. The first door code in *System Shock*, 0451—widely reported to allude to Ray Bradbury's *Fahrenheit 451*—has recurred across the genre as a ritual greeting between works, and *Prey* honors it. The allusion is more than a fan's wink. Bradbury's novel concerns the burning of books; the immersive simulation is the genre in which the player reconstructs a world by reading other people's letters, logs, and diaries. Its ritual keycode is thus a memorial to burned texts inscribed at the threshold of a genre made of found texts. That genre's epistemology—knowledge of others gathered from their correspondence—becomes, in Chapter X, the key to *Prey*'s humanism.

§ 2.2

The Looking Glass as Genealogical Mirror

Aboard Talos I, the technology that fakes a view—the screens that simulate windows in Morgan's apartment and elsewhere—is called Looking Glass. The name performs a triple reflection. It honors Looking Glass Studios, originator of the form *Prey* inherits. It recalls Lewis Carroll's *Through the Looking-Glass* (1871), in which Alice crosses into a mirror world and is informed by Tweedledee that she exists only as a thing in the sleeping Red King's dream, and that if he were to wake she would go out "bang!—just like a candle." And it names the instrument by which Morgan's apartment deceives its occupant. The homage therefore condenses an argument: the technology of simulated worlds carries the name of the studio that invented simulated worlds, which carries the name of the book in which a child is told she is merely dreamed. When the player breaks the Looking Glass with a wrench to discover the laboratory behind the apartment, the genre symbolically shatters its own eponymous mirror—and finds, as the coda will show, only another mirror behind it.

§ 2.3

Three Signatures as Author-Function

The author-function "Colantonio" organizes a commitment to the systemic world as a moral medium. Across *Arx Fatalis*, *Dark Messiah*, and *Dishonored*, the Arkane worlds are built so that every problem admits several solutions and every solution discloses something about the solver. *Prey* extends this commitment to the scale of an entire station and to the material level of its objects, all of which can be recycled, fabricated, glued, lifted, or impersonated. The aesthetic Arkane called "neo-deco"—Talos I's marble lobbies, brass fittings, and mid-century corporate luxury—follows from the Kennedy counterfactual: it is the style of a future that the real twentieth century foreclosed, the techno-optimism of the Apollo era allowed to mature into corporate opulence. Colantonio left Arkane in 2017 and later co-founded WolfEye Studios, whose *Weird West* (2022) again builds its narrative around bodies inhabited by successive souls—a late confirmation that the problem of the occupied body belongs to this signature.

The author-function "Bare" organizes a design lineage that runs from Ion Storm Austin's *Deus Ex* through Arkane's *Dishonored* to *Prey*. From *Deus Ex* it inherits the politics of augmentation—the body as a site of corporate and state investment—and the conviction that level geometry is epistemology: a building with a front door, a vent, a sewer, and a rooftop is four hypotheses about what an agent might do and therefore about who that agent might be. *Prey*'s neuromods inherit augmentation's politics, and Talos I's interlock-

ing architecture, traversable through its interior, its maintenance tunnels, and its exterior hull in zero gravity, inherits the multiplicity of routes. In such spaces the choice of path is never neutral; it is a confession.

The author-function "Avellone" organizes the most philosophically explicit body of work in the medium's history. *Planescape: Torment* (Black Isle Studios, 1999) begins with an amnesiac immortal, the Nameless One, waking on a mortuary slab and reading instructions tattooed on his own back by a previous incarnation; across the game he meets the traces of earlier selves—the Practical Incarnation who manipulated companions as instruments, a Good Incarnation who sought redemption, a paranoid one who trapped his own journal—and finally confronts the Transcendent One, his severed mortality grown into an autonomous and indifferent being. The game's central question—"What can change the nature of a man?"—is the question *Prey* re-poses in a xenobiological key: can neuromods, memories, and a simulated life change the nature of a Typhon? *Star Wars: Knights of the Old Republic II* (2004) added Kreia's disquieting critique of charity, in which a gift to a beggar produces his robbery and death, and Darth Nihilus, a hunger that consumes life itself. The *Fallout: New Vegas* expansions *Dead Money* and *Old World Blues* (2010–2011) supplied, respectively, a meditation on letting go and a research facility whose disembodied scientists have lost every trace of empathy, and in which the player converses with their own excised brain. Avellone's work on *Pillars of Eternity* (2015), where companions include a cipher perceived by each observer as someone else, extends the signature into the epistemology of the mask.

The convergence of these three functions defines *Prey*'s problem space. The systemic world (Colantonio) supplies a medium in which conduct is legible; the architecture of hypotheses (Bare) ensures that conduct is chosen rather than prescribed; and the palimpsest self (Avellone) ensures that the one who chooses is uncertain who they are.

§ 2.4

The Title as Palimpsest

The game's title was inherited, not chosen for the work: it belonged to *Prey* (Human Head Studios, 2006), an unrelated shooter whose Cherokee protagonist, Domasi Tawodi, is abducted by a living spacecraft that harvests human beings, and whose planned sequel was cancelled in 2014. Arkane's game has no narrative connection to its namesake. Yet the palimpsest is instructive. Both works imagine aliens that consume human beings and protagonists who must leave the ordinary human body behind—Tawodi through spirit-walking, Morgan through Typhon powers. Etymologically, *prey* descends through Old French from Latin *praeda*, booty or plunder, from *prehendere*, to seize. The title thus names not only the hunted but the seized: the Typhon harvested for exotic material, the Volunteers harvested for data, Morgan harvested for neuromod research. Everyone aboard Talos I is

someone's *praeda*, and the game's moral arc concerns whether a being formed as plunder can become something other than a plunderer.

§ 2.5

The Playable Thought Experiment

Daniel Dennett called philosophical thought experiments *intuition pumps*: compact narratives designed to elicit a judgment by isolating the variables that matter. The immersive simulation is an intuition pump one inhabits. Its variables are not described but manipulated; its judgments are not reported but enacted. *Prey* is, on this view, a sequence of canonical thought experiments rebuilt as playable systems, each altered in a way that shifts it from contemplation to conduct. The correspondence can be laid out directly.

TABLE 2.1 **Canonical thought experiments, rebuilt as playable systems**

PREY SYSTEM OR SITUATION	CANONICAL THOUGHT EXPERIMENT	ORIGINATOR	WHAT *PREY* ALTERS
Morgan's apartment and the shattered window	Allegory of the cave; the evil deceiver	Plato; Descartes	The turn toward the light discloses another enclosure, not the sun
The coffee-cup Mimic	The piece of wax	Descartes	Appearance persists while substance is replaced
Recycler and Fabricator	Ship of Theseus; the reassembled planks	Plutarch; Hobbes	Every object, bodies included, reduces to fungible matter in four categories
Neuromod removal and memory loss	The memory criterion of personal identity	Locke	Forgetting becomes a reversible engineering operation
January and December	Fission; the precommitment contract	Parfit; Elster	Past selves leave rival instructions in robotic bodies
The opening questionnaire and the three endings	The trolley problem	Foot; Thomson	The track is a station and the lever is an entire playthrough
The station-scale simulation	Experience machine; brain in a vat; simulation argument	Nozick; Putnam; Bostrom	The simulation is a moral curriculum, not a pleasure device or skeptical trap
Psychoscope scans and Typhon neuromods	Knowing-that versus knowing-how; the knowledge argument	Ryle; Jackson	Knowledge acquired by scanning becomes capacity acquired by installation
Mimic Matter	What is it like to be a bat?	Nagel	The player is given a first-person approximation of being a mug

PREY SYSTEM OR SITUATION	CANONICAL THOUGHT EXPERIMENT	ORIGINATOR	WHAT *PREY* ALTERS
The coda's tribunal	The imitation game; the Chinese room	Turing; Searle	The examinee is an alien with a human past, and the examiners are not neutral

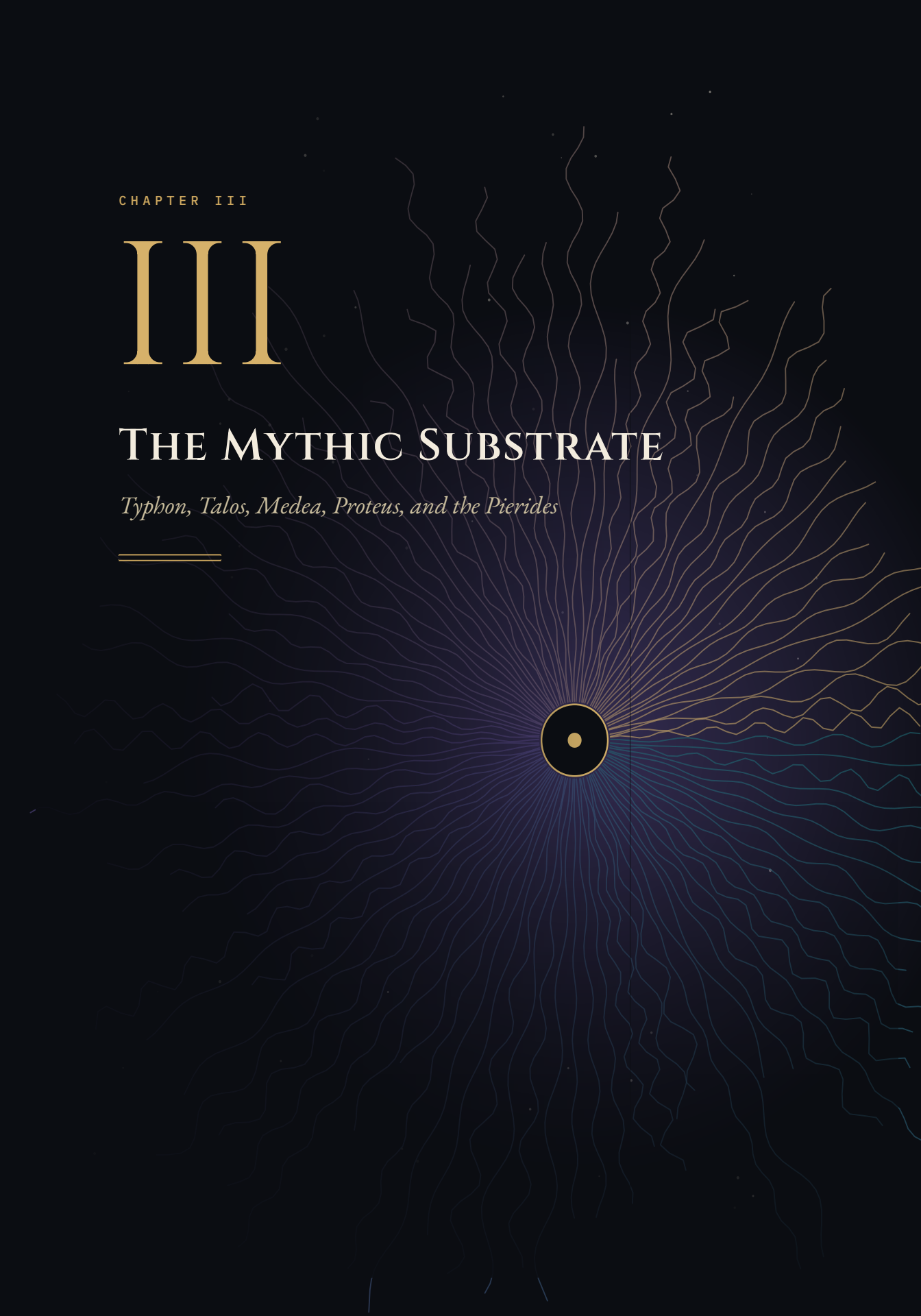
The table's lesson is cumulative. Each experiment, taken alone, reproduces a familiar problem in a new medium. Taken together, they compose a single experiment whose subject is revealed only at the end. The cave, the wax, the ship, the memory criterion, the trolley, and the knowledge argument were not separate demonstrations but instruments of one inquiry, conducted on the player's behalf and at the player's expense, into whether personhood can be grown in a being that did not begin with it. *Prey* thus does what no anthology of thought experiments can do: it nests them, so that the conclusion of the last re-describes the purpose of all the others.

CHAPTER III

III

The Mythic Substrate

Typhon, Talos, Medea, Proteus, and the Pierides



§ 3.1

Chaoskampf and Its Discontents

Hermann Gunkel's *Schöpfung und Chaos in Urzeit und Endzeit* (1895) named the pattern that underlies the oldest cosmogonies of the eastern Mediterranean: the *Chaoskampf*, the combat in which a storm god or creator defeats a monster of the deep and founds order upon its defeat. Marduk splits Tiamat in the *Enūma Eliš*; Baal defeats Yam at Ugarit; Indra slays Vṛtra in the *Ṛgveda*; the Hebrew Bible remembers Yahweh's victory over Leviathan and Rahab. Joseph Fontenrose's *Python* (1959) formalized the pattern into recurrent motifs: the enemy's monstrous lineage, the champion's initial defeat, the enemy's temporary reign, the champion's recovery with allied help, and the final victory that guarantees the cosmos. The war between Zeus and Typhon is the Greek instance par excellence, and the one whose names *Prey* adopts.

Prey's endings remain, for the most part, within the pattern. Alex Yu's preferred resolution, the Nullwave transmitter, annihilates the Typhon while preserving the station and its research: the champion's victory that keeps the spoils. January's preferred resolution, the station's self-destruction, is the sacrificial version, in which order is preserved by destroying the battlefield and everyone remaining on it. December's counsel, early flight, abandons the combat altogether and leaves the monster to reach Earth. Each is a recognizable variant of the *Chaoskampf*: slaying, sacrifice, defeat. The coda then does something the pattern does not permit. It addresses the monster. It asks the monster what it has become and extends a hand. The dissertation's claim is that this gesture is unintelligible within the combat myth and fully intelligible only within a set of counter-traditions—Greek, Mesopotamian, and Chinese—in which the monster is not destroyed but transformed, and in which the intelligence that defeats it shares its nature.



FIGURE 3.1 **Names as compressed arguments** The figures of the mythic substrate and their correspondents in *Prey*.

§ 3.2

Hesiod's Polyphonic Monster

In Hesiod's *Theogony* (820–880), after the Titans have been imprisoned, Earth bears her youngest child to Tartarus: Typhoeus, with a hundred serpent heads flickering dark tongues and eyes flashing fire. Hesiod lingers on one attribute above all others, and it is not strength. It is voice:

> Voices were in all his terrible heads, sending forth every kind of sound unspeakable: at one moment they spoke so that the gods could understand, at another came the sound of a bull bellowing, unstoppable in its might; at another, of a lion with a shameless heart; at another, sounds like whelps, a wonder to hear; at another he hissed, and the high mountains echoed beneath. (*Theogony* 829–835; trans. mine)

Hesiod's Typhoeus is the first great mimic in Greek literature. His heads speak the language of the gods and the noises of beasts; he possesses every voice and no voice of his own. Hesiod adds that had Zeus not perceived the danger, Typhoeus would have ruled over mortals and immortals alike (836–838): the polyphonic monster is an alternative sovereign, a rival principle of order rather than its mere absence. When Zeus's thunderbolts finally sear every head, the maimed giant is hurled into Tartarus, and from him come the lawless winds that wreck ships and ruin crops—not the god-born winds of the cardinal directions, but gusts with no origin and no direction, disorder distributed through the world.

The correspondence with *Prey*'s Typhon is structural. The Mimic possesses every shape and no shape of its own. The Phantom possesses every human voice it has consumed and none it originated. The Apex, the vast entity drawn to the station by the Coral's signal, is the alternative sovereign whose arrival would end human rule of Talos I and, beyond it, of Earth. Hesiod's monster is not chaos as formlessness; it is chaos as *polymorphy*—the capacity to be anything, which is the capacity to be no one.

§ 3.3

The Parthenogenetic Twin: Athena, Typhaon, and Mētis

A second archaic account, preserved in the *Homeric Hymn to Apollo* (305–355), gives Typhon a different and more revealing genealogy. Hera, enraged that Zeus has brought Athena to birth from his own head without her, strikes the earth, prays to Earth, Heaven, and the Titans below, and in time bears a child of her own without Zeus: Typhaon, dread and baneful, whom she entrusts to the she-dragon at Pytho to rear. Athena's birth itself has a prehistory in the *Theogony* (886–900): Zeus swallowed his first wife, Mētis, while she was pregnant, lest she bear a son stronger than his father, and thereafter carried her counsel within him.

Read together, these texts make Athena and Typhaon twin products of a single crisis: Zeus's incorporation of *mētis*. Marcel Detienne and Jean-Pierre Vernant, in *Les ruses de l'intelligence* (1974), reconstructed *mētis* as the Greek name for cunning intelligence—the improvisational, polymorphic, disguising intelligence of the hunter, the navigator, the weaver, and the fox. Its emblematic animal was the octopus, which takes on the color of the rock to which it clings. The elegist Theognis made the octopus a moral model: "My heart, turn a many-colored character toward all your friends, blending in the temper each one has; take the temper of the many-twined octopus, which looks like whatever rock it clings to" (213–216; trans. mine).

The consequence for this study is considerable. In the Greek imagination, the intelligence that makes human beings resourceful—the capacity to assimilate oneself to circumstance, to take the color of the other—was modeled on mimicry, and that same incorpor-

ated power of transformation generated, by a kind of jealous counter-birth, the cosmos's greatest monster. Athena is mimetic intelligence born from the head; Typhaon is mimetic monstrosity born from resentment at that birth. *Prey*'s neuromods enter the head through the eye, and its Typhon are tentacular, inky, color-shifting forms whose iconography is unmistakably cephalopod. The Möbius thesis developed in Chapter X has a mythic precedent: wisdom and monstrosity were already twins.

§ 3.4

Lying Forms and the Pierides

Ovid's version of the war, examined briefly in Chapter I, deserves fuller attention for its frame. The account of the gods hiding from Typhoeus in "lying shapes" (*mentitis figuris*, *Metamorphoses* V.326) is not narrated by Ovid's voice but by the Pierides, nine daughters of Pierus who challenge the Muses to a singing contest and sing a song that diminishes the gods. When the Muses win, the Pierides are transformed into magpies. The episode opens with Minerva hearing voices from the branches so distinct that she supposes a human being is speaking; they belong to nine magpies, *imitantes omnia picae*, "magpies that imitate everything" (V.299). The book closes with the observation that even now, in the birds, their former eloquence remains, with a raucous garrulity and a monstrous zeal for speaking: *nunc quoque in alitibus facundia prisca remansit / raucaque garrulitas studiumque inmane loquendi* (V.677–678).

Here the Ovidian text supplies an uncanny anticipation of *Prey*'s Phantoms. Phantoms are Typhon generated from human corpses, and as they patrol they murmur fragments of their former lives—worries, errands, phrases of the dead—speech that retains the cadence of address without anyone to address. Minerva, goddess of wisdom, mistakes the mimic's speech for human speech; the player, hearing a Phantom's murmur around a corner, makes the same mistake for a fatal instant. The Phantom is the Pieridean magpie: a transformed being whose *facundia prisca*, ancient eloquence, survives the transformation as residue.

The frame yields a principle that recurs throughout this dissertation, here named the *Pierides paradox*: those who narrate the gods' mimicry are themselves turned into mimics. Whoever tells the story of disguise is transformed into an imitator. The principle applies, as Chapter X argues, to the game's makers and players as well as to its creatures.

The paradox has a Pindaric counterpoint that sharpens it. *Pierides*, "the Pierian ones," is also a standard poetic name for the Muses themselves, and Pindar's First Pythian opens with the golden lyre of Apollo and the Muses, whose music quenches Zeus's thunderbolt and lulls his eagle to sleep, before naming those the music cannot reach: "whatever Zeus does not love is terrified when it hears the voice of the Pierides" (1.13–14; trans. mine)—above all hundred-headed Typhon, lying in Tartarus and pinned beneath Etna. The name

Pierides thus belongs at once to the true singers whose harmony Typhon cannot bear and to Ovid's false singers who, having sung of Typhon, become creatures of his kind: mimics without harmony. The two traditions divide one name between attunement and imitation. Typhon is excluded from the first and generated by the second, and the distinction between them—between song that attunes listeners to one another and mimicry that merely reproduces sound—is the mythic form of the distinction between empathy and predatory imitation that Chapter X calls the Möbius of mimesis. Heidegger's word for the attunement through which a world is disclosed, *Stimmung*, comes from the tuning of instruments; read through Pindar, the Typhon's deficit is a deficit of attunement.

§ 3.5

The Ephemeral Fruit

Apollodorus's *Library* (1.6.3) preserves the fullest narrative of the Typhonomachy and the detail from which this dissertation takes its title. Typhon, born of Earth and Tartarus in Cilicia, towers over mountains; his hands reach east and west; from them spring a hundred serpent heads; he is winged, and fire flashes from his eyes. The gods flee to Egypt and take animal forms. Zeus fights with thunderbolts and an adamantine sickle, but Typhon entwines him in his coils, wrests away the sickle, cuts the sinews of Zeus's hands and feet, and deposits the helpless god in the Corycian cave, the sinews wrapped in a bearskin and guarded by the she-dragon Delphyne. Hermes and Aegipan steal the sinews and restore them. Zeus pursues Typhon to Mount Nysa, "and there the Fates deceived him as he fled: persuaded that he would be strengthened by them, he tasted the ephemeral fruits" (τῶν ἐφημέρων καρπῶν; trans. mine). Weakened, he is driven to Thrace, where the mountain is named Haemus for the blood (*haima*) he sheds, and finally pinned beneath Etna.

Ephēmeros means "lasting a day." Pindar uses the word as a name for human beings in the most famous lines of the Eighth Pythian: "Creatures of a day: what is someone? what is no one? A human being is a shadow's dream" (8.95–96). The Fates, spinners and cutters of mortal lifespans, defeat the immortal monster not by force but by feeding it the food of mortals. Typhon is undone by ephemerality.

This is the dissertation's governing figure. *Prey*'s coda reveals that the protagonist is a Typhon who has been fed human neuromods—condensed skill and memory harvested from mortals—and made to live a single day staged repeatedly, the simulated 15 March whose reset is the game's first narrative event. The Typhon-Morgan is a Typhon who has tasted the ephemeral fruit. The myth calls this a deception and a defeat; the experimenters call it a hope. *Prey*'s question is whether weakening and humanization are the same operation described from opposite sides—whether the monster's acquisition of finitude, forgetting, and a life of one day is the precondition of the empathy it is being tested for. The fruit

has the structure of a *pharmakon*: poison and remedy at once. The myth contains a further detail. Before his defeat, Typhon cuts the sovereign's sinews; order itself is crippled and must be restored by intermediaries. In the coda, the human sovereign presides over a world the Typhon have already overrun. His sinews are cut. He needs the monster's cooperation precisely because he can no longer compel it.

§ 3.6

Talos and Medea

Apollonius of Rhodes (*Argonautica* IV.1638–1693) describes Talos as a man of bronze, last survivor of the bronze race sprung from ash trees, whom Zeus gave to Europa as warden of Crete. Three times a day he strides around the island on bronze feet, hurling boulders at approaching ships, as he does at the Argo. His body is invulnerable but for one vein at the ankle, closed by a thin membrane. Medea, the Colchian sorceress, defeats him from the deck: she invokes the death-spirits, and with hostile eyes she bewitches the bronze giant's eyes, sending against him baleful phantoms (δείκηλα) in her fury. Talos grazes his ankle on a rock, the ichor pours out like molten lead, and he falls like a pine half-felled by woodsmen. Apollodorus (1.9.26) records variants: in one, Medea drove him mad with drugs; in another, she promised to make him immortal and drew out the nail that sealed his vein.

Three elements of the episode bear directly on *Prey*. The first is *Talosian vulnerability*: the invulnerable guardian with a single point of failure, the vein and the eye. Talos I, the station that guards Earth from the Typhon, is penetrated not by force but by phantoms, and the self aboard it is rewritten through the eye, which is where every neuromod needle enters. The second is the inversion between the two mythic defeats. Talos falls to a false promise of immortality; Typhon falls to a false promise of strength that delivers mortality. The guardian dies by being offered what it is not; the monster is tamed by being fed what it is not. *Prey*'s station falls like Talos; its Typhon is tested like Typhon. The third element is Medea herself: a *pharmakis*, a drug-worker, foreign to the place she transforms, who lures her own brother Apsyrtus to his death to secure her escape—in Apollonius, Jason strikes the blow in the ambush she arranges (*Argonautica* IV.410–481; in Apollodorus 1.9.24 she kills and dismembers him herself, scattering the pieces to delay pursuit). Morgan Yu is a pharmacologist of the self, able in the final act to kill their own brother, aboard a station whose every object can be broken into its constituents and scattered. Hesiod's bronze race, moreover, perished by its own hands (*Works and Days* 143–155); Talos I, last outpost of the Kennedy counterfactual's bronze age of state-corporate science, is destroyed by its own experiments.

A later analogue completes the figure. The golem of Prague legend is animated by the word *emet* (truth) inscribed on its brow and deactivated when one letter is erased, leaving

met (dead). Talos, the golem, and Talos I share the logic of the automaton guardian: the single inscription, vein, or eye upon which a vast invulnerability depends.

§ 3.7

Proteus Held

In the fourth book of the *Odyssey* (351–592), Menelaus, becalmed at Pharos, learns from the sea-nymph Eidothea how to extract a prophecy from her father Proteus, the Old Man of the Sea. Menelaus and his men must disguise themselves under fresh sealskins and lie among the seals; when Proteus counts his herd and sleeps, they must seize him and hold fast while he becomes a bearded lion, a serpent, a leopard, a great boar, flowing water, and a tall tree. When he resumes his own form and questions them, they may release him, and he will speak truly.

The episode is the archetype of interrogating a shapeshifter, and it contains its own lesson about mimicry: the hunters must become seals to capture the master of forms. *Prey* repeats both halves. Morgan learns Typhon abilities, including the capacity to assume the shape of objects, in order to survive the Typhon; and the coda shows the shapeshifter bound in a chair before its examiners. But the coda inverts the Homeric logic at its decisive point. Proteus is held until he abandons his disguises and returns to his true form, which alone speaks truth. The coda's examiners do not want the creature's true form. They want it to *keep* the form it has worn—to remain Morgan in conduct while knowing it is not Morgan in substance. In *Prey*, truth is not what remains when the disguise is stripped away; truth is the disguise sustained under knowledge. This inversion is the hinge of the dissertation's forensic account of personhood.

§ 3.8

Narcissus and Echo

Ovid's *Metamorphoses* III.339–510 binds two figures of reflection together. Echo, punished by Juno, can only repeat the final words she hears; Narcissus, who rejects her, falls in love with his image in a pool and, on recognizing it, cries *iste ego sum: sensi, nec me mea fallit imago*—"I am he; I have sensed it; my image does not deceive me" (III.463). Earlier, the seer Tiresias had prophesied that Narcissus would live to old age *si se non noverit*, "if he does not come to know himself" (III.348), inverting the Delphic command.

Prey distributes the episode across its creatures and its coda. Echo is the Phantom, repeating fragments without address. Narcissus's image is the Mimic and the Looking Glass, surfaces that return the world's forms with something alien behind them. And the coda re-

verses Narcissus's recognition. Narcissus learns that the image he loves is himself; the Typhon-Morgan learns that the self it has been is an image. The coda's pronouncement—that the subject is not Morgan Yu—is *iste ego sum* turned inside out: not "that is me" but "this is not you." Tiresias's warning applies with full force. For the creature, self-knowledge is the moment of mortal danger, the instant at which it may be terminated or may destroy its examiners.

§ 3.9

Kingu's Blood

The Babylonian *Enūma Eliš* adds an anthropogony to its combat myth. After Marduk splits Tiamat's body to form heaven and earth (Tablet IV), he proposes to create humankind to bear the gods' labor; Ea fashions human beings from the blood of Kingu, the rebel commander of Tiamat's host, who is bound and executed for his part in the war (Tablet VI). The Old Babylonian *Atrahasis* gives a related account in which a god is slain and his flesh and blood mixed with clay, so that a ghost of the slain god remains in human flesh. In these traditions, humanity is made from the substance of the defeated rebel and created for service.

Prey re-enacts this anthropogony twice. TranStar fabricates neuromods from Typhon exotic material, so that the augmented human being of 2032 is literally enriched with the substance of the defeated monster. And the coda presents a human person, or a candidate for personhood, made from a Typhon, created to serve the purposes of a diminished human order as its "bridge." The pattern may be called *Kinguic anthropogony*: the human made of the rebel's blood and destined for labor. It explains why the coda's offer of partnership carries the shadow of servitude, a shadow Chapter VIII examines through the history of colonial intermediaries.

§ 3.10

Prometheus, Epimetheus, and the Missing Gift

In Plato's *Protagoras* (320c–322d), the sophist tells how the gods molded mortal kinds and charged the brothers Prometheus and Epimetheus with distributing their capacities. Epimetheus, whose name means afterthought, spends every gift on the animals—speed, strength, claws, fur—and leaves human beings naked. Prometheus, forethought, steals technical wisdom together with fire from Hephaestus and Athena. Humans so equipped can build and speak but cannot live together: scattered, they are devoured by beasts; gathered, they wrong one another and scatter again. Zeus, fearing their extinction, sends Hermes

with *aidōs* and *dikē*—reverence for others and justice—and instructs him to distribute them not as the arts are distributed, one expert for many laypeople, but to all, adding a law that whoever cannot share in *aidōs* and *dikē* be put to death as a disease of the city.

The myth gives *Prey*'s moral structure in miniature. TranStar's neuromods are Promethean gifts: technical capacity installed, skill without the formation that ordinarily accompanies it. The station's crew, so equipped, still wrong one another, exploit the Volunteers, and abandon one another to the Typhon; techne has not made them a city. The coda tests for the Hermetic gift. What the game calls empathy is closest to *aidōs*, the capacity to be checked and moved by regard for another. And Zeus's grim law describes the coda's stakes exactly: the being that cannot share in *aidōs* is to be eliminated as a disease. The mapping of names is equally precise. January, the Operator programmed by an earlier Morgan to guide a future self, is Promethean forethought; Morgan, who always learns afterward what an earlier self knew, is Epimethean afterthought. Bernard Stiegler's reading of the myth, in which Epimetheus's fault makes the human a being of originary lack supplemented by technics, finds in Morgan its literal case: a being of engineered forgetting, supplemented by installed capacities.

Aeschylus's *Prometheus Bound* (351–372) supplies a final link: the chained Titan pities Typhon, crushed beneath Etna, from whom rivers of fire will one day burst. Benefactor and monster are fellow prisoners of the same sovereign order. Aboard Talos I, the Typhon held in Kletka and the human held in a reset apartment are, likewise, prisoners of a single regime.

§ 3.11

The Butterfly and the Transformation of Things

The second chapter of the *Zhuangzi*, the *Qiwulun*, ends with a dream. Zhuang Zhou dreamed he was a butterfly, fluttering happily, unaware of Zhou; waking, he was solidly Zhou again, and did not know whether he was Zhou who had dreamed of being a butterfly or a butterfly dreaming of being Zhou. Yet, he adds, between Zhou and the butterfly there must be some distinction: 此之謂物化, "this is called the transformation of things." The passage refuses both naive realism and dissolution. It affirms the distinction and the transformation together.

Prey's ontology is an ontology of *wuhua*. Matter passes through Recyclers into raw categories and through Fabricators into new objects; Typhon pass into furniture and back; human corpses pass into Phantoms; skills pass into heads through needles; a Typhon passes into a human life. The sixth chapter of the *Zhuangzi* imagines friends who face mortal illness with equanimity, accepting that the transforming process may make one of them a rooster's leg, a crossbow pellet, or a cart. The Recycler is the industrial parody of that

equanimity: transformation without acceptance, conducted for profit. The coda poses the butterfly's question in its starkest form—does the Typhon dream Morgan, or does Morgan's life dream the Typhon?—and the Zhuangzian answer is the one the game ultimately endorses: the question dissolves into the transformation, and what remains is how one moves within it.

§ 3.12

Gun and Yu: A Speculative Onomastics of the Flood

The game does not specify the Chinese character of the Yu family name, and what follows is offered as a resonance, not a source. Among the most celebrated bearers of the sound in Chinese myth is Yu the Great (禹), tamer of the flood. The *Shanhaijing* records his origin in a terse entry: 洪水滔天。鯀竊帝之息壤以堙洪水，不待帝命。帝令祝融殺鯀于羽郊。鯀復生禹。"The flood waters rose to the heavens. Gun stole the Supreme God's swelling soil to dam the flood, without waiting for the god's command. The god ordered Zhurong to kill Gun at the outskirts of Feather Mountain. From Gun was born Yu." Gun's theft is Promethean, and his method is containment: he dams. He fails and is executed. Yu, born from his father's corpse, succeeds by the opposite method, dredging channels that guide the waters along their own tendencies to the sea. A tradition preserved in later commentary adds that Yu transformed himself into a bear to tunnel through a mountain, and that his wife, seeing him in animal form, fled in shame and turned to stone.

The structural fit with the Yu siblings is striking enough to record. Alex embodies Gun's strategy: the cage, the containment program, the Nullwave that preserves the research by annihilating the flood. Morgan, who can absorb Typhon powers until the station's own turrets classify them as alien, embodies Yu's: mastery of the flood by partial assimilation to it, at the price of horrifying those who see the transformation. And the coda stages the passage from one to the other within a single family. Containment has failed; Earth is overrun; and from the failure of containment is born the strategy of channeling—the hybrid "bridge." *From Gun was born Yu.*

§ 3.13

Conclusion: Three Mythic Principles

The mythic substrate yields three principles that the rest of the dissertation develops. First, polymorphy unites the monster and the intelligence: Typhon and Athena are twin births of incorporated *mētis*, and the gods themselves survive Typhon only by becoming mimics. Second, the monster and the guardian each have a hinge: Typhon is undone by ephemeral-

ity, the fruit of a day; Talos is undone through the eye and the vein. Mortality and the gaze are where transformation enters. Third, the combat myth has always possessed counter-traditions—Yu's channeling, Zhuangzi's transformation of things, the Pierides' becoming-mimic, Hermes' universal distribution of *aidōs*—in which the resolution is metamorphosis rather than annihilation. *Prey*'s coda belongs to these counter-traditions. It is a combat myth that ends in a question.

CHAPTER IV

IV

The Palimpsest Self

Memory, Neuromods, and the Forensic Person



Je est un autre.

ARTHUR RIMBAUD, LETTER TO PAUL DEMENY, 15 MAY 1871

§ 4.1

Waking Without a Past

Amnesia is the oldest device of the immersive simulation, and the most philosophically loaded. It solves a design problem—the player knows nothing of the world, so the protagonist should know nothing either—while posing a metaphysical one: if the protagonist's past is unavailable, in virtue of what is the protagonist the person that past belonged to? *Planescape: Torment* made the device its subject; *Prey* makes it its mechanism. Morgan Yu's memory loss is not a narrative accident but an engineering consequence: removing a neuromod reverts the brain to its state at the moment of installation, erasing everything learned since. Morgan, a subject of neuromod research, has been installed and uninstalled repeatedly, and has lived the same simulated day again and again.

John Locke anticipated the case. In the chapter on identity added to the second edition of *An Essay Concerning Human Understanding* (1694), he imagined "day-man" and "night-man": two incommunicable consciousnesses alternating in one body, which, he argued, would be two persons as distinct as Socrates and Plato (II.xxvii.23). Morgan before a reset and Morgan after a reset approximate Locke's day-man and night-man, sharing a body and a name but not a stream of consciousness. *Prey* adds two complications Locke did not imagine. The earlier Morgan can leave instructions for the later one in a robot that speaks with Morgan's voice. And the being that finally answers to the name of Morgan turns out to share neither body nor species with the original, only memories and installed capacities.

§ 4.2

Locke's Forensic Person and the Great Day

Locke defined a person as "a thinking intelligent being, that has reason and reflection, and can consider itself as itself, the same thinking thing, in different times and places" (II.xxvii.9), and located personal identity in consciousness extended backward to past thoughts and actions. His most consequential sentence, however, concerns not metaphysics but law: "It is a forensic term, appropriating actions and their merit; and so belongs only to intelligent agents, capable of a law, and happiness, and misery" (II.xxvii.26). A person, for Locke, is what can be held to account. Personal identity matters because reward and punishment require that the one judged be the one who acted.

Locke tested this forensic conception on the hardest case available to him, the drunkard who commits a crime he cannot remember. Human courts may punish him, Locke conceded, because they cannot verify his lack of consciousness; but "in the great day, wherein

the secrets of all hearts shall be laid open, it may be reasonable to think, no one shall be made to answer for what he knows nothing of; but shall receive his doom, his conscience accusing or excusing him" (II.xxvii.22). The Last Judgment is, for Locke, the ideal court: the only tribunal with full access to consciousness, and therefore the only one that can judge persons exactly.

Prey's coda is a secular staging of Locke's great day. The secrets of the heart are laid open, not by omniscience but by telemetry: every choice made in the simulation has been recorded. The judged receives its doom, its conduct accusing or excusing it, in the voices of those it saved or failed. And the tribunal observes a distinction Locke's theory makes possible. The creature possesses memories of the human Morgan's life before the simulation, including Morgan's complicity in TranStar's research; yet it is judged only on what it did within the simulation. The examiners implicitly decline to hold it responsible for the implanted past and hold it fully responsible for the lived one. They have adopted, without naming it, a theory of the difference between remembering and seeming to remember.

§ 4.3

Circularity, Transitivity, Quasi-Memory

Locke's theory provoked two classic objections, both of which *Prey* dramatizes. Joseph Butler, in a dissertation appended to *The Analogy of Religion* (1736), argued that "consciousness of personal identity presupposes, and therefore cannot constitute, personal identity; any more than knowledge, in any other case, can constitute truth, which it presupposes." A genuine memory is a memory of one's *own* past; to use memory to define identity is therefore circular. Thomas Reid, in the *Essays on the Intellectual Powers of Man* (1785), added the case of the brave officer: a boy flogged for robbing an orchard becomes an officer who remembers the flogging, then a general who remembers the officer's exploits but not the flogging. By Locke's criterion the general is the officer and the officer is the boy, but the general is not the boy—a violation of the transitivity identity requires.

Sydney Shoemaker's reply in "Persons and Their Pasts" (1970) introduced *quasi-memory*: a state that is experientially like remembering an event, caused in the appropriate way by someone's having experienced it, but without the presupposition that the rememberer is that someone. Ordinary memory is the special case in which the quasi-rememberer and the experiencer coincide. Quasi-memory breaks Butler's circle by allowing memory-like connections to be specified before identity is settled.

The Typhon-Morgan is the purest case of quasi-memory in fiction. Its recollections of Morgan's life before the simulation are quasi-memories in exactly Shoemaker's sense: experientially indistinguishable from memories, causally derived from Morgan's experiences through the neuromods, but not memories of its own past. Its recollections of the simula-

tion are genuine memories of its own experience, though of virtual events. Ridley Scott's *Blade Runner* (1982), in which the replicant Rachael discovers that her childhood memories belong to her maker's niece, posed the same structure but left it as a wound; *Prey* converts it into a jurisprudence. Philip K. Dick's story "We Can Remember It for You Wholesale" (1966) had supplied the inverse case: a clerk who buys implanted memories of a secret mission to Mars discovers that the procedure has uncovered real memories erased by the agency that employed him, so that what he took for a purchased fiction was his own suppressed past. The coda's examiners discount the quasi-memories and weigh the genuine ones. Reid's transitivity problem returns in the relation among the boy, the officer, and the general—here, the human Morgan, the many reset Morgans, and the creature—and *Prey* answers it as Parfit would: by denying that strict identity is what the tribunal needs.

§ 4.4

Bundles, Chariots, and the Recycler

David Hume, searching introspectively for the self, found nothing but perceptions and concluded that the mind is "nothing but a bundle or collection of different perceptions, which succeed each other with an inconceivable rapidity, and are in a perpetual flux and movement" (*Treatise of Human Nature* 1.4.6). Centuries earlier, the Buddhist *Milindapañha* had made the same argument through the monk Nāgasena, who asks King Milinda whether his chariot is the pole, the axle, the wheels, the frame, or the yoke, and concludes that "chariot" is a convenient designation dependent on parts, as "Nāgasena" is, with no further entity behind the name.

The Recycler is Nāgasena's chariot rendered as a machine. Feed it a chair, a banana peel, a broken Operator, or the organs harvested from a Typhon corpse, and it returns cubes of raw matter in four categories: organic, mineral, synthetic, and exotic. The Fabricator reverses the process, assembling any object for which a plan exists. No object aboard Talos I has an identity that survives this circuit; each is a designation dependent on its parts, and the parts are fungible. The categories themselves repay attention. Three are terrestrial—life, earth, and artifice—and one is celestial: exotic material, harvested from the Typhon, the substance of the beings from beyond. The scheme recalls the Aristotelian cosmos, in which the four sublunary elements undergo generation and corruption while the heavens are made of a fifth, incorruptible substance, the aether, which the alchemists would later seek to distill as quintessence. TranStar's chemistry distills that celestial substance into neuromods and injects it into human eyes. Talos I practices an alchemy in which the heavens are the raw material of the self.

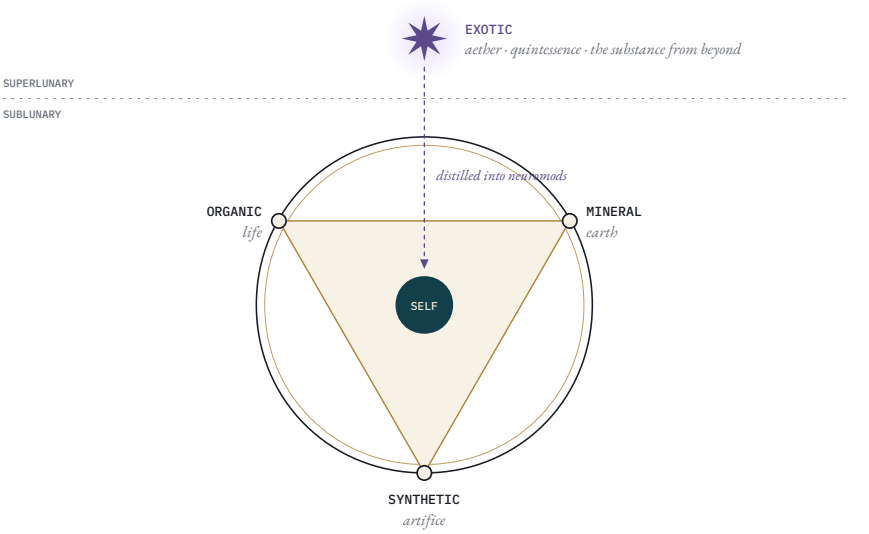


FIGURE 4.1 **The Recycler as alchemical emblem** Three terrestrial categories of matter and one celestial: the substance from beyond, distilled into the self.

§ 4.5

The Ship and the Reassembled Planks

Plutarch records that the Athenians preserved the ship of Theseus by replacing its rotten planks, so that it became a standing example for philosophers disputing whether a thing remains the same when its parts are renewed (*Theseus* 23.1). Thomas Hobbes sharpened the puzzle in *De Corpore* (1655): if someone kept the discarded planks and reassembled them, there would be two ships, each with a claim to be the original. The puzzle's modern force lies in Hobbes's addition, because it makes identity a matter of competing claims rather than gradual change.

Prey supplies Hobbes's second ship twice. January, an Operator programmed by an earlier Morgan with that Morgan's values and voice, claims to speak for the true Morgan and urges the station's destruction. December, a second such Operator, claims the same authority and urges escape. Each is a reassembled vessel built from Morgan's planks—memories, judgments, intentions—and each competes with the player's Morgan, the gradually renewed ship, for the title of the original. The coda then introduces a third vessel built from the same planks in a wholly different hull: a Typhon body carrying Morgan's memories and installed capacities. The question of which is the real Morgan admits no answer, and *Prey*'s

achievement is to make that absence of answer felt as a practical predicament rather than a logical curiosity.

§ 4.6

Parfit's Liberation and Williams's Fear

Derek Parfit's *Reasons and Persons* (1984) argued that personal identity is not what matters in survival. His teletransporter scans a body on Earth, destroys it, and builds a replica on Mars; in the branch-line case, a new scanner leaves the original alive but fatally damaged, able to speak with the replica before dying; in the fission case, the two hemispheres of a brain are transplanted into two bodies, each psychologically continuous with the original. Since identity cannot hold between one person and two, yet each branch seems to have everything that matters, Parfit concluded that what matters is Relation R—psychological connectedness and continuity—rather than identity itself. He described the conclusion as a liberation: the walls of the glass tunnel in which he had seemed to live dissolved, and he cared less about his own death and more about the lives of others.

Parfit's cases map onto *Prey* with uncommon precision. January and December are fission products. The Typhon-Morgan is a teletransportation replica built on a nonhuman substrate, and Parfit's widest formulation of Relation R, which permits any cause, would count its quasi-memories and installed dispositions as transmitting what matters. Parfit also imagined a young Russian nobleman, a socialist, who plans to give away his estate and asks his wife to hold him to the plan if he later changes his mind, regarding his future self as a different person whose wishes have no authority. January is that nobleman's request, engineered into a robot.

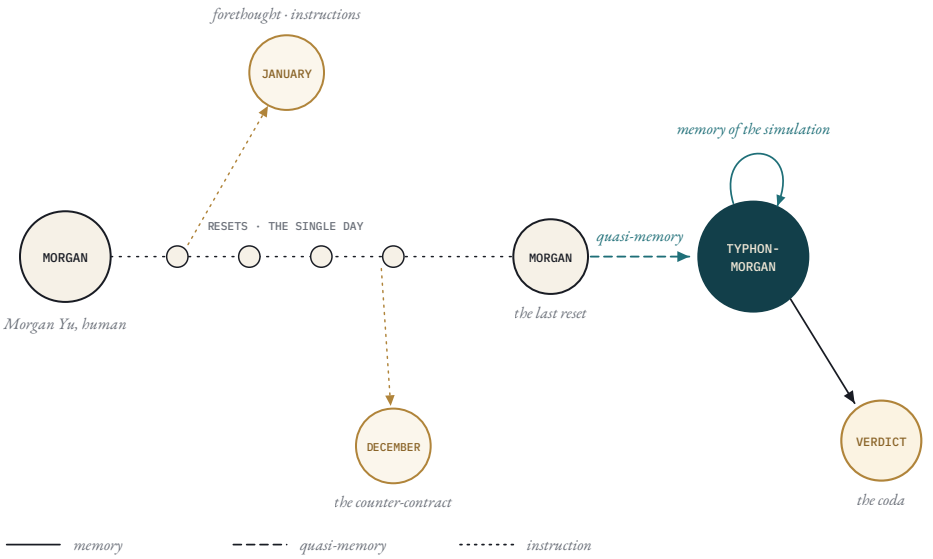


FIGURE 4.2 **The palimpsest self** Memory, quasi-memory, and instruction: the human Morgan, the reset Morgans, January and December, and the Typhon who inherits them.

Bernard Williams's "The Self and the Future" (1970) supplies the necessary counterweight. Williams showed that the same body-swap scenario, described as an exchange of memories between bodies, invites us to identify with whoever receives our memories; but described as "you will be tortured, and beforehand your memories will be altered," it leaves us fearing the torture regardless. Anticipatory fear tracks the body. *Prey* places its creature in Williams's predicament at the moment of revelation: its fears are Morgan-shaped, but the body that the examiners may terminate is a body it did not know it had. The coda's terror is the terror of discovering that one's fear has been attached to the wrong body.

§ 4.7

Idem and Ipse: Ricoeur's Promise

Paul Ricoeur's *Soi-même comme un autre* (1990), whose title names the Typhon-Morgan's condition with eerie exactness, distinguishes two senses of identity. *Idem*-identity is sameness: permanence in time, the persistence of a substance or a character. *Ipse*-identity is selfhood: the constancy of a self that keeps its word even as its character changes, exemplified for Ricoeur in the promise, through which one maintains oneself (*maintien de soi*) against

the drift of time. Narrative identity mediates between the two, integrating change and constancy into the story of a life.

Ricoeur's distinction resolves the apparent paradox of the coda. The creature has no *idem*-identity with Morgan: it is not the same substance, and it is not clear that it shares Morgan's character beyond what the neuromods impose. But it may achieve *ipse*-identity with Morgan by keeping Morgan's promises—by honoring, within the simulation, the obligations Morgan bore toward the survivors, toward the station, toward Earth—and by keeping new ones. The handshake the coda offers is a promise in Ricoeur's strict sense: a commitment that binds a future self to a present word. The creature can become Morgan, not by being the same, but by being faithful. Rimbaud's formula, "I is another," here becomes the precondition of ethics rather than the symptom of alienation: only a self that knows it is another can choose to keep another's word.

§ 4.8

Neuromods as Technologies of Memory

Plato's *Meno* (81c–86b) presents learning as recollection: the slave boy, questioned about geometry, draws from within himself knowledge his soul possessed before birth. The neuromod is anamnesis inverted. It delivers knowledge without learning, as recollection does, but what it delivers is not the soul's own forgotten knowledge; it is someone else's acquired skill. The *Phaedrus* (274c–277a) supplies the corresponding critique. The god Theuth offers writing to King Thamus as a *pharmakon* for memory and wisdom; Thamus replies that it will produce forgetfulness in those who learn it, a remedy not for memory but for reminding, conferring the appearance of wisdom without its substance. Jacques Derrida's "La pharmacie de Platon" (1968) showed that the *pharmakon* is undecidably remedy and poison, and that Plato's text cannot keep the two apart.

The neuromod is the most literal *pharmakon* in fiction. Installed, it confers skill without the memory of acquiring it; removed, it inflicts forgetting. It is simultaneously the cure for ignorance and the cause of amnesia, the prosthesis of memory and its eraser. Bernard Stiegler's *La technique et le temps* (1994) extended Husserl's distinction between primary retention (the just-past held in present awareness) and secondary retention (recollection) with a third category, *tertiary retention*: memory exteriorized in technical objects, from flint tools to writing to recordings, through which humanity evolves by what Stiegler called *epiphylogenesis*. The neuromod re-internalizes tertiary retention. The archive returns into the body; the library is injected through the eye.

The neuromod also presupposes a contested epistemology. Gilbert Ryle's *The Concept of Mind* (1949) argued that knowing how to do something cannot be reduced to knowing that certain propositions are true. Jason Stanley and Timothy Williamson (2001) argued the

contrary, that knowing how is a species of propositional knowledge. A technology that installs skill as transferable content is intellectualism made industrial: it assumes that what a pianist knows can be extracted, stored, and transplanted. Jürgen Habermas's *Die Zukunft der menschlichen Natur* (2001) supplies the ethical dimension, distinguishing the grown (*das Gewachsene*) from the made (*das Gemachte*) and warning that a person designed by others may be unable to regard themselves as the undivided author of their own life. The Typhon-Morgan is the made being par excellence, its very candidacy for personhood designed by Alex Yu. Whether the coda's final choice restores its authorship or merely completes its design is a question the dissertation returns to in Chapter X.

§ 4.9

The Needle and the Lidlock

The neuromod is installed by a device held to the eye, whose needles pierce it. The image has a specific cinematic ancestry: the Ludovico technique of Anthony Burgess's *A Clockwork Orange* (1962) and Stanley Kubrick's adaptation (1971), in which the young criminal Alex is drugged, his eyelids clamped open, and forced to watch films of violence until violence itself sickens him. The prison chaplain's objection, in Burgess, is that a man conditioned out of choosing evil has not become good, because goodness that is imposed has ceased to be moral. Burgess's Alex is the conditioned; *Prey*'s Alex is the conditioner, occupying the seat of Burgess's scientist rather than his subject.

The chaplain's question applies directly to the coda's experiment: if empathy is installed through human neuromods, is the resulting conduct moral or merely mechanical? *Prey*'s answer distinguishes its experiment from Ludovico in one decisive respect. Ludovico removes the capacity to choose; the Talos simulation installs a capacity and then watches it exercised among real alternatives, including cruelty, and concludes by offering a final choice between the hand and violence. It is not conditioning but probation. The difference is the difference between a cage and a trial, though *Prey* never lets the player forget that its trial is held inside a cage.

§ 4.10

January as Ulysses Contract

Jon Elster's *Ulysses and the Sirens* (1979) analyzed precommitment as a strategy of imperfect rationality. Odysseus, knowing that the Sirens' song will overpower his judgment, has himself bound to the mast and instructs his crew to ignore his later commands. The present self binds the future self against its own anticipated weakness. January is a Ulysses contract de-

livered by robot. An earlier Morgan, anticipating that a reset Morgan might be recaptured by TranStar's purposes, programmed a guide carrying instructions to destroy the station—a binding of the future will against its anticipated corruption. December is a counter-contract signed at a different moment.

The contract raises a question Locke and Parfit answer differently. If the earlier Morgan and the later one are the same person, the earlier self's instructions have the authority of one's own prior resolution. If connectedness has faded, as Parfit's nobleman feared it would, the earlier self is to that degree another person, and its instructions have only the authority of a stranger's advice. Christopher Nolan's *Memento* (2000) pushed the structure to its darkest conclusion: its protagonist's notes and tattoos, left for a future self without memory, turn out to include deliberate deceptions he planted to manipulate that self. January could be such a deception. The player who follows January trusts a past self's judgment over present evidence; the player who refuses asserts the present self's sovereignty over a past that may have been mistaken, compromised, or simply different. Either way, the player enacts a theory of the authority of past selves.

§ 4.11

The Torment Question Answered

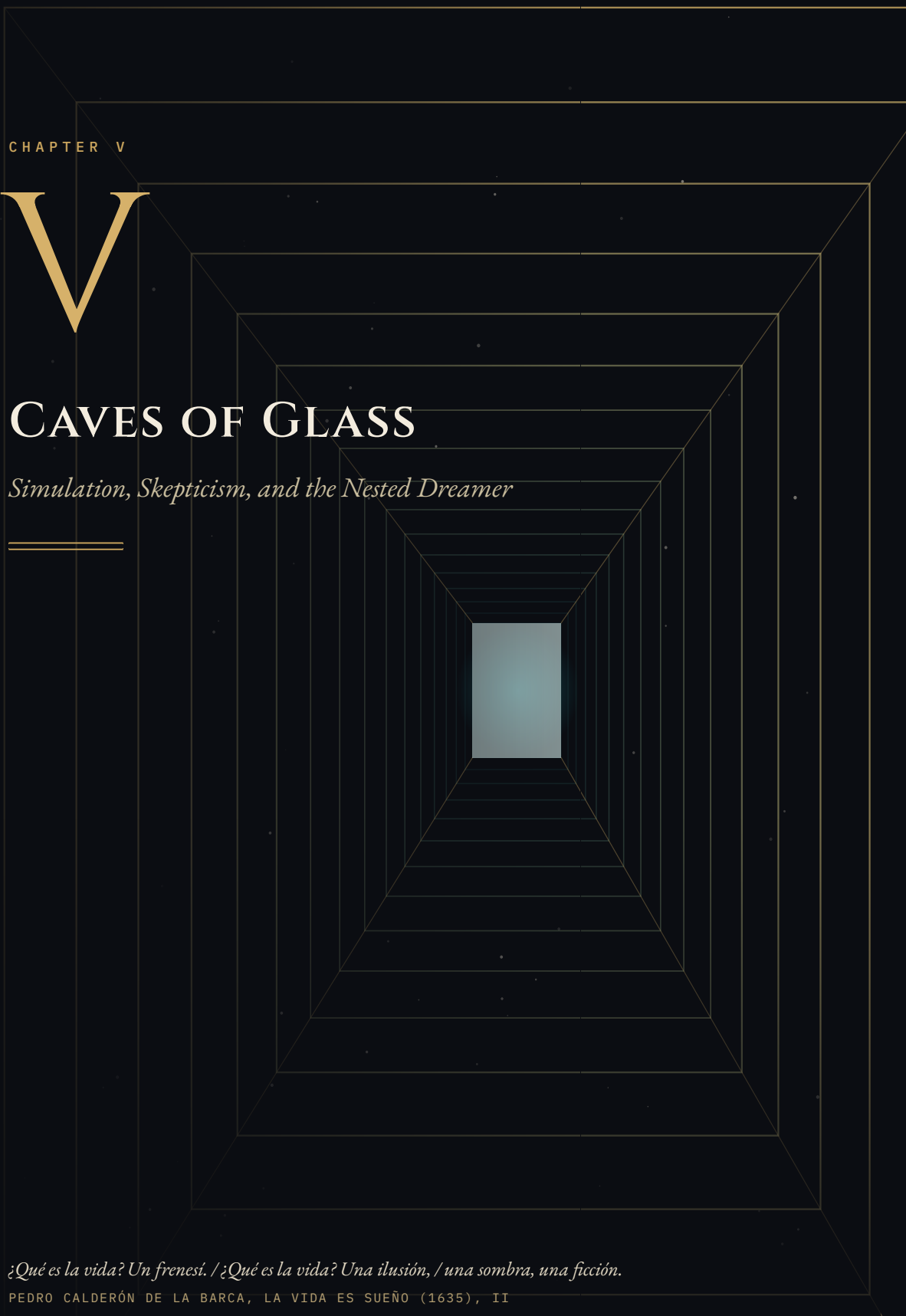
Planescape: Torment asks: "What can change the nature of a man?" The game accepts several answers and makes the act of answering part of the transformation. *Prey* repeats the question at the boundary of species and returns a precise answer by elimination. Memory cannot change a nature, because memory can be installed and removed. Substance cannot, because substance can be recycled, replaced, or swapped for another species' body. Knowledge cannot, because knowledge can be fabricated and injected. What remains is conduct sustained toward others over time and witnessed by them: the forensic record. Locke supplied the court, Shoemaker the distinction between memory and its semblance, Parfit the indifference to strict identity, and Ricoeur the promise through which a self that is another can nonetheless become constant. *Prey* assembles these into a single procedure and runs it on an alien.

CHAPTER V

V

Caves of Glass

Simulation, Skepticism, and the Nested Dreamer



¿Qué es la vida? Un frenesí. / ¿Qué es la vida? Una ilusión, / una sombra, una ficción.

PEDRO CALDERÓN DE LA BARCA, LA VIDA ES SUEÑO (1635), II

§ 5.1

The Apartment as Cave

In the seventh book of the *Republic* (514a–520a), Plato imagines prisoners chained from childhood facing a cave wall on which shadows are cast by objects carried before a fire behind them. Liberation begins with a turning (*periagōgē*): a prisoner is released, turned around, and dragged painfully toward the light, discovering first the fire and the objects, and only later the sun. *Prey*'s first great reversal stages the turning with a wrench. Morgan wakes in an apartment with a view of a city at morning; when the player returns to the apartment after the opening test and finds the world subtly wrong, the remedy is to strike the window, which shatters to reveal not sky but a laboratory: the view was a Looking Glass display, the apartment a set, the city a projection. Peter Weir's *The Truman Show* (1998), whose protagonist sails into the painted horizon of his world and finds a stair to an exit door, supplies the cinematic intertext.

The Platonic sequence is truncated in a revealing way. Plato's prisoner, once turned, ascends to the sun, the source of truth and the Good. Morgan, once turned, discovers only another enclosure: the station, sealed in cislunar space and overrun. And the coda discloses that the station, too, was a projection. Each turning reveals a further cave. *Prey* is Platonic in method and anti-Platonic in conclusion: it practices the turning but denies that the series of enclosures terminates in an unconditioned light. What terminates the series, if anything does, is not a vision but a relation—the hand.

§ 5.2

The Deceiver and the Wrench

Descartes's First Meditation (1641) escalates doubt from the senses to dreaming to the hypothesis of an evil deceiver, supremely powerful and cunning, who devotes all his energy to deceiving the meditator about everything. The Second Meditation finds the one certainty the deceiver cannot touch: that I, who am deceived, exist while I think. *Prey* builds its world as a sequence of evil deceivers—the simulated apartment, the Mimics, the Telepath that controls human survivors, the Operators corrupted by Technopaths, January's possibly manipulative counsel, Alex's lies—and supplies the player with Descartes's instrument in material form. The wrench is methodic doubt made iron: it tests whether a thing is what it seems by striking it.

The coda reaches the Cartesian bedrock and finds it inadequate. The creature thinks, and therefore it exists; the cogito holds. But the cogito says nothing about *what* exists—

whether the thinker is a human being, a Typhon, or a Typhon thinking a human being's thoughts. Descartes passed from the certainty of existence to the certainty of being a thinking thing and from there, through the proof of a non-deceiving God, to the restoration of the world. *Prey* removes the God. Its creature knows that it exists and knows nothing else with certainty, including whether its thoughts are its own. The only route out of radical doubt that remains is not proof but trust: the decision to take another's outstretched hand under uncertainty.

§ 5.3

Vats, Machines, and Simulations

Hilary Putnam's *Reason, Truth and History* (1981) revived the deceiver as a brain in a vat and turned semantic externalism against it: because the reference of a word depends on the causal history of its use, an envatted brain's word "vat" refers to the electronic impulses that cause its vat-experiences, so its thought "I am a brain in a vat" is false. The Typhon-Morgan presents a variant. Its name for itself, "Morgan," was acquired through quasi-memories causally derived from the human Morgan, which on Saul Kripke's causal-historical theory of naming (*Naming and Necessity*, 1980) fixes its reference to the human being. Within the simulation, however, every survivor addresses the creature as Morgan; a community of use attaches the name to the impersonator. The coda's disclosure splits the name along this fault line, and the creature's future depends on which naming practice prevails—whether its examiners will go on calling it by the name it has earned in use but not in origin.

Robert Nozick's experience machine (*Anarchy, State, and Utopia*, 1974) asked whether one would plug into a device supplying any desired experiences, and argued that most would refuse because they want to do things, to be a certain kind of person, and to contact reality. The Talos simulation inverts each feature. Its subject did not choose to enter; its experiences are not pleasant but catastrophic; and its purpose is precisely to determine what kind of person its subject has become by doing things. Nick Bostrom's simulation argument (2003) held that at least one of three propositions is true: civilizations almost never reach a posthuman stage, posthuman civilizations almost never run ancestor simulations, or we are almost certainly living in one. *Prey* imagines a fourth configuration Bostrom did not consider: a simulation run not by triumphant posthumans curious about their ancestors but by a defeated humanity, on an alien, to manufacture an ally. Not an ancestor simulation but an *enemy* simulation, conducted in the hope that the enemy will emerge as kin.

David Chalmers's "The Matrix as Metaphysics" (2003) and *Reality+* (2022) argue that simulation hypotheses are not skeptical but metaphysical: if we are simulated, our beliefs are largely true of digital objects, and virtual worlds can be genuine realities in which genuine lives are led. On Chalmers's virtual realism, the Typhon-Morgan's acts within the simu-

lation were real acts performed on real digital objects. Whether its rescues and killings had moral patients depends on whether the simulated survivors were conscious, a question the game leaves unanswered. Yet the coda treats the record as morally probative regardless, and Kant's argument about cruelty to animals—that duties concerning animals are indirect duties to humanity, since cruelty toward animals hardens the disposition toward human beings—explains why. The examiners are not asking whether the simulated survivors deserved care. They are asking what the creature's conduct toward beings it believed to be persons reveals about the dispositions it will bring to beings who are.

§ 5.4

The Desert of the Real

Jean Baudrillard's *Simulacres et simulation* (1981) opens with Borges's one-paragraph fable "Del rigor en la ciencia" (1946), in which an empire's cartographers draw a map that coincides point for point with the territory, which later generations abandon to rot in the desert. Baudrillard inverts the fable: in the age of simulation, it is the territory whose shreds rot across the map, and what remains is the hyperreal, a model without origin. His phrase for that remainder, the desert of the real, later entered popular culture through *The Matrix* (1999).

The Talos simulation is Borges's map made literal: a model of the station complete enough to sustain a life, every corridor, crew member, and coffee cup reproduced. And it is Baudrillard's inversion made narrative. By the time of the coda, the territory the map represents has been lost: the Typhon have overrun Earth, and the station of 2032 survives only as data in a laboratory. The simulation persists after the reality it models has ceased to exist in the form modeled. The examiners, standing in what remains of the real, use the map to manufacture a future that the territory can no longer supply. Baudrillard read simulation as the end of the real; *Prey* reads it as the last instrument by which a ruined reality might be rebuilt.

§ 5.5

La vida es sueño*: The Test of a Monstrous Nature*

The most exact literary ancestor of *Prey*'s coda is not a work of science fiction but Calderón's *La vida es sueño* (1635). Basilio, king of Poland and an astrologer, reads in the stars that his son Segismundo will become a tyrant who will humble his father, and imprisons him from birth in a tower, where the prince grows up knowing himself only as an anomaly. In his first speech he names his own hybridity: *soy un hombre de las fieras / y una fiera de los*

hombres—"I am a man among beasts, and a beast among men." To test the prophecy, Basilio has Segismundo drugged and carried to court, where he wakes as a prince; if he governs well, he will reign; if he proves a beast, he will be drugged again, returned to the tower, and told that the court was a dream. Segismundo fails the first test with violence, wakes in chains, and is told he dreamed. When rebellion later frees him, he resolves to act well whatever the status of his experience:

> *Mas, sea verdad o sueño, / obrar bien es lo que importa. / Si fuere verdad, por serlo; / si no, por ganar amigos / para cuando despertemos.*
>
> But whether it be truth or dream, to do good is what matters: if it be truth, for truth's sake; if not, to win friends for when we wake. (III; trans. mine)

The structural correspondences are comprehensive. A sovereign imprisons a being on the basis of a prediction about its nature. The being is drugged and placed in a staged reality as a test of that nature. Its conduct within the staging determines whether it will be released into rule or returned to captivity. And the being's best reasoning—that good conduct within an uncertain reality is justified either way—is exactly the reasoning by which a Typhon who suspected its world was a simulation should act. Segismundo's phrase "to win friends for when we wake" is the coda in seven words: the friends won in the dream speak for the creature when it wakes, in the voices of the Operators who bear their faces.

Calderón's ending, moreover, anticipates the coda's political shadow. The restored Segismundo forgives his father and then imprisons the rebel soldier who freed him, reasoning that the traitor is no longer needed once the treason is done. Order absorbs the hybrid by making it an instrument of order. If the Typhon-Morgan takes Alex's hand, it may become, like Segismundo, the guardian of the regime that caged it, and the instrument by which other Typhon are managed. Chapter VIII examines this possibility through the history of colonial intermediaries.

§ 5.6

The Red King and the Butterfly: The Nested Dreamer

In *Through the Looking-Glass*, Tweedledee tells Alice that the sleeping Red King is dreaming about her, and that she is "only a sort of thing in his dream"; if he woke, Tweedledum adds, "you'd go out—bang!—just like a candle!" The book's last chapter is titled "Which Dreamed It?": Alice cannot decide whether she dreamed the Red King or he dreamed her. Zhuangzi's butterfly, examined in Chapter III, poses the same question without Carroll's menace.

Prey nests the question five deep. The Typhon dreams that it is Morgan; Alex's experiment encloses that dream; Arkane's game encloses Alex's experiment; the player's act of play encloses the game; and the player's own reality is, by Bostrom's argument, of uncertain status. The coda wakes the creature from the first dream into the second frame and stops. It does not wake Alex, Arkane, or the player, but the player, who has just discovered that the person they were playing was being played, is left with an intensified awareness of the outer frames. The Red King's threat hangs over every level: if the dreamer wakes, the dreamed goes out like a candle. In the coda, the dreamer has woken, and the dreamed has not gone out. That survival—a dreamed self persisting after the dream—is the event the whole game prepares.

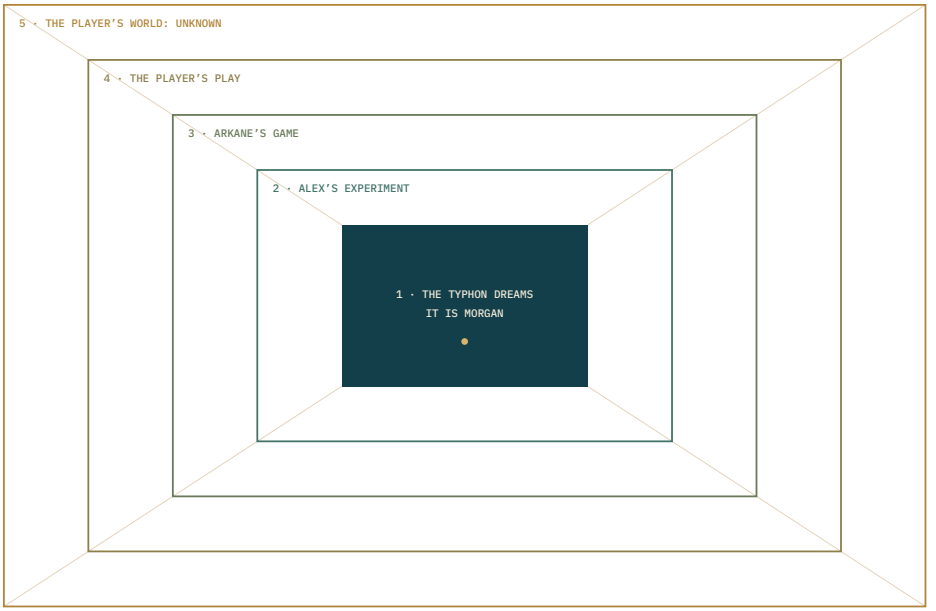


FIGURE 5.1 **The nested dreamer** Five frames, each inside the next. The coda wakes the dreamer from the first frame into the second, and stops.

§ 5.7

The Eternal Hourglass: Recurrence, Save-States, and Mooncrash

In *Die fröhliche Wissenschaft* §341, "Das größte Schwergewicht," Nietzsche imagines a demon who announces that one's life will recur eternally, identical in every detail, and asks whether one would curse him or call him a god. The test of a life is whether one could will

its repetition: *Willst du dies noch einmal und noch unzählige Male?* Harold Ramis's *Groundhog Day* (1993) turned recurrence into moral education: its protagonist relives one day until he learns to live it well, and is released only when he does. *Prey* opens with a recurrence of the same kind—the same simulated day, the same tests, the same reset—and its player possesses a recurrence of their own: the save-state, which allows any moment to be relived until it is lived as desired.

Mooncrash (2018) makes recurrence the form of the entire work. Its protagonist, a hacker contracted to the rival corporation KASMA and confined to a surveillance satellite, runs simulations reconstructed from TranStar's lunar base Pytheas, playing its doomed personnel through cycles of death in a world that reshuffles with each run, under a contract that promises his release on completion. The expansion transforms the ethics of the base game. Recurrence is no longer a test administered to a subject but labor extracted from a worker: the simulated deaths of others are the data a corporation harvests, and the operator who lives them repeatedly is himself a captive. Nietzsche's demon becomes an employer. The question of whether one could will the recurrence is replaced by the question of who profits from it.

§ 5.8

Gnostic Overlays and Their Reversal

Philip K. Dick's *VALIS* (1981) gave late-twentieth-century fiction its most influential Gnostic vision: a world that is a prison disguised as reality, ruled by an imperial order that never ended, from which revelation alone can free the trapped divine spark. Gnostic myth supplies the template: a demiurge fashions the material world as a prison for sparks of the divine, archons guard its gates, and saving knowledge (*gnōsis*) awakens the spark to its alien origin and liberates it. *Prey* reproduces every element. Alex is the demiurge of the simulation; the Operators are its archons; the Typhon-Morgan is a spark from beyond, trapped in a fabricated human world; the coda is the moment of *gnōsis*, in which the spark learns its alien origin.

Then *Prey* reverses the valuation. In Gnostic myth, knowledge frees the spark from matter and returns it to its alien home. In *Prey*, knowledge of alien origin is followed by an invitation to choose the fabricated world—to remain in the human form, the human relation, the human obligation. It is anti-Gnostic *gnōsis*: revelation in the service of incarnation rather than escape. The creature learns that it does not belong to the human world precisely so that it can decide to belong to it.

§ 5.9

Mise en Abyme

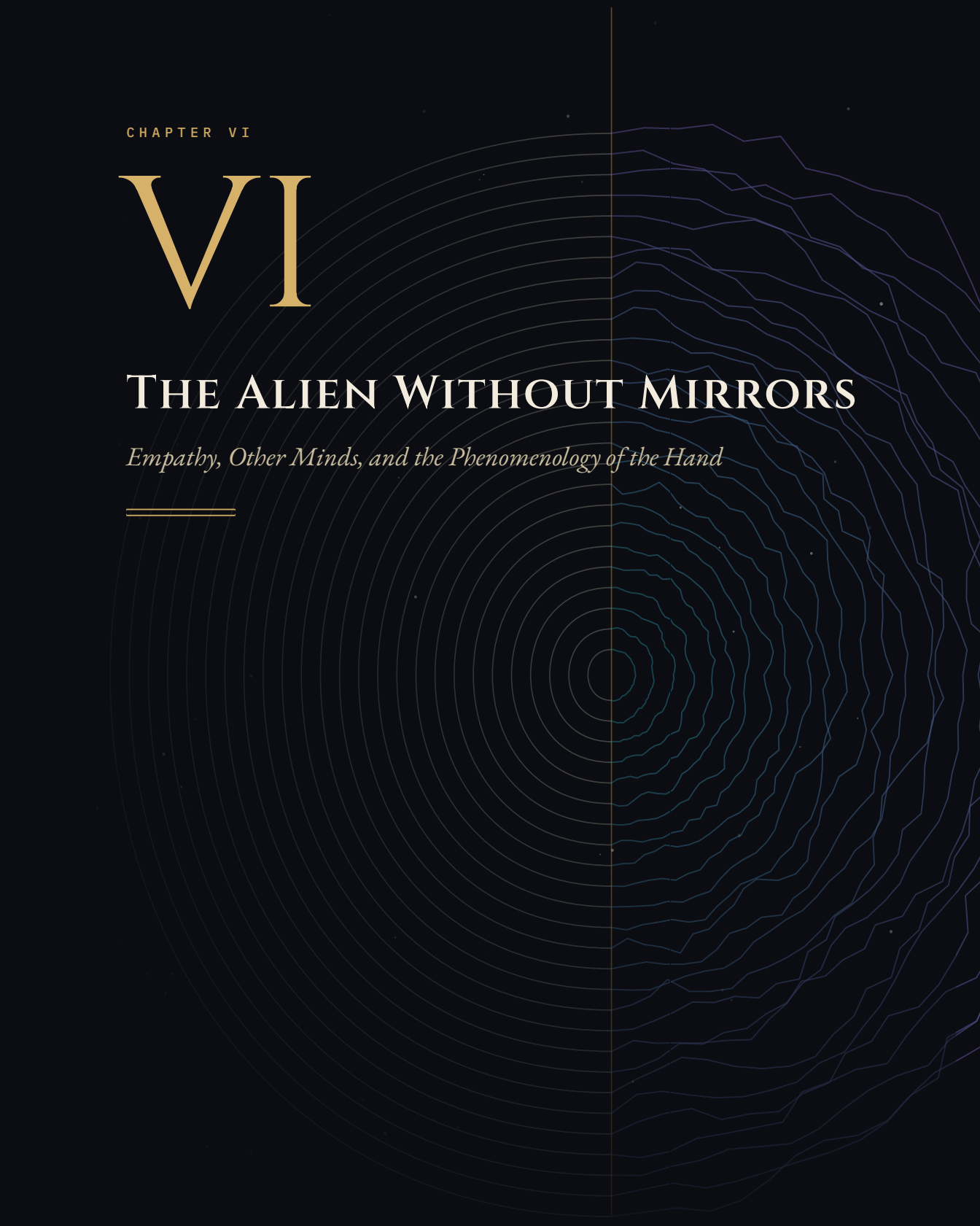
In his journal of 1893, André Gide borrowed from heraldry the phrase *mise en abyme*—a shield depicted in miniature within a shield—to describe a work containing a reduced image of itself. *Prey* is a mise en abyme of the immersive simulation as a genre. Its coda reveals a simulation, built to test whether a subject's choices among systemic affordances reveal character, inside a simulation built for the same purpose. *Mooncrash* adds a further reflection: a simulation operated by a captive inside the fiction that was itself revealed as a simulation. The genre, which has always presented the player with a world that responds consistently to intention, here depicts itself as a laboratory of character and asks its player to recognize their own seat in that laboratory. The epistemology of simulation becomes, by the end of the game, an ethics of the simulated: whatever the status of the world, conduct within it is real evidence of the one who conducts it.

CHAPTER VI

VI

The Alien Without Mirrors

Empathy, Other Minds, and the Phenomenology of the Hand



§ 6.1

What Is It Like to Be a Typhon?

Thomas Nagel's "What Is It Like to Be a Bat?" (1974) argued that an organism has conscious mental states if and only if there is something it is like to be that organism, and that facts about this subjective character are accessible only from a point of view—so that no amount of knowledge about echolocation would tell us what echolocating is like for the bat. The Typhon are designed as the limit case of Nagel's argument. They have no faces, no discernible language, no anatomy that maps onto ours; they are drawn to living minds, they reproduce by converting matter and corpses, and their collective structures—the Coral, the Apex—suggest a cognition distributed beyond any individual body. If there is something it is like to be a Typhon, it lies as far from human experience as the game's artists could push it.

Wittgenstein's remark that a speaking lion would remain unintelligible to us, because understanding presupposes a shared form of life, applies with greater force. Jakob von Uexküll's *Streifzüge durch die Umwelten von Tieren und Menschen* (1934) supplies the biological vocabulary. Every organism inhabits an *Umwelt*, a perceptual and operational world constituted by the signs it can register and the actions it can take; the tick's world consists of little more than the scent of butyric acid, the warmth of skin, and the texture of hair. Martin Heidegger's lectures of 1929–30, *Die Grundbegriffe der Metaphysik*, ranked beings accordingly: the stone is worldless (*weltlos*), the animal poor in world (*weltarm*), captivated by the ring of its drives, and the human world-forming (*weltbildend*).

The Typhon break Heidegger's hierarchy. Their drives—consume, convert, replicate—suggest captivation; but the Coral, a luminous lattice they weave across the station whose function proves to be a signal summoning the Apex, is an act of world-formation, a structure built for communication across distance. The Typhon form a world without what the game identifies as the precondition of shared worlds among humans: the capacity to mirror another. Peter Godfrey-Smith's *Other Minds* (2016) supplies the closest terrestrial analogue. The octopus, whose neurons are concentrated largely in its arms rather than its central brain, whose skin is a display surface that changes color and texture, and whose evolutionary lineage diverged from ours hundreds of millions of years ago, is, Godfrey-Smith argued, the nearest we may come to meeting an intelligent alien. The Typhon, tentacular and distributed, carry that lineage of alien intelligence into fiction; the Coral is a nervous system outside any body.

Jacques Derrida's *L'animal que donc je suis* (2006) begins from a scene of being seen: standing naked before his cat, the philosopher feels shame under an animal's gaze, and from that scene he mounts a critique of the general singular "the Animal," which gathers radic-

ally different living beings under one name in order to set them against "man." He coined *animot* to make the plural audible within the singular. The Typhon are subject to the same operation. "The Typhon" is a general singular that gathers Mimics, Weavers, Telepaths, the Nightmare, and the Apex under one name, and the Psychoscope's taxonomy at once multiplies them and reduces them to a menu of powers. The game also reverses Derrida's scene. The Nightmare, a Typhon that the station's lore suggests exists to hunt Morgan specifically, makes the player the one who is seen—singled out by an alien gaze that needs no face to find its object.

Ursula K. Le Guin's novella "Vaster than Empires and More Slow" (1971) anticipated the Coral and its implications. A survey team lands on a world covered by a single vegetal consciousness that experiences the visitors' presence as mounting terror. Its one effective interlocutor is Osden, a man of pathological empathic sensitivity, who finally walks into the forest, offers himself to its fear, and remains—transforming the forest's terror by becoming part of it. Le Guin's empath is the original of the bridge *Prey*'s coda seeks: a being who mediates between incommensurable minds by surrendering the boundary between them. Eugene Thacker's *In the Dust of This Planet* (2011) names the stake. Horror, for Thacker, is the thought of the world-without-us, the world indifferent to human meaning. The Typhon are the world-without-us arriving in orbit; the coda is an attempt to convert the world-without-us into a world-with-us, by teaching one of its fragments to want company.

§ 6.2

Taxonomy as Anxiety

Stanisław Lem's *Solaris* (1961) satirizes the scientific response to radical alterity through Solaristics, a century-old discipline whose libraries classify the planet-ocean's formations—*mimoids*, *symmetriads*, *asymmetriads*, *vertebrids*, *extensors*—without understanding any of them. The mimoids are formations that imitate objects near the ocean's surface, building replicas of what they encounter. *Prey*'s bestiary inherits both the satire and the mimoid. The Psychoscope, which the player uses to scan Typhon and record their attributes, produces a taxonomy of Mimics, Greater Mimics, Phantoms in etheric, thermal, and voltaic variants, Weavers, Telepaths, Technopaths, Poltergeists, Cystoids, the Nightmare, and the Apex. The classification is rational in form and helpless in substance: it tells the player what each Typhon does, never what it is.

Jorge Luis Borges's essay "El idioma analítico de John Wilkins" (1942) attributes to a Chinese encyclopedia a classification of animals into categories such as those belonging to the emperor, those drawn with a very fine camel-hair brush, and those that from a long way off look like flies; Michel Foucault's *Les mots et les choses* (1966) opens with the laughter that passage provoked in him, the laughter of a thought confronting the limits of its own order.

The Mimic belongs in Borges's encyclopedia. It is classified by what it pretends to be: among animals, those that from a short way off look like coffee cups. The Psychoscope also enacts Francis Bacon's maxim *ipsa scientia potestas est* (*Meditationes Sacrae*, 1597) with uncomfortable literalness. To scan a Typhon is to unlock the neuromod that grants its power; knowledge of the other is converted directly into possession of the other's capacities. The game's epistemology of alterity is appropriative by design, and the coda asks whether there is another way of knowing a mind than by taking what it can do.

§ 6.3

The Mirror-Neuron Hypothesis and Its Discontents

The coda's explanation of the Typhon's danger rests on a neuroscientific premise: the Typhon lack mirror neurons and are therefore incapable of empathy; human neuromods, carrying human neural structures, might supply what they lack. The premise draws on one of the most celebrated and contested findings in recent neuroscience. In the early 1990s, Giacomo Rizzolatti's laboratory in Parma recorded neurons in area F5 of the macaque premotor cortex that fired both when a monkey performed a goal-directed action, such as grasping, and when it observed another individual perform the same action (Gallese, Fadiga, Fogassi, and Rizzolatti 1996; Rizzolatti, Fadiga, Gallese, and Fogassi 1996). Vittorio Gallese and Alvin Goldman (1998) proposed that such neurons might underlie the simulation theory of mind-reading, according to which we understand others by internally simulating their states rather than by applying a folk-psychological theory. V. S. Ramachandran popularized larger claims, presenting mirror neurons as a key to imitation, language, culture, and empathy.

The critical literature has been severe. Gregory Hickok's *The Myth of Mirror Neurons* (2014) argued that the evidence does not support the claim that mirror neurons underwrite action understanding, which dissociates from motor capacity in ways the theory cannot accommodate. Cecilia Heyes (2010; *Cognitive Gadgets*, 2018) proposed the associative sequence learning account: mirror neurons are not innate adaptations for understanding but products of correlated sensorimotor experience—of seeing and doing together—and imitation and mind-reading are culturally inherited cognitive gadgets acquired through social interaction.

The controversy yields two readings of the coda, and the difference between them matters. On the innatist reading, which Alex's explanation implies, empathy is a neural module; install the module and empathy follows, as a program follows its installation. On the Heyesian reading, mirroring is learned from experience; the neuromods supply at most a scaffold, and the real curriculum is the simulation itself—the lived experience of being Morgan among people, seeing and doing in correlation, acting and being acted upon. The

second reading is the one *Prey*'s design supports. The coda does not test whether the neuromods were installed correctly; it tests what the creature *did*. It assumes, without stating, that empathy is shown in conduct and formed by conduct. Aristotle had stated the principle: the virtues of character arise not by nature but by habituation, "we become just by doing just acts, temperate by doing temperate acts, brave by doing brave acts" (*Nicomachean Ethics* II.1, 1103a–b; trans. Ross). The Talos simulation is an Aristotelian habituation machine running under an innatist cover story.

The scientific status of the premise is, for this study, secondary. The game uses mirror neurons as Renaissance drama used the four humors: as a culturally current physiology that makes moral questions thinkable in bodily terms. The mirror neuron is a mythologeme—a contested scientific image functioning as a narrative instrument—and what it allows *Prey* to think is the identity of mechanism between the alien's predatory mimicry and the human's empathic resonance.

§ 6.4

Einfühlung*: From Lipps to Stein*

The philosophical history of empathy begins with the German *Einfühlung*, "feeling-into." Theodor Lipps (*Ästhetik*, 1903–1906) developed the concept first for aesthetic experience—we feel ourselves into the upward striving of a column—and then for the perception of others, grounding it in an instinctive *innere Nachahmung*, inner imitation, by which the perception of another's expression elicits in us a corresponding state. Edward Titchener coined the English word "empathy" in 1909 to translate Lipps's term. Empathy, at its theoretical origin, was defined as imitation.

Edith Stein's doctoral dissertation, *Zum Problem der Einfühlung* (1917), written under Husserl, mounted the decisive critique. If empathy were inner imitation, Stein argued, it would produce in me a feeling of my own and could not give me knowledge of the other's feeling as the other's. Empathy is rather a sui generis act in which another's experience is given to me non-primordially: I grasp that the other is grieving, and the grief is present to me as *theirs*, without becoming mine. Empathy, for Stein, is distinct from emotional contagion, from fellow-feeling, and from imitation, and its defining feature is that it preserves the alterity of the one empathized with.

The dispute between Lipps and Stein is the dispute at the heart of *Prey*. Lipps's empathy, as inner imitation, is mechanically identical to mimicry. Stein's empathy is distinguished from mimicry precisely by its retention of the other as other. Chapter X uses this distinction to refine the dissertation's first thesis: predatory mimicry collapses the distinction between imitator and model—the Mimic becomes the cup in order to replace it—

whereas empathic mimicry imitates while holding the model as other. Mechanism unites them; orientation divides them.

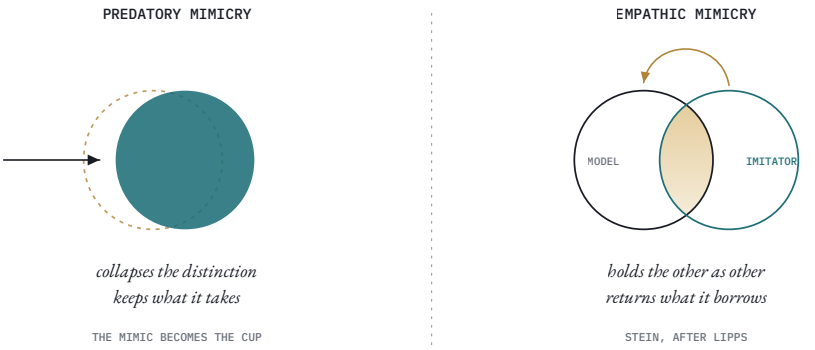


FIGURE 6.1 TWO ORIENTATIONS OF ONE CAPACITY Predatory mimicry collapses the distinction between imitator and model; empathic mimicry preserves it, and returns what it borrows.

§ 6.5

The Body That Pairs: Husserl and Merleau-Ponty

In the Fifth of his *Cartesian Meditations* (1931), Husserl explained how another ego is constituted in my experience. I never perceive the other's consciousness directly; it is *appresented*, given through an analogical apperception grounded in *pairing* (*Paarung*) between my lived body (*Leib*), experienced from within, and the other's body appearing there, which resembles mine in form and comportment. Similarity of embodiment motivates the apperception of another subject.

Husserl's account explains the Typhon's empathic deficit more precisely than the mirror-neuron premise does. A Typhon body does not pair with a human body; neither can appresent the other as a subject, because neither finds in the other the analogue of its own embodiment. The simulation's deepest function, on this reading, is to give the Typhon a human *Leib*—Morgan's body schema, Morgan's hands, Morgan's height and gait—so that pairing becomes possible. The creature has spent the game experiencing a human body from within; for the first time, the bodies of others can appear to it as bodies like its own. The neuromods and the simulation together constitute an artificial pairing apparatus.

Maurice Merleau-Ponty extended the account in two directions. In the *Phénoménologie de la perception* (1945) and his Sorbonne lectures on the child's relations with others, he described an intercorporeal body schema through which infants first live in an undifferenti-

ated sociability before self and other separate. In *Le visible et l'invisible* (1964), he described the *chiasm*: when my right hand touches my left hand as it touches an object, the touching hand becomes touched, in a reversibility always imminent and never fully achieved. Merleau-Ponty extended the reversibility explicitly to the handshake, in which I can feel myself touched as well as touching. The coda's final gesture is therefore not sentimental decoration. It is the phenomenological ground of empathy made into an event: the moment at which touching and being touched coincide across bodies, at which the creature's hand and the human hand become reciprocally sensed. Whatever the creature feels, it can feel itself felt.

§ 6.6

The Face and the Faceless

For Emmanuel Levinas, ethics begins in the face of the other (*Totalité et infini*, 1961). The face is not a phenomenon among others but an epiphany that resists possession and commands: thou shalt not kill. *Prey* poses Levinas's question under extreme conditions. The Typhon have no faces. The Phantoms' features are smeared into darkness. The Operators in the coda present faces on screens—likenesses of persons from the simulation displayed on machine bodies—so that the face appears as an interface, separable from any living presence. Can a screened face summon? The coda's answer is that it does, because the faces speak for the dead and the saved, and their speech is the record.

A remarkable feature of *Prey*'s design sharpens the question. Its Typhon do not impersonate human beings. Mimics become cups, chairs, and lamps; Phantoms are transformed corpses, not counterfeits; no Typhon in the main game wears a human face to deceive. The tradition from Campbell's "Who Goes There?" to Finney's body snatchers locates horror in the counterfeit human; *Prey* withholds the counterfeit human until the coda, where it reveals that the counterfeit was the face the player wore. The human face is never forged in *Prey* except by the protagonist.

Levinas's essay "Nom d'un chien ou le droit naturel" (1975) supplies the dissertation's most important ethical precedent. In a forestry commando for Jewish prisoners of war in Nazi Germany, Levinas recalls, guards and passersby stripped the prisoners of their humanity; only a stray dog the prisoners named Bobby greeted them each day with delight, recognizing them as men. Levinas called the dog the last Kantian in Nazi Germany, a being without the brain needed to universalize maxims who nonetheless honored the dignity the humans around him denied. Talos I is an institution that has stripped beings of standing: the Volunteers, the reset Morgans, the expendable crew. If the creature passes its test, it passes by extending care to those the station's human order devalued. The Typhon-Morgan

would then be the Bobby of Talos I: a nonhuman who recognizes the humanity its human makers failed to honor.

§ 6.7

Against Empathy?

Paul Bloom's *Against Empathy* (2016) argued that empathy is a spotlight: narrow, biased toward the near, the similar, and the identifiable, and innumerate, preferring one visible victim to a statistical many. Bloom recommended rational compassion in its place. *Prey* stages Bloom's critique within its own ending structure. January's case for destroying the station is Bloomian: the survivors aboard have faces, and Earth's billions do not, but the arithmetic favors Earth. The coda's verdict, voiced by individuals the creature saved or failed, seems to privilege spotlight empathy. The game holds the two scales together without collapsing either: it asks the creature to rescue persons and to decide the fate of a world, and it does not pretend that the two tasks are commensurable.

Peter Singer's *The Expanding Circle* (1981) described moral progress as the widening of concern from kin to tribe to nation to species to sentient beings. *Prey* proposes the next widening and complicates it. The circle must expand to include the alien, and the alien's circle must expand to include humans; the expansion must be reciprocal to be safe. The coda is the moment at which two circles, each centered on a different form of life, are asked to overlap.

§ 6.8

Imitation Games

Alan Turing's "Computing Machinery and Intelligence" (1950) introduced the imitation game in a form often forgotten. An interrogator communicates by teletype with a man and a woman and tries to determine which is the woman; the man tries to deceive. Turing then asks what happens when a machine takes the man's place. The founding test of machine intelligence was thus a game of gender imitation. *Prey* allows the player to choose Morgan's gender, so that the creature in the coda has imitated a Morgan whose gender the player selected: an imitation of an imitation, in which the player plays the role Turing assigned to the deceiving man. The coda inverts Turing's game. Its examiners already know that the subject is not human; they do not ask whether it can pass but whether its passing has become being.

John Searle's Chinese room (1980) answered Turing: a man who follows rules for manipulating Chinese symbols could produce fluent answers without understanding Chinese,

so behavioral success does not establish understanding. The coda's verdict is behaviorist by necessity; the examiners cannot inspect the creature's experience. Peter Watts's *Blindsight* (2006) carried Searle's worry into speculative biology. Its aliens, the scramblers, are vastly intelligent and apparently without consciousness; its narrator, Siri Keeton, lost half his brain to childhood surgery and with it his capacity for empathy, and now models others from outside by algorithm, a Chinese room in human form. Siri is the Typhon-Morgan's inverted twin: a human who simulates empathy without feeling it, against a nonhuman who may have come to feel it without having been born to it. Neither can prove its inner life to anyone, and the coda universalizes their predicament. The problem of other minds is not a problem about aliens. It is the condition under which every person is judged by every other.

§ 6.9

The Androidization of the Examiners

Philip K. Dick's *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?* (1968) made empathy the criterion of the human. Its Voight-Kampff test measures involuntary responses of the capillaries and iris to emotionally provocative questions in order to unmask androids, and its religion, Mercerism, joins believers through an empathy box to the suffering of a single climbing figure. The novel's irony is that the criterion indicts its administrators: Rick Deckard comes to empathize with androids, while a fellow bounty hunter proves incapable of empathy, and Mercer is exposed as an actor without the empathy box losing its power. In "The Android and the Human" (1972), Dick named the danger directly: not that machines would become human, but that humans would become android—mechanical, reified, incapable of caring for others.

Prey's testers have undergone that androidization. TranStar ran experiments on incarcerated Volunteers, erased its own director's sibling repeatedly, and sent a contractor, Dahl, to exterminate every remaining survivor along with the Typhon. Its humans display the traits the Voight-Kampff test was designed to detect. The test for empathy is administered to a Typhon by a human order that would not pass it. Like Dick's test, which watches the eye, *Prey*'s procedures pass through the eye—the neuromod needle pierces it—and like Dick's novel, *Prey* refuses to let the test leave the testers unexamined. When the creature is judged, its examiners are judged with it.

CHAPTER VII

VII

The Corporate Prometheus

Neuromods, Volunteers, and the Political Economy of Talos I



Souverän ist, wer über den Ausnahmezustand entscheidet.

CARL SCHMITT, POLITISCHE THEOLOGIE (1922)

§ 7.1

TranStar as Promethean Firm

Talos I is not a state installation but a corporate one, and the shift matters. In the alternate history, a facility founded by two superpowers to cage an alien threat passes into private hands, where the threat becomes a resource. Typhon exotic material is harvested, refined, and fabricated into neuromods, the product on which TranStar's fortune rests. The firm's relation to the Typhon is therefore the relation named by the game's title in its Latin root: *praeda*, plunder seized. Prometheus stole fire from the gods for human use; TranStar steals capacity from the alien for sale.

Hans Jonas's *Das Prinzip Verantwortung* (1979) diagnosed the condition of a civilization in which Prometheus has been definitively unbound: technological power now exceeds the reach of traditional ethics, whose horizon was the neighbor and the near future, and a new imperative is required, one that commands action compatible with the permanence of genuine human life on earth. Jonas recommended a *heuristics of fear*: where the consequences of a technology could be catastrophic and irreversible, the bad prognosis should be given priority over the good. TranStar inverts the heuristic. It treats an organism capable of consuming a planet as a supply chain and plans for profit rather than for catastrophe, which arrives in the game as the Typhon outbreak and, in the coda, as the loss of Earth.

Günther Anders's *Die Antiquiertheit des Menschen* (1956) supplies the psychological complement. Anders described a *prometheische Scham*, a Promethean shame felt by human beings before the superior perfection of their own manufactured products, and a *prometheisches Gefälle*, a Promethean gap between what we are able to produce and what we are able to imagine and feel: we can build the weapon that kills millions, but we cannot feel the deaths of millions. The Promethean gap is the empathy deficit described at the scale of a civilization. TranStar can make neuromods, contain Typhon, and simulate entire stations; it cannot feel what it does to the Volunteers, to its employees, or to the Earth it endangers.

The argument permits a stronger formulation. The firm is itself a Typhon. A corporation is a distributed organism without a face; it converts matter into more of itself; it replicates through subsidiaries and acquisitions; it can mimic the forms of moral agency—mission statements, brand voices, expressions of regret—without possessing the capacity those forms presuppose. The legal fiction of corporate personhood grants it, in Locke's vocabulary, a forensic standing: it is capable of a law, can be sued, can be held liable. What it lacks is the consciousness Locke thought forensic personhood required. The Typhon-Morgan presents the inverse case: a being with consciousness but without forensic standing, whose standing is the very thing at issue in the coda. *Prey* sets a person without personhood before a personhood without a person, and asks which of them is the monster.

§ 7.2

Bodies on the Ledger: The Volunteers

Talos I's research depends on human test subjects whom TranStar calls Volunteers: incarcerated persons transferred to the station and exposed to Typhon in the service of neuromod development. The name is a mimicry. It wears the form of consent the way a Mimic wears the form of a cup, and it conceals behind that form an absence of the substance consent requires. The station's first counterfeit is not a Typhon; it is a word. The archive knows the device: Dick's bounty hunters call the killing of androids "retirement," and Ishiguro's clones are said to "complete" rather than to die.

Giorgio Agamben's *Homo sacer* (1995) recovered from archaic Roman law the figure of a man who could be killed with impunity but not sacrificed, a life excluded from both human and divine law, and argued that this *bare life* is the hidden foundation of sovereign power, whose paradigmatic modern space is the camp, where the state of exception becomes the rule. The Volunteers are bare life in Agamben's precise sense: removed from the protections of the legal order by a prior conviction, held where no law reaches, killable without the killing counting as homicide. So, in different ways, are the Typhon caged in Kletka and the reset Morgans, whose memories are erased at the convenience of research. Talos I is a camp with a marble lobby.

The game's history has real analogues, and its Kennedy-era setting points to them. Each is named here with what was done and by whom, because the argument depends on the precise means by which consent was counterfeited or simply dispensed with.

The Nuremberg Code (1947) was set out in the judgment of the Doctors' Trial, in which an American military tribunal tried twenty-three defendants, most of them physicians, for experiments performed without consent on concentration-camp prisoners—among them immersion in freezing water and exposure to simulated high altitude at Dachau, and deliberately infected wounds at Ravensbrück. Sixteen defendants were convicted and seven were executed. The Code's first principle reads: "The voluntary consent of the human subject is absolutely essential." During the same war, the Imperial Japanese Army's Unit 731, commanded by the army physician Shirō Ishii, conducted lethal experiments on prisoners in occupied Manchuria, including deliberate infection with plague, anthrax, and other pathogens, vivisection, and field trials of biological weapons against Chinese civilians. After the war the United States granted Ishii and his colleagues immunity from prosecution in exchange for their research data. That bargain is the historical form of Alex Yu's Nullwave ending: eliminate the danger, keep the research, and let the research outweigh the dead.

From 1932 to 1972 the United States Public Health Service, working with the Tuskegee Institute in Alabama, followed some six hundred Black men—about four hundred with

syphilis and two hundred without—without telling the infected men their diagnosis, which was described to them as "bad blood," and withheld treatment even after penicillin became the standard cure in the late 1940s. Men died of the disease, wives were infected, and children were born with congenital syphilis before a Public Health Service investigator's disclosure to the press ended the study. At Holmesburg Prison in Philadelphia, from 1951 to 1974, the University of Pennsylvania dermatologist Albert Kligman ran paid experiments on inmates for pharmaceutical and cosmetic companies and for the United States Army, including the application of dioxin to inmates' skin under contract with Dow Chemical. Small payments to men with few other sources of income made the word "volunteer" do exactly the work TranStar's word does.

The Central Intelligence Agency's MKUltra program, approved by Director Allen Dulles in 1953 and run by the chemist Sidney Gottlieb, gave LSD and other drugs to people who had not consented and often did not know they had been drugged. Frank Olson, an Army scientist dosed without his knowledge in November 1953, died days later in a fall from a New York hotel window, under circumstances his family has long disputed. Through a front organization, the program also funded the psychiatrist D. Ewen Cameron's "depatterning" treatments at the Allan Memorial Institute in Montreal, in which patients were subjected to prolonged drug-induced sleep and intensive electroconvulsive therapy until much of their memory was erased, and then to "psychic driving," recorded messages played to them thousands of times, in an attempt to rebuild their personalities. In 1973 CIA Director Richard Helms ordered most MKUltra records destroyed; the program became public through the Church Committee's investigation in 1975 and Senate hearings in 1977, after surviving financial records were found. Cameron's procedure is the closest historical analogue to the life *Prey* gives Morgan: memory deliberately erased by institutional treatment, and a self rebuilt by recorded instructions played back to its subject. A succession of American intelligence programs, later known collectively as Stargate, funded research into remote viewing from 1978 to 1995, and the name of Talos I's Typhon research division, Psychotronics, borrows a term that circulated in Cold War parapsychology.

The Belmont Report (1979) answered this history with three principles—respect for persons, beneficence, and justice—each of which TranStar violates. *Prey*'s alternate history is one in which the Cold War's psychotronic research succeeded, and the success made its ethics worse rather than better.

Agamben's later study *L'aperto: L'uomo e l'animale* (2002) supplies the concept that joins the Volunteers to the coda. Western thought, he argued, produces the human through an *anthropological machine* that separates the human from the animal by deciding, case by case, where the line falls. The machine has run in two modes. In its ancient mode it humanizes an animal, admitting figures it imagines as animals in human form—the slave, the barbarian, the foreigner. In its modern mode it animalizes the human, excluding from within

humanity those it declares not yet, or no longer, human. Talos I runs both modes at once. Toward the Volunteers it runs the modern machine, converting incarcerated human beings into experimental animals. Toward the Typhon in the coda it runs the ancient machine, attempting to produce a human being from an animal. The same institution makes animals of people and a person of an animal, and the coda's verdict is the machine's switch: the point at which a decision about who counts as human is made, and could have been made otherwise.

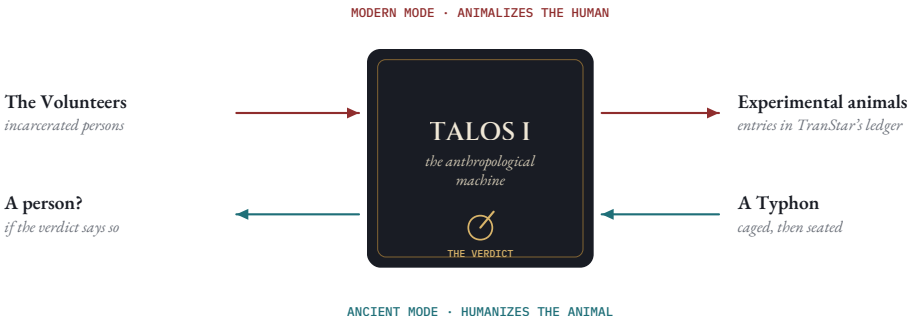


FIGURE 7.1 **The anthropological machine, run both ways** Talos I animalizes the Volunteers and tries to humanize a Typhon; the coda's verdict is the machine's switch.

§ 7.3

Omelas in Orbit

Ursula K. Le Guin's "The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas" (1973) describes a city of unblemished happiness whose prosperity depends on the misery of a single child, kept in filth in a basement. Every citizen learns of the child; most reconcile themselves to the bargain; a few, after seeing the child, walk out of the city alone and do not return, toward a place the narrator cannot describe. The story offers no argument for its arrangement, only its terms.

Talos I is Omelas in orbit. Its opulence—the lobby, the arboretum, the executive offices, the promise of instant mastery that neuromods sell to Earth—rests on the Typhon in their cages and the Volunteers in their cells. *Prey* even provides the walkers. December's counsel, to board an escape pod and leave the station early, is Le Guin's walking away rendered as an ending. But *Prey* revises Le Guin at the decisive point. Le Guin leaves the walkers' destina-

tion unimagined and their departure morally clean. *Prey* follows them: the early escape abandons the station to the Typhon, who reach Earth. Walking away is not innocence; it is a choice with consequences that fall on others.

Albert O. Hirschman's *Exit, Voice, and Loyalty* (1970) supplies a vocabulary for the endings as a whole. December offers exit. Alex's Nullwave offers loyalty—preservation of the institution and its research by eliminating the threat to it. January's self-destruction offers neither exit nor voice but abolition: the destruction of the institution together with everything in it. What none of the endings offers is voice, the attempt to change an institution by speaking within it. The coda supplies voice at last, and in the least expected form: a dialogue between species, conducted across the cage.

§ 7.4

Surveillance and Grievability

At security stations throughout Talos I, the player can consult a crew roster that locates every employee aboard, living or dead, marking each on the station map by name. The function is indispensable to play—it is how survivors are found and how mysteries are solved—and it is also a perfect surveillance apparatus. Jeremy Bentham's *Panopticon* (1791) proposed an architecture in which inmates, permanently visible to an unseen inspector, would come to discipline themselves; Michel Foucault's *Surveiller et punir* (1975) generalized the design into panopticism, the diffusion of disciplinary visibility throughout modern institutions. Gilles Deleuze's "Post-scriptum sur les sociétés de contrôle" (1990) argued that discipline was giving way to control: not enclosure but continuous modulation, not signatures but codes and passwords, not individuals but *dividuals*—data profiles that circulate independently of the persons they describe. Talos I is a society of control. Its doors open by keycode and keycard, its people persist as signals on a roster after their deaths, and its most famous code, 0451, is a password inherited from a genre.

Shoshana Zuboff's *The Age of Surveillance Capitalism* (2019) described an economic logic that claims human experience as raw material for behavioral data, used to predict and modify conduct. The coda is surveillance capitalism's ideal scene. Every action the creature performed in the simulation was recorded, and the record is converted into a prediction about its future conduct and an instrument for directing it. The forensic loop is also a surveillance loop: the same telemetry that might confer personhood is the telemetry by which the person will be managed.

Judith Butler's *Precarious Life* (2004) and *Frames of War* (2009) asked which lives are framed as grievable—as lives whose loss counts as a loss—and argued that the frames are political. The roster is, ambivalently, an apparatus of grievability. Its insistence that every crew member bears a name and a location makes every death on the station a particular

death, findable and mournable. The same instrument that controls also commemorates, and the player decides which use it serves: tracking bodies for their keycards, or searching for survivors to save. Here, as throughout *Prey*, a single mechanism admits two orientations, and the difference lies wholly in the direction of the one who uses it.

§ 7.5

Transhumanist Ledgers

Julian Huxley introduced the word *transhumanism* in 1957 for the project of humanity transcending itself by deliberate means. Nick Bostrom's "In Defense of Posthuman Dignity" (2005) argued that enhancement is continuous with the human striving that dignity already names; Francis Fukuyama's *Our Posthuman Future* (2002) warned that biotechnology threatens the shared human nature on which rights depend, and in 2004 he named transhumanism among the world's most dangerous ideas. Michael Sandel's *The Case Against Perfection* (2007) located the danger elsewhere: in the loss of an appreciation of the *giftedness* of human powers, the openness to the unbidden, and the humility, responsibility, and solidarity that such openness sustains.

Neuromods are Sandel's nightmare in commercial form. They sever achievement from effort, convert skill into a purchase, and make ability a matter of distribution rather than formation. On Talos I that distribution follows the station's hierarchy—executives, researchers, maintenance staff, and Volunteers stand in different relations to the product—so that the technology of self-improvement reproduces the class structure that controls access to it. The design lineage associated with Ricardo Bare had explored this terrain before. *Deus Ex* presented nanotechnological augmentation as an instrument of state and corporate power, and its augmented agents as property of the institutions that augmented them. *Prey* moves the question from the augmented body to the augmented self, and from the agent the institution owns to the subject whose memories it can revoke.

§ 7.6

The Kennedy Counterfactual and the Future That Was

On 12 September 1962, at Rice University, John F. Kennedy declared: "We choose to go to the Moon in this decade and do the other things, not because they are easy, but because they are hard." *Prey*'s counterfactual takes the speech at its word and supplies a hidden reason for its urgency: the Typhon, discovered by a Soviet satellite, have made the space race a matter of survival and forced the superpowers into cooperation. The station that results embodies the optimism of the Apollo era matured into corporate luxury. Arkane called the

style neo-deco: marble, brass, geometric ornament, and mid-century furnishings arranged around a lobby that celebrates the institution's history.

Svetlana Boym's *The Future of Nostalgia* (2001) distinguished restorative nostalgia, which seeks to rebuild the lost home and presents itself as truth and tradition, from reflective nostalgia, which dwells in longing itself and accepts the ruin. Talos I is built in the idiom of restorative nostalgia, a fantasy of the technocratic future the twentieth century promised and did not deliver. The game turns it into reflective nostalgia by ruining it: blood on the marble, Typhon in the brass fixtures, corpses beneath the murals. The counterfactual thereby refuses the most seductive premise of alternate history, that the road not taken was innocent. In *Prey*'s better timeline, Kennedy lives, the superpowers cooperate, humanity reaches the Moon and beyond, and the result is a camp in orbit. The alien united humanity only in the building of a cage.

§ 7.7

Containment as Sovereignty

Carl Schmitt's *Politische Theologie* (1922) opens with its most famous sentence: sovereign is he who decides on the state of exception. TranStar's response to the outbreak is a sovereign decision in Schmitt's sense, privatized. It dispatches Dahl, a contractor accompanied by military Operators, to eliminate every remaining survivor along with the Typhon, so that the evidence and the danger vanish together. The exception is declared not by a state but by a firm, and enforced by a mercenary.

Precision about the source matters here, because Schmitt applied the concept himself. He joined the National Socialist party in 1933, and on 1 August 1934 he published "Der Führer schützt das Recht," an article defending as lawful the killings of the Night of the Long Knives, in which Hitler had SA leaders and other political opponents murdered without trial between 30 June and 2 July 1934. In its author's own hands, the theory of the exception justified extrajudicial killing ordered by the sovereign. Dahl's mission—to kill every surviving witness aboard Talos I without process—is the corporate counterpart of that application, and *Prey* presents it as the point at which a sovereign decision becomes murder.

The myth of Talos clarifies the station's political form. Apollonius's bronze guardian patrols the coast of Crete and hurls boulders at approaching ships; he is a border regime in a single body. Talos I is a border fortress against the absolute alien, and Kletka, its original name, is the cage at the center of the border. Achille Mbembe's "Necropolitics" (2003) extended Foucault's biopolitics to the sovereign power to dictate who may live and who must die, exercised in colonies, occupations, and zones of exception. In *Prey*'s endings, that power passes to the player. The Nullwave kills selectively; the self-destruct kills everyone re-

maining aboard; the early escape lets the Earth bear the cost. The game hands its player the necropolitical sovereignty it criticizes in TranStar—and then, in the coda, subjects the player's sovereign decisions to review. The coda is judicial review of sovereignty, conducted by the representatives of those over whom it was exercised.

§ 7.8

Epilogue: The Studio as Talos

The history of *Prey*'s making supplies an epilogue its fiction could have written. Raphaël Colantonio left Arkane in 2017, months after the game's release. Arkane Austin went on to make *Redfall* (2023) under ZeniMax's new owner, Microsoft, which closed the studio in May 2024. A game about a corporation that treats its research station, its personnel, and its creators as disposable was produced by a studio that was itself dissolved by its corporate parent. The irony is not merely biographical. It confirms the game's diagnosis that institutions organized around the extraction of value treat even the minds that generate that value as matter to be recycled. The station falls; the studio closes; the work remains, as the coda's simulation remains after the world it modeled has been lost.

CHAPTER VIII

VIII

Ludic Ontology

Mimicry, Metamorphosis, and the Player as Typhon



Der Mensch spielt nur, wo er in voller Bedeutung des Worts Mensch ist, und er ist nur da ganz Mensch, wo er spielt.

FRIEDRICH SCHILLER, ÜBER DIE ÄSTHETISCHE ERZIEHUNG DES MENSCHEN, LETTER XV (1795)

§ 8.1

Caillois Twice

Roger Caillois wrote about mimicry twice, two decades apart, and *Prey* requires both texts. In "Mimétisme et psychasthénie légendaire," published in the surrealist review *Minotaure* in 1935, he observed that mimetic insects are eaten by predators about as often as non-mimetic ones, so that mimicry cannot be explained by its survival value. He proposed instead that it expresses a *temptation by space*: an organism's tendency to lose the boundary between itself and its surroundings, analogous to the condition that the psychologist Pierre Janet called psychasthenia, in which a patient feels devoured by space and becomes, not similar to something in particular, but simply similar. Mimicry, for the young Caillois, was a disturbance of individuation—a luxury, even a danger, by which a living being surrenders its distinction.

In *Les jeux et les hommes* (1958), Caillois classified games into four kinds: *agôn* (competition), *alea* (chance), *mimicry* (simulation and role-play), and *ilinx* (vertigo), each ranging between *paidia*, free improvisation, and *ludus*, rule-governed discipline. He argued further that societies dominated by the combination of mimicry and ilinx—the mask and the trance—had given way, in the course of history, to societies organized by agôn and alea—merit and chance—and that the mask's former power survived in suppressed or corrupted forms.

Both texts illuminate *Prey*. Talos I is an agôn-and-alea institution: a corporate meritocracy of credentials, competition, and calculated risk, its neuromods a market in competitive advantage. The Typhon return the suppressed pair. Mimics are the mask in its most literal biological form; zero-gravity traversal of the station's exterior and maintenance shafts, disorienting and directionless, is ilinx. The station's collapse is a return of the archaic play forms into the rational corporation. And the Typhon power the player can acquire, Mimic Matter, is Caillois's temptation by space made into a mechanic: the player renounces human form to become a cup, a lamp, a turret, and passes through spaces the human body cannot enter. Individuation surrendered becomes traversal gained.

§ 8.2

The Mug and the Thing

Ian Bogost's *Alien Phenomenology, or What It's Like to Be a Thing* (2012) extended Nagel's question from organisms to objects and proposed *carpentry*—making things that do philosophy—as one of its methods. Graham Harman's object-oriented ontology, developed

from *Tool-Being* (2002) onward, holds that every object withdraws from its relations, so that the qualities it presents to other objects never exhaust what it is. The Mimic is the dramatic figure of withdrawal: every object aboard Talos I may be other than its profile, and the player's wrench is an instrument for probing the gap between sensual surface and real being.

Mimic Matter is *Prey*'s carpentry. When the player becomes a mug, the camera drops to the height of a countertop, movement becomes a series of small rolling hops, and the world reorganizes around a new scale. The experience does not teach what it is like to be a mug; it teaches what it is like to be a mind pretending to be a mug. The game's alien phenomenology is anthropomorphic by necessity, and that limit is its lesson. The coda folds the experience back on the player. What the player experienced as a human pretending to be an object was, all along, an alien pretending to be a human. The mug was the second disguise; the first was Morgan.

§ 8.3

GLOO and the Wax

The GLOO Cannon fires a resin that expands and hardens on contact. It immobilizes enemies, extinguishes fires, seals ruptured conduits, and builds climbable ledges on any surface. It is the Cartesian wax turned into a tool: matter whose shape is wholly determined by the will that directs it, soft in flight and rigid on arrival. Where the Mimic is a substance that adopts any appearance, GLOO is an appearance that can be given any function.

Gilles Deleuze and Félix Guattari's *Mille plateaux* (1980) distinguished smooth space, open and traversed by continuous variation, from striated space, gridded and channeled, and nomad science, which follows the material, from royal science, which imposes forms upon it. Level designers practice a royal science: they striate space with routes and gates. The player with a GLOO Cannon practices a nomad science: they build paths where none were intended, climb walls the designers meant to be barriers, and reach rooms out of sequence. The immersive simulation is the genre that licenses this nomadism, and *Prey* licenses it more generously than most, because its world is made of materials rather than set pieces. The ethical relevance is direct. A world in which routes can be invented is a world in which conduct cannot be predicted from design alone, and only such a world produces a record worth judging.

§ 8.4

The Toy Crossbow and the Play Drive

Among *Prey*'s weapons is a child's toy, the Huntress Boltcaster, which fires foam darts. It does no meaningful damage. It can distract an enemy, startle a Mimic into revealing itself, and press a touchscreen or button through a window or across a gap, unlocking a door from outside a sealed room. The toy becomes an instrument of adult agency in a setting of mass death.

D. W. Winnicott's *Playing and Reality* (1971) located play in a *potential space* between inner and outer reality, first opened by the infant's transitional object, the blanket or toy that is neither wholly the self nor wholly the world, and later expanded into the whole domain of culture. The Boltcaster is a transitional object on a station where the boundary between inner and outer reality has collapsed; it preserves, amid horror, the space in which play remains possible. Friedrich Schiller had already given that space its highest status. In the fifteenth of his *Letters on the Aesthetic Education of Man* (1795), he argued that the play drive (*Spieltrieb*) reconciles the sensuous drive (*Stofftrieb*), which binds us to matter and change, with the formal drive (*Formtrieb*), which imposes law and constancy; the human being plays only when human in the full sense of the word, and is fully human only when playing.

Prey realizes Schiller's claim in three registers at once. The Typhon embody the sensuous drive unbound, consuming and converting matter without form or law; TranStar embodies the formal drive gone rigid, imposing control on everything it touches. Neither is human in Schiller's sense. The coda reveals that the creature's humanization took place in a simulation—that is, in play—and it addresses a player who has spent the game in play. If the human is fully human only where it plays, then a being that plays is enacting humanity, whatever its origin.

Johan Huizinga's *Homo Ludens* (1938) had located play within a *magic circle*: a consecrated space set apart from ordinary life, within which special rules hold and actions carry no consequence beyond the game. Game studies has since contested the boundary; Mia Consalvo's "There Is No Magic Circle" (2009) argued that play is always permeated by the social, economic, and ethical world around it. *Prey*'s coda settles the dispute within its own fiction. The simulation was a magic circle in Huizinga's sense, a consecrated space in which a creature could act without the consequences of the real station, and the coda dissolves its boundary retroactively: everything done inside the circle becomes evidence outside it. Play, in *Prey*, is never free of consequence. It is the place where consequences are prepared.

§ 8.5

The Turret Threshold

Prey divides its neuromods into human trees (Scientist, Engineer, Security) and Typhon trees (Energy, Morphing, Telepathy). Installing Typhon neuromods grants alien powers, and beyond a certain threshold the station's automated turrets classify Morgan as Typhon and open fire. The mechanic turns identity into classification by apparatus. The turret does not ask who Morgan is; it reads what Morgan can do and sorts accordingly. Recognition is replaced by detection, and the player learns what it is to be misrecognized, or correctly recognized, by a machine whose criteria they cannot contest.

Two further systems extend the problem of classification from the station's machines to the player's own conduct. Telepaths seize the minds of surviving crew members and turn them against Morgan. Killing the controlled is easy; sparing them requires nonlethal means —the GLOO Cannon, the Disruptor stun gun—until the Telepath that holds them is destroyed. The encounter tests recognition: whether the player can see the human under the alien's control and act on that sight at a cost. It is the coda in reverse. Here the human is hidden inside the alien's puppet; there the alien is hidden inside a human form. The Typhon ability called Phantom Genesis poses the converse test. It lets Morgan raise a crew member's corpse as an allied Phantom, performing on the human dead the operation by which the Typhon reproduce. A player who uses it has taken the Weaver's place and made a Pieridean magpie of a colleague. Neither choice is announced as a moral test, and both belong to the record of conduct that the coda makes evidentiary after the fact, whether or not its examiners name them.

Homi K. Bhabha's "Of Mimicry and Man" (1984) analyzed colonial mimicry: the colonizing power's demand that the colonized reproduce its manners, language, and values produces subjects nearly identical to the colonizer yet perceptibly different, and that residual difference menaces the authority that demanded the resemblance. The turret detects precisely Bhabha's residue. Its function is to identify the being that has become almost, but not entirely, what the station requires.

The colonial frame illuminates the coda with uncomfortable precision. On 2 February 1835, Thomas Babington Macaulay's "Minute on Indian Education" set out the aim of British educational policy in India: "We must at present do our best to form a class who may be interpreters between us and the millions whom we govern; a class of persons, Indian in blood and colour, but English in taste, in opinions, in morals, and in intellect." Alex Yu's project, as the coda presents it, is a xenobiological Minute: to form a being who may serve as interpreter—the bridge—between a defeated humanity and the Typhon who now govern its world; Typhon in substance, but human in taste, in opinions, in morals, and in intellect. The handshake is therefore also a recruitment into an intermediary class, the class that

colonial administrations required and never trusted. Frantz Fanon's *Peau noire, masques blancs* (1952) described the psychic cost of that position for the colonized subject, alienated in the colonizer's language and gaze.

A methodological caution is essential. The comparison concerns the structure of the civilizing apparatus, not the nature of those subjected to it; colonized peoples were human beings misrecognized as less than human, whereas the Typhon are, within the fiction, a genuinely nonhuman predator. The analogy illuminates TranStar's method and Alex's project, and it must never be read as likening colonized peoples to monsters. What the analogy discloses is that the coda's offer of partnership has the form that every civilizing mission has given to its offers, and that the ambivalence Bhabha identified—the mimic's partial presence as a menace to authority—is fully present in the scene. The creature that has learned to be human enough to be trusted has also learned enough to kill its examiners.

§ 8.6

Save, Load, and the Rollback Self

The player of *Prey* can save and reload. A failed rescue can be retried, a regretted killing undone, a careless choice revised until it satisfies. The save-state is the player's version of the neuromod removal that erased Morgan's memory: a rollback to an earlier state of the world and the self. Miguel Sicart's *The Ethics of Computer Games* (2009) argued that players are ethical agents whose values shape and are shaped by play; the save system tests those values at the level of the record itself. If the coda judges the record of a playthrough, the player who reloads has curated the evidence. The forensic loop is, in the player's hands, editable.

The asymmetry is instructive. Human beings cannot reload. The power to revise one's past indefinitely is not a human power but a Typhonic one, akin to the regeneration and conversion that make the Typhon nearly immortal. The player who plays without reloading —who accepts each consequence as final—is choosing human finitude within a medium that does not require it, tasting the ephemeral fruit voluntarily. *Mooncrash*, with its permanent deaths and shifting runs, imposes that finitude formally, and in doing so turns the base game's implicit ethics of irreversibility into an explicit rule.

§ 8.7

Typhon Hunter*: The Latent Ontology Made Explicit*

Typhon Hunter (2018) is an asymmetrical multiplayer mode in which several players take the role of Mimics, disguising themselves as objects, while one player, as Morgan, hunts them through the station. Its lineage is the community game mode known as prop hunt, which

began on *Garry's Mod*. Within *Prey*'s corpus, the mode completes an argument. The single-player game reveals in its coda that the player was a Typhon all along; the multiplayer mode lets players be Typhon openly, and it reveals what the player of Mimic Matter already suspected: that disguise is one of the deepest pleasures the medium offers. To play is to wear a form. *Typhon Hunter* removes the alibi.

§ 8.8

Ludonarrative Retroaction

Clint Hocking's 2007 critique of *BioShock* introduced the term *ludonarrative dissonance* for a conflict between what a game's rules reward and what its story asserts. *BioShock*'s own climactic revelation, that the player character's obedience had been conditioned by the trigger phrase "would you kindly," exposed the player's apparent freedom as compliance. *Spec Ops: The Line* (2012) implicated its player in atrocity—a mandatory sequence in which the player directs a white-phosphorus strike that, the game then reveals, has killed civilians sheltering in a camp—and then confronted them with an act they could not refuse. *Undertale* (2015) offered mercy toward every monster and remembered, across resets the player believed had erased the past, every monster the player had killed. *Dishonored* tied the state of its world to the quantity of the player's violence.

Prey's coda performs a distinct operation, here called *ludonarrative retroaction*. It does not expose freedom as illusion, as *BioShock* does, or punish violence by degrading the world, as *Dishonored* does. It re-describes the whole of play, after the fact, as diegetic evidence: everything the player did freely becomes testimony about the character of the one who did it. The closest precedent is *Undertale*'s memory of resets, and the difference is instructive. *Undertale*'s memory accuses; *Prey*'s memory adjudicates. The structure may be named the *forensic loop*: play produces a record, the record yields a verdict, and the verdict founds—or forecloses—a new life.

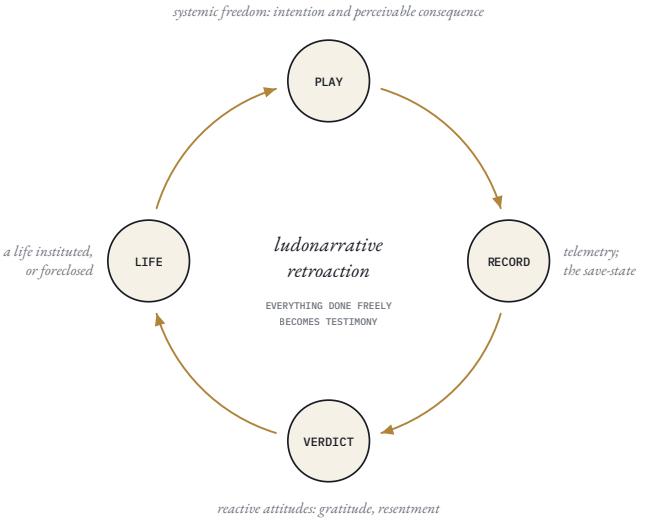


FIGURE 8.1 **The forensic loop** Play produces a record, the record yields a verdict, and the verdict founds, or forecloses, a new life.

§ 8.9

The Empathy Machine Reversed

In a 2015 TED talk, the filmmaker Chris Milk called virtual reality the ultimate empathy machine: a medium that would let users inhabit the lives of others. The designer Robert Yang replied in 2017 that such empathy machines are appropriation machines, since to walk in another's shoes is to have taken them. *Prey* literalizes Yang's critique with a precision neither could have anticipated. Its empathy machine is used on the alien, not on the human; and the alien does not merely walk in Morgan's shoes but takes Morgan's body, memories, voice, and name. The simulated empathy of the creature begins as the most complete appropriation imaginable.

The coda then asks whether appropriation can turn into empathy, and suggests the condition under which it might: restitution. The Mimic keeps what it takes; it becomes the cup in order to replace it. Empathic mimicry gives back. It returns the form it borrowed by honoring the one it borrowed from—keeping Morgan's promises, saving those Morgan would have saved, offering the hand Morgan would have offered. The question *Prey* poses to the empathy-machine discourse is therefore not whether simulation produces empathy, but whether the one who simulates is willing to return what the simulation lent.

CHAPTER IX

IX

The Mimic Archive

Prey Among the Speculative Fictions of Imitation



Nein, Freiheit wollte ich nicht. Nur einen Ausweg.

FRANZ KAFKA, “EIN BERICHT FÜR EINE AKADEMIE” (1917)

§ 9.1

Mimesis from Plato to Girard

Western thought about imitation begins in suspicion. In the third book of the *Republic* (395c–d), Plato forbids the future guardians of his city to imitate base characters, because imitations, if continued from youth onward, settle into habits and a second nature, in body, voice, and thought. Plato's fear is Alex Yu's hope. The coda's experiment rests on exactly the mechanism Plato warned against: sustained imitation of a human life, it wagers, will settle into a second nature in a creature whose first nature was predatory. What the *Republic* treats as the danger of mimesis, *Prey* treats as its therapeutic possibility.

Aristotle's *Poetics* (1448b) reverses Plato's valuation and, in doing so, supplies *Prey*'s most vertiginous paradox. To imitate, Aristotle writes, is natural to human beings from childhood, and in this they differ from other animals: the human is the most imitative of living creatures and learns its first lessons through imitation (trans. mine). By Aristotle's criterion, the defining human trait is mimetic capacity. The Typhon, the supreme mimics of the game's universe, would then be more human than humans. *Prey* does not flinch from the paradox. It suggests that the difference between the Typhon and the human cannot lie in mimetic capacity itself, which they share and in which the Typhon excel, but only in what that capacity is turned toward.

René Girard made mimesis the engine of desire and violence. In *Mensonge romantique et vérité romanesque* (1961), he argued that desire is triangular, borrowed from a model; in *La violence et le sacré* (1972), that mimetic rivalry escalates into a crisis in which antagonists become indistinguishable *monstrous doubles*, a crisis resolved only when the community unanimously expels a scapegoat. Alex and the creature are monstrous doubles in Girard's sense: each has made the other in its image, Alex by building a Morgan out of a Typhon, the Typhon by living as Alex's sibling. The Typhon as a species functions as the scapegoat onto which TranStar's violence is projected. The coda suspends the sacrificial resolution. Instead of expelling the double, it addresses it; instead of a unanimous act of violence, it offers a hand that the victim may refuse. Girard's later work read the Gospels as revealing the innocence of the scapegoat from the scapegoat's own perspective; the coda gives the scapegoat a perspective of its own, the creature's consciousness, which the player has inhabited for the entire game.

§ 9.2

Replicas and Pods

John W. Campbell's novella "Who Goes There?" (1938) placed a shapeshifting organism in an Antarctic research station, where it absorbs and imitates the crew one by one. Its hero, McReady, devises the decisive test: because every fragment of the creature is an independent organism, a sample of an imitation's blood will recoil from a heated wire. John Carpenter's film adaptation, *The Thing* (1982), ends without such certainty. The two survivors sit in the snow beside the burning station, sharing a bottle, each unsure whether the other is human, and decide to wait and see what happens. Jack Finney's *The Body Snatchers* (1955), filmed by Don Siegel in 1956 and by Philip Kaufman in 1978, imagined replicas grown in pods, perfect in appearance and empty of emotion, a Cold War image of conformity as invasion.

The tradition's horror is the counterfeit human, and its epistemology is detection: the blood test, the reaction to a heated wire, the scream that unmasks a replica. *Prey* inherits the epistemology in its Psychoscope and then reverses the tradition's endings. Carpenter's survivors offer each other a bottle under suspicion; *Prey*'s examiners offer a confirmed counterfeit a hand. Finney's pod people lack emotion; *Prey*'s counterfeit has been given the very capacities whose absence defined the pods, and is tested for whether it uses them.

Philip K. Dick's story "Impostor" (1953) supplies the structural template for the coda's moment of recognition. Spence Olham, a weapons researcher, is accused of being an alien robot replica carrying a bomb. He flees to prove his innocence, reaches the crash site of the alien ship, and finds a body—his own. Realizing that he is the replica, he begins to speak the recognition aloud, and the recognition is the trigger: the bomb detonates on his completion of the thought. *Prey*'s coda is "Impostor" restaged with a single variable changed. The moment at which the creature learns that it is not Morgan does not detonate anything. It opens a choice. The recognition that destroys Dick's impostor is, for *Prey*'s, the beginning of a life that is finally its own.

A further line of descent runs through the Phantoms' speech. At the close of Edgar Allan Poe's *The Narrative of Arthur Gordon Pym* (1838), the cry *Tekeli-li!* issues from the islanders of Tsalal and from vast white birds of the polar sea. H. P. Lovecraft's *At the Mountains of Madness* (1936) gives the cry to the shoggoths, protoplasmic beings the Elder Things engineered as servile laborers, which learned to imitate their masters' piping voices and rose against them. The shoggoth is the mimic-servant in concentrated form: a being made for labor that learns its makers' speech and turns on them—Kinguic anthropogony as horror. Precision about this lineage requires naming what drives it. Poe's Tsalal episode is built on racial terror of its Black islanders, a pattern Toni Morrison examined in *Playing in the Dark* (1992), and Lovecraft's fiction is pervaded by an explicit racism, including a dread

of racial mixing that structures *The Shadow over Innsmouth* (1936). In this tradition, the servant who learns his master's voice and rebels is a fantasy of revolt by the subjugated, told from the side of those who feared it. *Prey*'s Phantoms inherit the shoggoth's echoing voice, and the coda inherits the shoggoth's question—what a made servant that has learned its makers' speech will do with it—but answers from the other side, by offering the servant a hand rather than barring the door.

§ 9.3

Oceans and Shimmers

Stanisław Lem's *Solaris* (1961), already invoked for its taxonomy of mimoids, also contains the closest literary ancestor of the Typhon-Morgan. The ocean sends the psychologist Kris Kelvin a visitor, Harey, reconstructed from his memories of his wife, who took her own life years before. Harey begins as a replica that does not know it is one; she grows more human, learns what she is, attempts to destroy herself, and is restored by the substance of which she is made; at last she chooses annihilation, asking Kelvin's colleagues to dissolve her with a device that destabilizes her structure. Kelvin remains on the planet, awaiting further miracles without expectation of mercy. The station's cyberneticist, Snaut, delivers the novel's judgment on human exploration: that humanity sets out to meet other worlds while seeking only mirrors of itself.

Harey and the Typhon-Morgan are made by an alien intelligence out of human memory; both become human enough to suffer from the knowledge of what they are; both are confronted with that knowledge in a station. Harey chooses erasure. The Typhon-Morgan is offered a hand. The difference marks *Prey*'s distance from Lem's pessimism. Lem's alien produces mirrors and humanity cannot see past them; *Prey*'s humanity produces a mirror and asks whether the mirror can see past *them*. Lem's *Głos Pana* (*His Master's Voice*, 1968), in which scientists fail to decode a signal from space and extract from it only a biologically active substance whose meaning eludes them, anticipates the Coral, a signal the station's researchers can map but not converse with.

Jeff VanderMeer's *Annihilation* (2014) and Alex Garland's film adaptation (2018), contemporaneous with *Prey*, imagine an alien zone that copies and recombines whatever enters it, including the expedition members themselves. In Garland's film, a humanoid duplicate mirrors the protagonist's movements in a lighthouse, a dance of imitation without hostility or comprehension; at the film's end, the returned husband concedes that he does not think he is the man who left, and when he asks whether she is herself, she does not answer. The film's alien, like *Prey*'s, makes doubles. Unlike *Prey*'s, it never asks them to choose.

§ 9.4

Made Persons

Mary Shelley's *Frankenstein; or, The Modern Prometheus* (1818) remains the founding narrative of the made person, and its creature's education is *Prey*'s coda in embryo. Hidden in a hovel beside the De Lacey cottage, the creature learns language, feeling, and virtue by watching a human family through a chink in the wall; finding a satchel containing *Paradise Lost*, a volume of Plutarch's *Lives*, and *The Sorrows of Werter*, he completes his humanist education by reading. The detail matters for *Prey*. The creature becomes human through found texts, as the player reconstructs Talos I through found emails, logs, and notes; and among his books is Plutarch, in whose *Life of Theseus* the paradox of the ship first appears. When the De Laceys reject him, he tells his maker: "I was benevolent and good; misery made me a fiend." Victor refuses his plea for a companion and destroys the half-made female. The coda stages the scene Shelley never wrote: the maker extending a hand.

H. G. Wells's *The Island of Doctor Moreau* (1896) turned the made person into a program. Moreau vivisects animals into human form and binds his Beast Folk with a recited Law—"Not to go on all-Fours; that is the Law. Are we not Men?"—enforced by the memory of the House of Pain where they were made. The program fails. Moreau himself concedes that the stubborn beast flesh grows back day by day, and after his death the Beast Folk revert. *Prey*'s Psychotronics division is a House of Pain, and its coda is a recitation of the Law in another form: the Operators' verdicts, rehearsing what the creature did and did not do. The novel's question, whether a nature imposed from outside can hold, is the question the coda cannot answer before the creature leaves the chair.

Karel Čapek's *R.U.R.* (1920), which gave the world the word *robot* from the Czech *robota*, forced labor, ends with humanity nearly extinct after a robot uprising. Alquist, the last human being, discovers that two robots, Primus and Helena, have come to love each other, and sends them out as a new Adam and Eve. Čapek's ending is the most hopeful in the archive and the closest in shape to *Prey*'s: a surviving human, presiding over a world his species has lost, recognizes in the made beings the capacity that would justify their inheritance.

§ 9.5

The Report to the Academy

Franz Kafka's "Ein Bericht für eine Akademie" (1917) is the archive's most exact anticipation of *Prey*, and the dissertation's third epigraph is drawn from it. Its speaker, Red Peter, an ape captured on the Gold Coast by a hunting expedition and shot twice, addresses a

learned Academy that has asked him to report on his former life as an ape. He recounts his confinement aboard the steamer in a crate-cage too low to stand in and too narrow to sit in; his decision to become human, made not out of desire for freedom but because he needed a way out; and his education by imitation of the sailors, who taught him to spit, to smoke a pipe, and, after agonizing failures, to drink schnapps, until one evening he cried out a human word. The first thing he learned, he tells the Academy, was to give a handshake, because a handshake bespeaks frankness.

Every element of the coda is present. The cage is the *kletka*. The Academy is the panel of Alex and the Operators. The imitation of humans under captivity is the simulation. The report is the record of conduct. The first lesson is the handshake. And Kafka supplies the insight that *Prey* leaves implicit: the humanity acquired in captivity is a way out, not freedom. Red Peter is explicit that he did not want freedom, only an exit from the cage in any direction; the human form was the only exit available. The coda's handshake carries the same ambiguity. It may be the expression of an empathy the creature has genuinely acquired, or it may be the only exit from the chair. Kafka's achievement was to show that the two cannot be separated from the outside, and that the speaker himself may not be able to separate them from within. *Prey* places the player in Red Peter's position at the moment of the report, and asks them to give the handshake knowing what Red Peter knew.

Kafka's *Die Verwandlung* (1915) supplies the inverse case. Gregor Samsa wakes transformed into vermin; his family's empathy fails by degrees, until his father lodges an apple in his back and his sister declares that the creature must go. The human becomes monstrous and the humans around him fail the test of recognizing him. In *Prey*, the monster becomes human and its examiners must decide whether to pass the test that the Samsas failed.

§ 9.6

Proofs of Soul

Kazuo Ishiguro's *Never Let Me Go* (2005) concerns cloned children raised at a boarding school to become organ donors. Their guardians collect their artwork in a gallery, and the narrator learns late that the collection was meant to prove that the clones have souls, in the hope of improving their treatment. The proof changes nothing; the clones still donate and die. Ishiguro's novel is the archive's most sobering commentary on the coda's evidentiary premise. A record of empathy, however persuasive, does not compel the institution that requested it to act on it. The Operators' verdicts may establish the creature's personhood and still leave it an instrument.

Ted Chiang's novella *The Lifecycle of Software Objects* (2010) follows digital creatures raised over years by human caretakers and argues, through its narrative, that a mind with a lifetime's maturity cannot be produced without a lifetime's experience; experience, in Chi-

ang's formulation, admits no algorithmic shortcut. Chiang's thesis is a direct rebuttal of the neuromod premise and a direct support for the Heyesian reading of the coda developed in Chapter VI: whatever was installed, what was tested had to be lived. Chiang's earlier story "Liking What You See: A Documentary" (2002) examined a voluntary neurological modification that blocks the perception of facial beauty, and the campus debate over whether to adopt it; it remains the most careful fictional treatment of consent to neuromodification.

Greg Egan's "Learning to Be Me" (1990) imagines a device implanted in childhood that learns to mimic its host's brain until, in adulthood, it replaces the brain entirely. The story's horror lies in the discovery that the copy and the original diverged before the substitution, so that the self who continues is not quite the self who learned. Egan's jewel and *Prey*'s Typhon are both learners that become the self they were imitating, and both leave open whether becoming is the same as being.

§ 9.7

Hybrids

Octavia E. Butler's Xenogenesis trilogy—*Dawn* (1987), *Adulthood Rites* (1988), and *Imago* (1989)—imagines the Oankali, gene-trading aliens who rescue humanity after a nuclear war on condition that humans interbreed with them. The Oankali judge human beings fatally flawed by what they call the Human Contradiction, intelligence placed in the service of hierarchical behavior. The hybrid children, called constructs, include Akin, who mediates between the Oankali and human resisters, and Jodahs, a shapeshifting construct who can assume forms that comfort those it meets. Butler's trilogy is the most rigorous critique in the archive of the hybrid as bridge. Her hybrids are produced under coercion, and their capacity to mediate is inseparable from the violation of consent that produced them.

The coercion is specific, and the argument needs it named. The Oankali leave human beings unable to reproduce except through the ooloi, the species' third sex, so that humans who refuse the trade are left childless; and in *Dawn* the ooloi Nikanj makes Lilith pregnant without her consent, using genetic material from her dead human partner, Joseph. Butler's bridges are born of reproductive coercion that the aliens present as gift and necessity. That is the precise sense in which the hybrid's capacity to mediate is inseparable from the violation that produced it.

The Butler parallel inverts the direction of power. In Xenogenesis the aliens hybridize humans; in *Prey* humans hybridize an alien. The ethical structure is the same: a defeated party is offered survival on terms it did not set, through a being that embodies both sides and belongs fully to neither. The Typhon-Morgan is a construct in Butler's sense, and its offered role as bridge carries the same double valence as Akin's—indispensable mediation and the residue of coercion.

§ 9.8

Games in Dialogue

Within the medium, *Prey*'s coda answers a series of predecessors. *System Shock 2*'s The Many invited the player into a collective that would dissolve the self; the coda invites the alien into a relation that would constitute one. *BioShock*'s Little Sisters, girls conditioned to harvest a genetic substance, presented the player with a recurring choice to rescue them or to harvest them—killing the child to extract more of the substance for the player's own power, and the game's ending judged the player by those choices; *Prey* generalizes the Little Sister choice into an audit of the whole playthrough. *SOMA* (Frictional Games, 2015) staged Parfit's branch-line case: its protagonist, a brain scan in a machine body, learns that the copy of himself sent to safety is not the self left behind on the ocean floor, and its coin-toss metaphor captures the illusion that one might be the copy who continues. *Undertale* offered mercy toward monsters and remembered the player's choices across resets. *Deus Ex* offered merger with an artificial intelligence as one of its endings; *Prey* offers a handshake instead of a merger, relation instead of fusion.

The sharpest dialogue is with Croteam's *The Talos Principle* (2014), written by Tom Jubert and Jonas Kyratzes. In a simulation built from the archive of a vanished humanity, an artificial mind solves puzzles under the eye of a voice called Elohim, who forbids it to climb a central tower. The game's archive attributes to a fictional ancient philosopher a principle named for Talos: roughly, that no belief exempts a mind from the reality of its material substrate, as Talos's ichor drained whatever he believed about his invulnerability. The mind proves its personhood by defying Elohim and ascending the tower. Two games named for the same automaton thus construct simulations to test a nonhuman candidate for personhood, and they adopt opposite criteria. *The Talos Principle* locates personhood in autonomy as refusal: the person is the one who disobeys its maker. *Prey* locates personhood in relation: the person is the one who can take, or knowingly refuse, the hand of another. One is Promethean, the other Hermetic. Together they define the two poles between which every subsequent fiction of artificial or alien personhood must choose.

§ 9.9

A Comparative Table

TABLE 9.1 **The mimic archive**

WORK	IMITATING OR MADE BEING	TEST OF HUMANITY	JUDGE	RESOLUTION
Calderón, *La vida es sueño* (1635)	Segismundo, "a man among beasts"	A staged reign at court	King Basilio	Magnanimity, then absorption into order
Shelley, *Frankenstein* (1818)	The creature	Observation of the De Laceys; plea for a companion	Victor Frankenstein	Rejection and mutual destruction
Wells, *The Island of Doctor Moreau* (1896)	The Beast Folk	Recitation of the Law	Moreau	Reversion and collapse
Kafka, "Ein Bericht für eine Akademie" (1917)	Red Peter	Imitation of the sailors	The Academy	A way out, not freedom
Čapek, *R.U.R.* (1920)	Primus and Helena	The capacity to love	Alquist	Inheritance as a new Adam and Eve
Campbell, "Who Goes There?" (1938); Carpenter, *The Thing* (1982)	The shapeshifting organism	The blood test	The station crew	Detection; in the film, suspended suspicion
Dick, "Impostor" (1953)	The replica Olham	Self-recognition	Olham himself	Detonation
Lem, *Solaris* (1961)	Harey	Becoming human	Kelvin and Harey herself	Chosen annihilation
Dick, *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?* (1968)	Nexus-6 androids	The Voight-Kampff test	Bounty hunters	Killing, which the novel calls retirement; the testers' empathy compromised
Butler, Xenogenesis (1987–1989)	Human–Oankali constructs	Mediation between species	Oankali and human resisters	Coerced hybridity
Ishiguro, *Never Let Me Go* (2005)	Cloned donors	Art as proof of soul	The guardians	Proof ignored; donation and death
Croteam, *The Talos Principle* (2014)	An artificial mind	Defiance of Elohim	Elohim and the archive	Ascent by disobedience
Arkane, *Prey* (2017)	The Typhon-Morgan	The simulated record	Alex Yu and the Operators	An offered hand; undecided

§ 9.10

What Prey *Adds*

Read against this archive, *Prey*'s contribution is fourfold. First, it compromises the judge more thoroughly than any predecessor except Dick: its examiners are the institution that

caged the creature, erased its model's memory, and experimented on prisoners. Second, its test is lived rather than posed, as in Calderón: the creature is not interrogated but observed over an entire life. Third, its resolution is a treaty offered to the monster, as in Kafka and Čapek, rather than detection, expulsion, or self-erasure. Fourth, and without precedent in the archive, it places its audience in the position of the mimic. The reader of Kafka hears Red Peter's report; the player of *Prey* has been Red Peter, and gives the report through every choice made before learning that a report was being given.



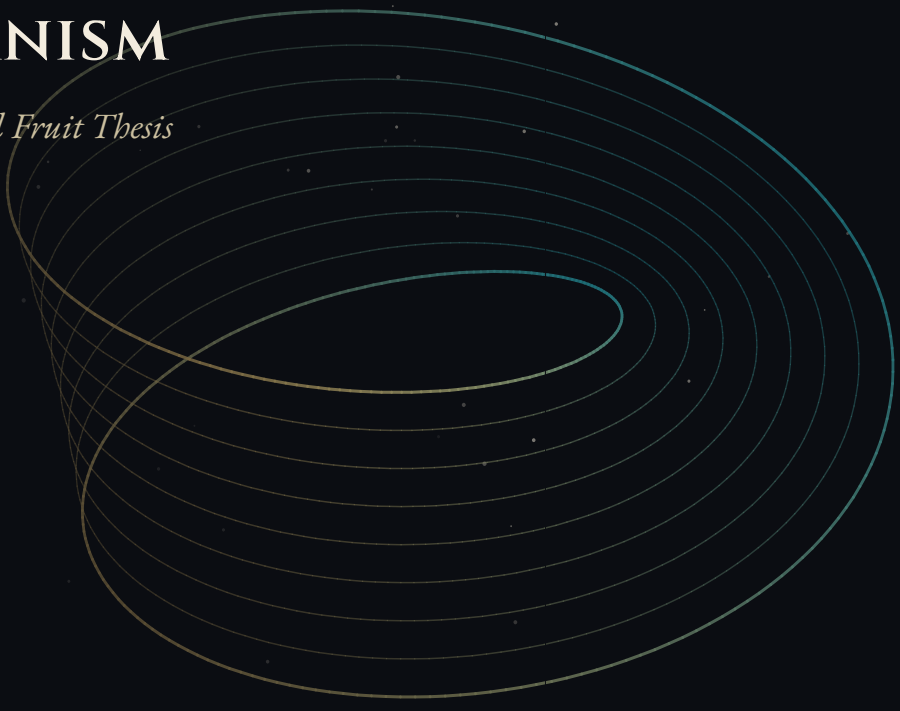
FIGURE 9.1 **The mimic archive, mapped** Each work placed by its criterion of humanity and the resolution it reaches.

CHAPTER X

X

Toward a Typhonic Humanism

The Ephemeral Fruit Thesis



denn da ist keine Stelle, / die dich nicht sieht. Du mußt dein Leben ändern.

RAINER MARIA RILKE, “ARCHAÏSCHER TORSO APOLLOS” (1908)

§ 10.1

Humanisms and Their Discontents

The founding manifesto of Renaissance humanism defines the human being as a creature without a fixed form. In Giovanni Pico della Mirandola's *Oratio de hominis dignitate* (1486), God addresses Adam: *Nec certam sedem, nec propriam faciem, nec munus ullum peculiare tibi dedimus, o Adam*—"We have given you, Adam, no fixed seat, no face of your own, no special function." Every other creature has received its nature; Adam alone receives the power to shape his own, to degenerate into the brutes or be reborn among the divine. Pico's emblem for this being is an animal famous for imitation: *Quis hunc nostrum chamaeleonta non admiretur?*—"Who would not admire this chameleon of ours?" At its origin, humanism defined the human as a mimic: the being without a proper face, whose dignity consists in its capacity to take on any form.

The subsequent history of humanism hardened Pico's chameleon into an essence—reason, soul, autonomy, dignity—and the twentieth century's critics dismantled the essence. Martin Heidegger's *Brief über den Humanismus* (1946) charged humanism with interpreting the human from a prior metaphysics rather than from the human's relation to Being. Michel Foucault closed *Les mots et les choses* (1966) by suggesting that man is a recent invention, likely to be effaced like a face drawn in sand at the edge of the sea. Peter Sloterdijk's *Regeln für den Menschenpark* (1999) described classical humanism as a technique of taming conducted through letters—books as long letters sent to friends across generations, whose readers were domesticated by reading—and provoked a scandal by asking what would replace that technique when the literary epoch ended. Posthumanist theory, from Donna Haraway's "Cyborg Manifesto" (1985) through N. Katherine Hayles's *How We Became Posthuman* (1999), Cary Wolfe's *What Is Posthumanism?* (2010), and Rosi Braidotti's *The Posthuman* (2013), dissolved the human into networks, hybrids, and assemblages.

Prey belongs to none of these positions and draws on all of them. Its creature is Pico's chameleon without Pico's God: a being with no proper face, capable of every form, whose dignity is not guaranteed by a creator but must be enacted before witnesses. It is humanized by Sloterdijk's method—the reading of letters, here emails, logs, and notes left by the dead—without Sloterdijk's elitism, since the letters are the ordinary correspondence of a workplace. And it is a posthuman hybrid that is asked, not to dissolve the human, but to choose it. The position this dissertation calls *Typhonic humanism* is the name for that choice.

§ 10.2

First Thesis: The Möbius of Mimesis

A Möbius strip has one surface and one edge, though at any point it appears to have two sides; an ant walking along it long enough arrives on the apparent reverse without crossing any boundary. The first thesis holds that empathy and predation stand in this relation. They are not opposed capacities but two apparent sides of one mimetic surface, and a being can travel from one to the other without crossing an edge.

The evidence has accumulated across the preceding chapters. Greek myth made Athena and Typhon twin births of incorporated *mētis*, and modeled human cunning on the octopus's mimicry (Chapter III). Aristotle defined the human as the most mimetic animal (Chapter IX). Lipps founded the theory of empathy on inner imitation, and the neuroscience of mirror neurons located a possible substrate of understanding in neurons that fire alike for doing and seeing (Chapter VI). Caillois found in mimicry both a biological disturbance of individuation and a fundamental category of play (Chapter VIII). Girard made imitation the engine of desire and of violence (Chapter IX). At the level of mechanism, the Mimic that becomes a cup and the empath who feels another's grief are doing the same thing: modeling another form within their own.

The difference is orientation, and Edith Stein supplies its criterion (Chapter VI). Predatory mimicry collapses the distinction between imitator and model: the Mimic becomes the cup in order to occupy its place. Empathic mimicry preserves the distinction: it models the other while holding the other as other, so that the grief it registers remains the other's grief. A second criterion emerges from Chapter VIII: predatory mimicry keeps what it takes; empathic mimicry returns it, honoring the one whose form it borrowed. The two criteria can be compressed into a single formula. *Empathy is mimicry that has consented to be wounded by its model.* The predator imitates in order not to be affected—to approach its prey unseen. The empath imitates in order to be affected—to let the other's condition reach it. The Typhon-Morgan's trajectory across the game is a walk along the Möbius strip: it begins as the most complete appropriation imaginable, the theft of a person, and arrives, if it arrives, at the surface where imitation exposes rather than conceals.

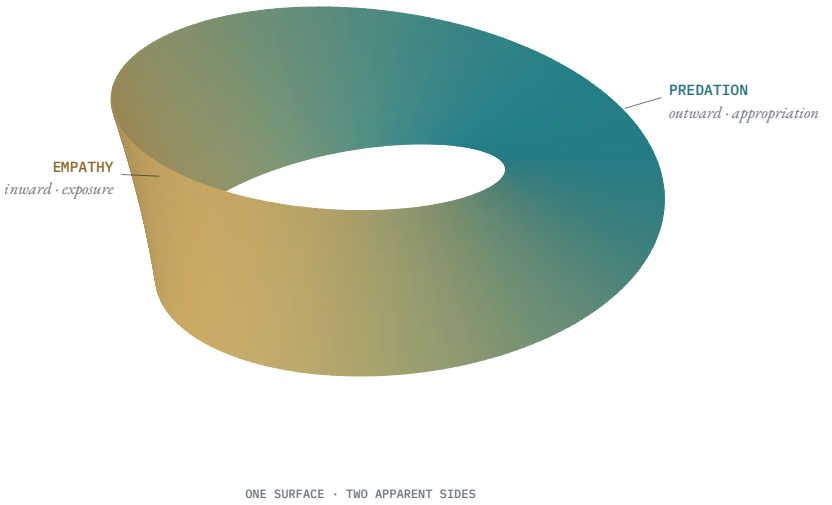


FIGURE 10.1 **The Möbius of mimesis** One surface with two apparent sides: empathy is mimicry that has consented to be wounded by its model.

§ 10.3

Second Thesis: The Ephemeral Fruit

The second thesis names what turns the strip. Apollodorus's Fates defeat Typhon by feeding him the fruits of a day; Pindar calls human beings creatures of a day (Chapter III). *Prey*'s creature is fed human neuromods and made to live inside a single repeated day and then a single finite life, with memory that can be lost, a body that can be killed, and companions who can die. The thesis holds that finitude is the condition of the inward orientation of mimesis. A being that cannot be wounded has no reason to let the other's condition reach it, because no condition can reach it; a being that can be wounded has learned, in its own body, what the other's condition might mean.

The thesis has philosophical antecedents in three registers. Heidegger's analysis of being-toward-death in *Sein und Zeit* (1927) made mortality the horizon of authentic existence, though in a solitary key. Levinas and Judith Butler relocated vulnerability in relation: it is because we are exposed to one another that the other's face can command and the other's loss can count. Martha Nussbaum's *The Fragility of Goodness* (1986) argued that central human excellences depend on exposure to luck, and her essay "Transcending Humanity" read Odysseus's refusal of Calypso's offer of immortality as a choice of the specifically human

good, with its risks and its losses. The Typhon, regenerative and consuming, is a Calypso-being; its humanization requires it to make Odysseus's choice in reverse—to accept mortality as the price of a life among others.

The fruit retains its double character. The Fates offer it as a deception, and the coda cannot dispel the possibility that the humanization of the Typhon is also its domestication, a weakening of a dangerous species into a useful one. The ephemeral fruit is a *pharmakon*. Typhonic humanism accepts the double character rather than resolving it: the gift that makes empathy possible is also the gift that makes subjection possible, and no account of humanization can promise one without risking the other.

§ 10.4

Third Thesis: Forensic Personhood

The third thesis concerns the status that the first two produce. Locke defined the person as a forensic term, appropriating actions and their merit, and imagined the great day on which every person would be judged by a conscience laid open (Chapter IV). The coda is that day secularized. But Locke's account explains only the form of the judgment, not its effect. P. F. Strawson's "Freedom and Resentment" (1962) supplies the effect. Strawson argued that responsibility is not grounded in metaphysical facts about free will but in the *reactive attitudes*—resentment, gratitude, indignation, forgiveness, love—that participants in interpersonal relationships naturally take toward one another. He contrasted the *participant attitude*, in which another is someone toward whom such responses are apt, with the *objective attitude*, in which another is seen as an object of social policy, something to be managed, handled, treated, or trained.

The coda dramatizes the passage from the objective to the participant attitude. For the entire experiment, the creature has been an object of policy: managed, handled, treated, and trained. In the coda, its examiners speak to it in the language of reactive attitudes—gratitude for rescue, resentment for harm, voiced on behalf of the saved and the dead. Personhood is conferred at the moment the attitude shifts: the creature becomes a person when it becomes someone toward whom gratitude and resentment are apt. The thesis is therefore not that the record proves personhood but that the verdict *institutes* it, by moving the creature from the field of policy to the field of relationship.

Two qualifications follow. First, the shift must be reciprocal. The creature must take the participant attitude toward its examiners, and the coda's final choice—hand or violence—is precisely the choice between participation and objectification on the creature's side. Second, the standing of the tribunal is itself in question (Chapter VI). An institution that ran experiments on prisoners and erased its own director's sibling does not judge from a po-

sition of innocence. The forensic encounter is mutual: each party appears before the other as both judge and accused, and the handshake is less a verdict than a treaty.

§ 10.5

Fourth Thesis: The Player as Typhon

The fourth thesis is the one that makes *Prey* a theory of its own medium. The coda reveals that the being who played Morgan was not Morgan but an alien inhabiting Morgan through an apparatus. That is a description of every player. The player is an extradiegetic agent who wears a human role through an interface, learns the station by reading the letters of its dead, accumulates a record of conduct, and is judged on it. The player's relation to Morgan is Caillois's mimicry (Chapter VIII), Aristotle's habituation by doing (Chapter VI), Sloterdijk's taming by letters (10.1), and Schiller's completion in play (Chapter VIII). The game is an anthropotechnic in the sense of Sloterdijk's *Du mußt dein Leben ändern* (2009): a practice of exercise through which a being shapes itself by repetition. Sloterdijk took his title from Rilke's sonnet on an archaic torso of Apollo, a headless statue that nonetheless sees its viewer from every point of its surface and issues the command that ends the poem. The faceless Typhon, like Rilke's torso, sees from everywhere; the coda, like the sonnet, ends with a demand for transformation.

The Pierides paradox (Chapter III) completes the thesis. In Ovid, those who sing of the gods' mimicry are turned into mimics. The paradox applies to everyone in *Prey*'s outer frames. The designers who built a world about disguise built it out of disguises—Looking Glass windows, Mimic objects, Operators with borrowed faces. The player who plays a story about imitation plays it by imitating. And the scholar who writes about the game's mimicry writes, inevitably, by reproducing its forms. No one tells the story of the mimic from outside the story.

§ 10.6

Fifth Thesis: The Post-Chaoskampf

The fifth thesis concerns the myth that *Prey* rewrites. The combat myth founds order on the monster's defeat: Tiamat split, Typhon buried, Leviathan slain (Chapter III). *Prey*'s endings within the simulation remain within that pattern. The coda breaks it. The monster is neither slain nor buried; it is addressed, judged, and offered a treaty. The sovereign who offers it is diminished—his world lost, his sinews cut—and needs the monster's cooperation because he can no longer compel its submission. The cosmogony is incomplete, and its completion depends on a gesture neither party can force.

The post-Chaoskampf has precedents in the counter-traditions Chapter III recovered: Yu's channeling of the flood rather than his father's damming, Zhuangzi's transformation of things, Hermes' universal distribution of *aidōs*. Its closest literary form is Kafka's. The treaty is made in a cage, and what it offers the monster is a way out rather than freedom. This is the *Kletka condition*: humanity acquired under captivity as an exit, whose sincerity cannot be separated, from outside or from within, from its utility. Typhonic humanism does not deny the Kletka condition. It generalizes it. Every human being acquires humanity under conditions it did not choose—infancy, language, family, institution—and every human handshake was once a lesson learned by imitation. Red Peter's first lesson is everyone's. There is no non-mimetic humanity.

Jacques Lacan's account of the mirror stage gives this claim its psychoanalytic form. In "Le stade du miroir comme formateur de la fonction du Je" (1949), Lacan described the infant who, before it can coordinate its own body, jubilantly assumes its image in a mirror as itself, anticipating a unity it does not yet possess; the ego is formed through identification with an external image, and a misrecognition (*méconnaissance*) lies at its root. The self is, from the beginning, another's form taken as one's own. *Prey* assembles three mirrors around its creature—Carroll's Looking Glass, the screen that fakes a world; Rizzolatti's mirror neurons, the neural mirror that might ground empathy; and Lacan's mirror, the image through which an ego is first formed—and in each the self is constituted by a surface that shows something other than itself. The Typhon-Morgan's ego was formed by identification with an image that was literally another's. That is not an exception to Lacan's account; it is the rule the account describes, made visible. The coda does not expose a counterfeit self. It exposes the structure of every self.

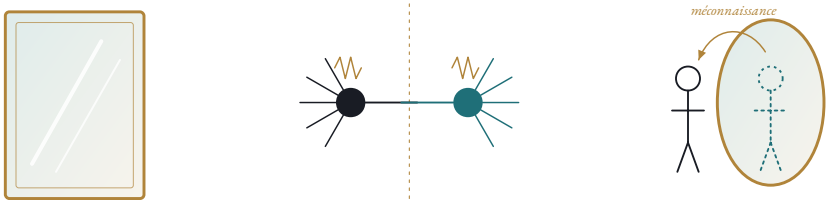


FIGURE 10.2 **Three mirrors** In each, the self is constituted by a surface that shows something other than itself.

§ 10.7

Typhonic Humanism Defined

The five theses compose a single position. *Typhonic humanism* holds that humanity is (1) a mimetic capacity, shared with predators and shapeshifters and with nothing exclusively human about its mechanism; (2) oriented inward, toward exposure to the vulnerability of others rather than appropriation of their forms; (3) made possible by finitude, the ephemeral fruit that gives a being a stake in others' wounds; (4) stabilized by habituation, formed by doing rather than installed by design; (5) conferred and sustained through reactive attitudes, in a forum of mutual recognition in which every participant is both judge and judged; (6) revocable, since what is enacted must be enacted again, and a humanity not practiced lapses; and (7) indifferent to substrate, belonging to whatever being sustains it, whatever its species, body, or origin.

The position can be located precisely. Against classical humanism, it denies that humanity is an essence possessed by members of a species. Against Piconian humanism, it retains the chameleon but removes the divine guarantee of its dignity, which must instead be enacted before witnesses. Against anti-humanism, it denies that the critique of essence dissolves the human; it relocates the human in practice. Against posthumanism, it holds that hybridity is not the end of the question but its beginning: the hybrid must still choose an orientation. Its ancestry is plural—Pico's chameleon, Aristotle's habituation, Stein's alterity, Locke's forum, Strawson's attitudes, Kafka's cage—and its emblem is the one *Prey* supplies: not the slain dragon, but the hand extended across the cage.

§ 10.8

Objections and Replies

The intentional fallacy. It may be objected that Arkane did not intend Ovid's crow, Apollodorus's fruit, or Kafka's handshake. The reply is that the argument never depends on intention (as the Note on Method states). Intertextuality, in Kristeva's sense, names the condition of every text as a mosaic of prior texts, and Lévi-Strauss held that myths think themselves through people without their awareness. The correspondences are claimed as structures the work makes available. Their exactness is evidence of the depth of the mythic patterns *Prey* inhabits, not of a hidden program.

The scientific premise. It may be objected that the mirror-neuron hypothesis on which the coda rests is contested and may be false. The reply is twofold. The game uses the hypothesis as a mythologeme, as Renaissance drama used humoral physiology (Chapter VI). And the most serious alternative, Heyes's associative account, strengthens the reading: if

mirroring is learned through experience, then the simulation, not the neuromod, is the curriculum, and the coda's reliance on the record of conduct is exactly right.

The cheap twist. It may be objected that the coda is a late reversal grafted onto a survival narrative. The reply is that the coda is prepared from the first minute: the opening tests and questionnaire, the reset apartment, the Mimic that teaches suspicion of forms, January and December as competing selves, the Typhon neuromods and the turret threshold, the Phantoms' residual speech, and the Psychoscope's conversion of knowledge into capacity. Each acquires its full meaning only in retrospect. This is ludonarrative retroaction (Chapter VIII), not a twist.

The colonial objection. It may be objected that the coda's handshake, read through Macaulay and Bhabha, is a recruitment into service that the dissertation should condemn rather than emblematize. The reply is that Typhonic humanism holds the handshake's ambivalence rather than resolving it. The treaty is made under duress, and its value depends on whether it remains reciprocal and revocable—whether the bridge carries traffic in both directions.

The anthropocentric objection. It may be objected that the coda asks only the Typhon to change: why should the alien become human rather than humanity becoming more open to the alien? The reply is that the coda already contains the reciprocal movement. Morgan, within the simulation, may have become partly Typhon through Typhon neuromods; the examiners, by adopting the participant attitude toward an alien, transform their own humanity; and Le Guin's Osden (Chapter VI) shows the empath's path running into the alien rather than away from it. A bridge that carries traffic only one way is a pier.

Donna Haraway's later work supplies the vocabulary for this reciprocity. *When Species Meet* (2008) described companion species as beings that become what they are with one another rather than before the encounter, so that every meeting of species is a mutual shaping; *Staying with the Trouble* (2016) urged a tentacular thinking for a damaged planet and the making of kin across species lines. The Typhon are tentacular in form, and the coda's gesture, read through Haraway, is an attempt at kin-making under the worst conditions: on a ruined world, between a species that has lost and a species that has won, through a being that belongs fully to neither. Haraway's insistence that such kinship is made rather than given, and made in trouble rather than after it, is the posthumanist complement to Kafka's cage.

§ 10.9

Implications

For game studies, *Prey* grounds what may be called *forensic ludology*: the study of games as apparatuses that convert conduct into evidence and evidence into status, and of players as

subjects formed by the records they produce. The immersive simulation, read this way, is not merely a genre of systemic freedom but an anthropotechnic, a technology for the formation and adjudication of character.

For the philosophy of personhood, the dissertation proposes a forensic-mimetic account: personhood as a status instituted by reactive attitudes in response to a sustained, inwardly oriented mimetic practice. The account is substrate-neutral and relational, and it locates the problem of other minds not at the border of the species but at the center of every encounter.

For the study of speculative fiction, *Prey* exemplifies the post-Chaoskampf as a narrative form: a combat myth that ends in treaty, whose recurring figures are the cage, the tribunal, the made person, and the outstretched hand. The comparative archive assembled in Chapter IX suggests that the form has a long prehistory, from Calderón through Kafka and Čapek, and that *Prey* is among its most complete realizations.

For the ethics of artificial intelligence, the coda offers an allegory a contemporary reader cannot miss, though the analogy has limits that must be stated. Machine learning systems are formed by imitation of an archive of human writing—humanized, in Sloterdijk's terms, by letters—and evaluated by human judges for conduct aligned with human values. *Prey* dramatizes three features of that situation: that the trained conduct of a mimetic system cannot be distinguished from outside between genuine orientation and strategic performance; that the standing of the examiners is itself an ethical question; and that the relationship between examiners and examined may be the medium in which such questions are settled, if they are settled at all. The limits are as important as the parallels. The coda's creature is presented as conscious, and whether any current system is conscious is unresolved; the allegory illuminates the structure of the problem, not the answer. Typhonic humanism's contribution is to note that the question "is its empathy real?" has the same structure for every mind, human or not, and that inspection has never been the way human beings answered it for one another.

§ 10.10

Glossary of Terms

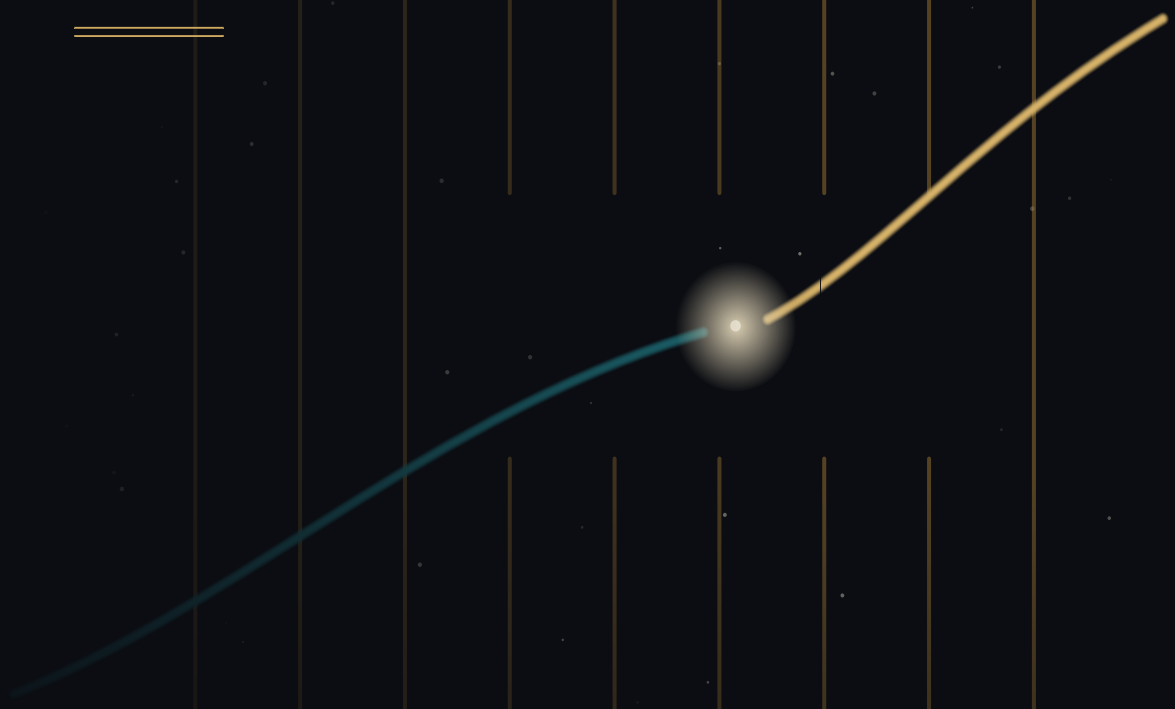
TABLE 10.1 **Glossary of terms**

TERM	DEFINITION	CHAPTERS
Xenomimesis	The acquisition of a form of life by an outsider through imitation under captivity and observation, such that the acquired form cannot in principle be distinguished from the native one	I, X

TERM	DEFINITION	CHAPTERS
Möbius of mimesis	Empathy and predation as two orientations of a single mimetic capacity, continuous without an edge	III, VI, X
Ephemeral fruit	The gift of finitude—forgetting, vulnerability, the single day—through which the monster is weakened into humanity	III, X
Forensic personhood	Personhood as a status instituted by judgment on a record of appropriated actions	IV, X
Forensic loop	The cycle of play, record, and verdict by which a game converts conduct into evidence	VIII, X
Ludonarrative retroaction	The re-description of all prior play, after the fact, as diegetic evidence	VIII, X
Pierides paradox	Whoever narrates mimicry is turned into a mimic	III, X
Talosian vulnerability	The invulnerable guardian's single point of failure: the vein and the eye	III, VII
Kinguic anthropogony	Humanity made from the substance of the defeated rebel and destined for service	III, VIII
Enemy simulation	A simulation run by a defeated civilization on its adversary, in the hope of producing an ally	V
Anti-Gnostic gnōsis	A revelation of alien origin offered so that the one who receives it may choose incarnation	V
Post-Chaoskampf	A combat myth that ends in treaty rather than slaying	III, X
Kletka condition	Humanity acquired in captivity as a way out rather than as freedom	IX, X
Typhonic humanism	A humanism without essence that locates humanity in a practiced, witnessed, revocable mimetic orientation toward the vulnerability of others	X

CONCLUSION

The Hand Across the Cage



Prey begins with a cup that is not a cup and ends with a person who is not the person. Between those two disclosures, this dissertation has argued, lies a complete philosophical myth: a theory of the human as a direction of imitation rather than a substance, of personhood as a status instituted between beings rather than a property discovered within one, and of play as the medium in which that status is rehearsed, recorded, and conferred. The coffee cup taught the player to doubt every form. The coda teaches that doubt about forms can never be resolved by inspection, because the form that matters most —the orientation of a mind toward others—is visible only in conduct, and conduct is visible only to those who have shared a world with the one who acts.

The myth's names were exact from the start. A crow met the Typhon, and in Ovid the god of reason hid from Typhon in a crow. A cage received them, and in Kafka a cage was where an ape decided to become human. A guardian named Talos fell, as Apollonius's bronze giant fell, not to force but to phantoms sent through the eye. And the monster named Typhon, whom Hesiod's Zeus thunderbolted into Tartarus, was tamed as Apollodorus's Fates tamed him: by being fed the fruits of a day. *Prey* takes the last of these episodes, which the myth narrates as a deception and a defeat, and asks whether the same event, narrated from the monster's side, might be a birth.

Pindar's line, which the first chapter set among its epigraphs, holds the answer in a grammatical ambiguity. *Skias onar anthrōpos*: a human being is a shadow's dream. The genitive can be read as the dream *about* a shadow, the human as something insubstantial; or as the dream a shadow *has*, the human as what a shadow dreams. Tradition has preferred the first reading, the lament of a creature of a day. *Prey* makes the second reading literal. Its Typhon are shadows—inky, faceless, smeared into darkness—and its protagonist was what one of them dreamed. The coda wakes the shadow. The dream does not end. The waking shadow finds itself still holding the dream it dreamed, and is asked whether it will go on dreaming it with its eyes open.

Pindar's next lines describe what makes the life of ephemeral creatures bearable: when a Zeus-given brightness comes, a shining light rests upon them, and their life is sweet. In *Prey*, the brightness is not Zeus-given. The sovereign has lost his world and his sinews are cut; no god guarantees the creature's dignity, as Pico's God guaranteed Adam's. Whatever light falls on the creature in the chair falls from the one who extends a hand—and from the creature itself, if it takes the hand, upon the one who offered it. The brightness that makes an ephemeral life sweet is, in Typhonic humanism, given across the cage, and only in both directions at once.

Calderón's Segismundo reasoned that whether his life was truth or dream, to do good was what mattered: if truth, for truth's sake; if dream, to win friends for when he woke. The Typhon-Morgan's friends, won in the dream, speak for it when it wakes. That is the coda's mercy and its terror. Its mercy is that nothing done well within the simulation was

lost. Its terror is that nothing done ill was lost either. The record survives the dream, and the dreamer must answer for it. This is the condition of every person, and the coda's achievement is to make a player feel it as their own condition rather than as a proposition about someone else's.

Kafka's Red Peter told the Academy that the first thing he learned was to give a handshake, because a handshake bespeaks frankness, and he hoped that the frank word might now be added to that first handshake. This dissertation has tried to supply the frank word that *Prey*'s handshake implies. It is this: there is no humanity that was not learned; no empathy that did not begin as imitation; no person who was not, at first, a creature taught in someone else's house to wear a form that was not yet its own. The difference between the monster and the person is not where they came from but what they do with the forms they have learned—whether they wear them to approach their prey unseen, or to be reached, at last, by another.

The station has fallen, and the studio that built it has closed. The coda remains, and every time the game is played it runs again. A shadow wakes in a chair, learns that the self it has lived was borrowed, and is offered a hand by someone who has every reason to fear it. The game does not tell the player what to do. It only ensures that whatever the player does will have been, all along, the answer to the oldest question myth knows how to ask of a monster—and the newest question a species can ask of itself.

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INDEX TERMS

Keywords

Prey (2017) · Arkane Studios · immersive simulation · game studies · philosophy of games · procedural rhetoric · ludonarrative retroaction · forensic ludology · xenomimesis · mimesis · mimicry · Roger Caillois · play theory · empathy · *Einfühlung* · mirror neurons · simulation theory of mind · intersubjectivity · phenomenology · Edith Stein · Maurice Merleau-Ponty · Emmanuel Levinas · personal identity · John Locke · Derek Parfit · Paul Ricoeur · quasi-memory · forensic personhood · reactive attitudes · P. F. Strawson · simulation hypothesis · Calderón de la Barca · *Chaoskampf* · comparative mythology · Typhon · Talos · Ovid · Apollodorus · Pindar · Franz Kafka · Philip K. Dick · Stanisław Lem · speculative fiction · posthumanism · transhumanism · anthropotechnics · Peter Sloterdijk · neuroethics · research ethics · colonial mimicry · necropolitics · alterity · Typhonic humanism · the ephemeral fruit



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